

Epistles

ΕΠΙΣΤΟΛΑΙ

Plato

translated by David Horan

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309a

EH: FIRST EPISTLE Plato to Dionysius: may you do well

309a

Although I spent so much time with you, administering your rule and being trusted more than anyone, you received the benefits while I endured the vexatious slanders. For I knew that people would not think I co-operated in enacting any of your more cruel deeds since I have, as my witnesses, all those who are involved in government along with you, many of whom I have assisted and saved from no small harm. And although I have often protected your city on my own authority, I was sent away with less respect than befits a beggar, banished by you, ordered to sail away having spent so much time with you. Hereafter, I shall consider my own interest, adopting a less human approach, while you, being the tyrant that you are, will dwell alone.

Πλάτων Διονυσίῳ εὖ πράττειν. διατρίψας ἐγὼ παρ' ὑμῖν χρόνον τοσοῦτον καὶ διοικῶν τὴν ὑμετέραν ἀρχὴν πεπιστευμένος πάντων μάλιστα, τὰς ὠφελίας ὑμῶν λαμβανόντων, τὰς διαβολὰς δυσχερεῖς οὓσας ὑπέμενον· ἤδη γὰρ ὅτι τῶν ὠμοτέρων οὐδὲν ἐμοῦ συνεθέλοντος ὑμῖν δόξει πεπραῆθαι· πάντες γὰρ οἱ συμπολιτευόμενοι μεθ' ὑμῶν ὑπάρχουσί μοι μάρτυρες, ὧν ἐγὼ πολλοῖς συνηγωνισάμην, ἀπολύσας αὐτοὺς οὐ σμικρὰς ζημίας. αὐτοκράτωρ δὲ πολλάκις τὴν ὑμετέραν πόλιν διαφυλάξας, ἀπεπέμφθην ἀτιμότερον ἢ πτωχὸν ὑμῶν ἀποστελλόντων προσήκει καὶ κελευόντων ἐκπλεῦσαι, τοσοῦτον παρ' ὑμῖν διατρίψαντα χρόνον. ἐγὼ μὲν οὖν περὶ ἐμαυτοῦ βουλευέσομαι τὸ λοιπὸν τρόπον ἀπανθρωπότερον, σὺ δὲ τοιοῦτος ὧν τύραννος οἰκήσεις μόνος. τὸ δὲ χρυσίον τὸ λαμπρόν,

309c

As for the glistening gold you gave me on my departure, Baccheius, the bearer of this letter, is returning it. For it was neither adequate to provide for my journey, nor beneficial for my life in general, and its provision reflects very badly on your reputation as the donor, and not much less upon mine as the recipient. That's why I have not accepted it. Of course, to receive or give such a sum makes no difference to you,

so now that you have it back, use it to serve another one of your associates just as you did in my case, for I have had enough of your services. And it is timely for me to quote Euripides, that should other misfortunes ever befall you, “You'll pray that such a man be by your side.” And I wish to remind you that most of the other tragedians, when they present a tyrant on stage being slain by someone, they have him cry out, “Bereft of friends, wretched, I perish.” But none of them portrays him as perishing for want of gold. The following lines too seem sensible to sensible people: It is not gold, though a shining rarity in mortals' hopeless life, nor gems nor silver couches, that brighten the eyes of men, nor broad and self-sufficient fields laden with the harvest, but the approving thought of upright men. Farewell, and please recognise how much advantage you have failed to obtain from us, so that you may behave better towards others.

ὅπερ ἔδωκας εἰς ἀποστολήν, ἄγει σοι Βακχεῖος ὁ τὴν ἐπιστολήν φέρων· οὔτε γὰρ ἐφόδιον ἐκεῖνό γ' ἦν ἱκανὸν οὔτε πρὸς τὸν ἄλλον βίον συμφέρον, ἀδοξίαν δὲ πλείστην τῷ διδόντι σοὶ παρασκευάζον, οὐ πολλῶ δὲ ἐλάττω κάμοι λαμβάνοντι, διόπερ οὐ λαμβάνω. σοὶ δ' οὐδὲν διαφέρει δῆλον ὅτι καὶ λαβεῖν καὶ δοῦναι τοσοῦτον, ὥστε κομισάμενος ἄλλον τινὰ τῶν ἐταίρων θεράπευσον ὥσπερ ἐμέ· κἀγὼ γὰρ ἱκανῶς ὑπὸ σοῦ τεθεράπευμαι. καί μοι τὸ τοῦ Εὐριπίδου κατὰ καιρὸν ἐστὶν εἰπεῖν, ὅτι σοὶ πραγμάτων ἄλλων ποτὲ συμπεσόντων—εὗξῃ τοιοῦτον ἄνδρα σοι παρεστάναι. ὑπομνήσαι δέ σε βούλομαι διότι καὶ τῶν ἄλλων τραγωδοποιῶν οἱ πλείστοι, ὅταν ὑπὸ τινος ἀποθνήσκοντα τύραννον εἰσάγωσιν, ἀναβοῶντα ποιοῦσιν— φίλων ἔρῃμος, ὧ τάλας, ἀπόλλυμαι· χρυσίου δὲ σπάνει ἀπολλύμενον οὐδεὶς πεποίηκεν. κἀκεῖνο δὲ τὸ ποίημα τοῖς νοῦν ἔχουσιν οὐ κακῶς ἔχειν δοκεῖ— οὐ χρυσὸς ἀγλαὸς σπανιώτατος ἐν θανατῶν δυσελπί- στω βίῳ, οὐδ' ἀδάμας οὐδ' ἀργύρου κλῖναι πρὸς ἄνθρωπον δοκιμαζόμεν' ἀστράπτει πρὸς ὄψεις· οὐδὲ γαίης εὐρυπέδου γόνιμοι βρίθοντες αὐτάρκεις γῦαι, ὥς ἀγαθῶν ἀνδρῶν ὁμοφράδμων νόησις. ἔρρωσο, καὶ γίγνωσκε τοσοῦτον ἡμῶν διημαρτηκῶς, ἵνα πρὸς τοὺς ἄλλους βέλτιον προσφέρῃ. Πλάτων Διονυσίῳ εὖ πράττειν· ἤκουσα Ἀρχεδήμου ὅτι σὺ ἡγῇ χρῆναι περὶ σοῦ

μὴ μόνον ἐμὲ ἡσυχίαν ἄγειν, ἀλλὰ καὶ τοὺς ἐμοὺς ἐπιτηδεῖους τοῦ φλαυρόν τι ποιεῖν ἢ λέγειν περὶ σέ· Δίωνα δὲ μόνον

310c

EH: SECOND EPISTLE Plato to Dionysius: may you do well

310c

I have heard from Archdemus that you think not only that I myself should say nothing about you, but that my friends too should neither do nor say anything bad concerning you. You made an exception in the case of Dion only, but your argument that Dion is an exception implies that I do not have control over my own friends. But what you should do in future, I think, if anyone reports anything of this sort about any of us, is to write to me and ask me about it. For I shall be neither reluctant nor ashamed to speak the truth.

ἐξαίρετον ποιῇ. οὗτος δὲ ὁ λόγος σημαίνει, τὸ Δίωνα ἐξαίρετον εἶναι, ὅτι οὐκ ἄρχω ἐγὼ τῶν ἐμῶν ἐπιτηδείων· εἰ γὰρ ἦρχον ἐγὼ οὕτω τῶν τε ἄλλων καὶ σοῦ καὶ Δίωνος, πλείω ἂν ἦν ἡμῖν τε πᾶσιν ἀγαθὰ τοῖς τε ἄλλοις Ἑλλησιν, ὥς ἐγὼ φημι. νῦν δὲ μέγας ἐγὼ εἰμι ἐμαυτὸν παρέχων τῷ ἐμῷ λόγῳ ἐπόμενον. καὶ ταῦτα λέγω ὥς οὐχ ὑγιές τι Κρατιστόλου καὶ Πολυξένου πρὸς σὲ εἰρηκότων, ὧν φασί

310d

As for yourself and myself and our dealings with one another: both of us are, in a sense, known to every Greek. And our relationship is no secret. Why am I saying this now? It is natural that wisdom and great power combine somehow, and they constantly pursue and seek one another. For instance, whenever people talk about Hiero, or Pausanias of Sparta, they love to bring in their association with Simonides and what he did and said to them. And they are in the habit of celebrating Periander of Corinth and Thales of Miletus together, Pericles and Anaxagoras too, and indeed Croesus and Solon, both wise, with the powerful Cyrus. Then, the poets too, imitating these relationships, bring together Creon with Tiresias, Polyeidus with Minos, Agamemnon with Nestor, and Odysseus with Palamedes.

λέγειν τὸν ἕτερον ὅτι ἀκούοι Ὀλυμπίασι πολλῶν τινων τῶν μετ' ἐμοῦ σε κακηγορούντων. ἴσως γὰρ ὀξύτερον ἐμοῦ ἀκούει· ἐγὼ μὲν γὰρ οὐκ ἤκουσα. χρὴ δέ, ὥς ἐμοὶ δοκεῖ, οὕτωςί σε ποιεῖν τοῦ λοιποῦ, ὅταν τι τοιοῦτον λέγῃ τις περὶ ἡμῶν τινος, γράμματα πέμψαντα ἐμὲ ἐρέσθαι· ἐγὼ γὰρ τάληθῃ λέγειν οὔτε ὀκνήσω οὔτε αἰσχυνοῦμαι. ἐμοὶ δὲ δὴ καὶ σοὶ τὰ πρὸς ἀλλήλους οὕτωςί τυγχάνει ἔχοντα· οὔτε αὐτοὶ ἂν ἀγνωτές ἐσμεν οὐδενὶ Ἑλλήνων ὥς ἔπος εἰπεῖν, οὔτε ἡ συνουσία ἡμῶν σιγᾶται. μὴ λανθανέτω δέ σε ὅτι οὐδ' εἰς τὸν ἔπειτα χρόνον σιγηθήσεται· τοιοῦτοι οἱ παραδεδεγμένοι εἰσὶν αὐτήν, ἅτε οὐκ ὀλίγην γεγεννημένην οὐδ' ἡρέμα. τί οὖν δὴ λέγω νυνί; ἐρῶ ἄνωθεν ἀρξάμενος. πέφυκε συνιέναι εἰς ταὐτὸν φρόνησίς τε καὶ δύναμις μεγάλη, καὶ ταῦτ' ἄλληλα ἀεὶ διώκει καὶ ζητεῖ καὶ συγγίγνεται· ἔπειτα καὶ οἱ ἄνθρωποι χαίρουσιν περὶ τούτων αὐτοῖ τε διαλεγόμενοι καὶ ἄλλων ἀκούοντες ἔν τε ἰδίαις συνουσίαις καὶ

311a

I am saying all this because I wish to demonstrate that when we both die, the stories told about us will not be silenced, and so we need to be careful about them. Now, in our case, it is still possible, God willing, if anything improper has been done in the course of our relationship heretofore, to correct this in word and in deed. For I maintain that if we are reasonable, true philosophy will be better regarded and better spoken of, but if we are corrupt, that will have the opposite effect.

ἐν ταῖς ποιήσεσιν. οἷον καὶ περὶ Ἰέρωνος ὅταν διαλέγωνται ἄνθρωποι καὶ Πausανίου τοῦ Λακεδαιμονίου, χαίρουσι τὴν Σιμωνίδου συνουσίαν παραφέροντες, ἃ τε ἔπραξεν καὶ εἶπεν πρὸς αὐτούς· καὶ Περίανδρον τὸν Κορίνθιον καὶ Θαλῆν τὸν Μιλήσιον ὑμνεῖν εἰώθασιν ἅμα, καὶ Περικλέα καὶ Ἀναξαγόραν, καὶ Κροῖσον αὖ καὶ Σόλωνα ὥς σοφοὺς καὶ Κῦρον ὥς δυνάστην. καὶ δὴ ταῦτα μιμούμενοι οἱ ποιηταὶ Κρέοντα μὲν καὶ Τειρεσίαν συνάγουσιν, Πολύειδον δὲ καὶ Μίνω, Ἀγαμέμνονα δὲ καὶ Νέστορα καὶ Ὀδυσσέα καὶ Παλαμήδη—ὥς δ' ἐμοὶ δοκεῖ, καὶ Προμηθέα Διὶ ταύτῃ πῃ συνῆγον οἱ πρῶτοι ἄνθρωποι—τούτων δὲ τοὺς μὲν εἰς διαφοράν, τοὺς δ' εἰς φιλίαν ἀλλήλοις ἰόντας, τοὺς δὲ τοτὲ μὲν εἰς φιλίαν, τοτὲ δ' εἰς διαφοράν, καὶ τὰ μὲν ὁμονοοῦντας, τὰ δὲ

διαφερομένους ἄδουσι. πάντα δὴ ταῦτα λέγω τόδε βουλόμενος ἐνδείξασθαι, ὅτι οὐκ, ἐπειδὴν ἡμεῖς τελευτήσωμεν, καὶ οἱ λόγοι οἱ περὶ ἡμῶν αὐτῶν σεσιγήσονται· ὥστ' ἐπιμελητέον αὐτῶν ἐστίν. ἀνάγκη γάρ, ὥς ἔοικε, μέλειν ἡμῖν καὶ τοῦ ἔπειτα χρόνου, ἐπειδὴ καὶ τυγχάνουσιν κατὰ τινα φύσιν οἱ μὲν ἀνδραποδωδέστατοι οὐδὲν φροντίζοντες αὐτοῦ, οἱ δ' ἐπιεικέστατοι πᾶν ποιοῦντες ὅπως ἂν εἰς τὸν ἔπειτα χρόνον εὖ ἀκούσωσιν. ὃ δὴ καὶ ἐγὼ τεκμήριον ποιοῦμαι ὅτι ἔστιν τις αἴσθησις τοῖς τεθνεῶσιν τῶν ἐνθάδε· αἱ γὰρ βέλτισται

311d

Now, I shall explain how we should proceed and where justice lies. I arrived in Sicily with the reputation of being the most distinguished of those engaged in philosophy, and when I got to Syracuse I wanted to involve you in my cause so that I might see philosophy honoured even by the general public. But the outcome was not propitious for me. The explanation I give is that you appeared not to trust me very much and wanted to get rid of me and send for others instead, and out of mistrust, to find out what my business was. With that there was a general clamour declaring that you despised me and had more important matters to attend to.

ψυχὰι μαντεύονται ταῦτα οὕτως ἔχειν, αἱ δὲ μοχθηρόταται οὐ φασι, κυριώτερα δὲ τὰ τῶν θείων ἀνδρῶν μαντεύματα ἢ τὰ τῶν μῆ. οἶμαι δ' ἔγωγε τοῖς ἔμπροσθεν, περὶ ὧν λέγω, εἰ ἐξείη αὐτοῖς ἐπανορθώσασθαι τὰς αὐτῶν συνουσίας, πάνυ ἂν σπουδάσαι ὥστε βελτίω λέγεσθαι περὶ αὐτῶν ἢ νῦν. τοῦτο οὖν ἡμῖν ἔτι, σὺν θεῷ εἰπεῖν, ἔξεστιν, εἴ τι ἄρα μὴ καλῶς πέπρακται κατὰ τὴν ἔμπροσθεν συνουσίαν, ἐπανορθώσασθαι καὶ ἔργῳ καὶ λόγῳ· περὶ γὰρ φιλοσοφίαν φημὶ ἐγὼ τὴν ἀληθινήν δόξαν ἔσεσθαι καὶ λόγον ἡμῶν μὲν ὄντων ἐπιεικῶν βελτίω, φαύλων δέ, τούναντίον. καίτοι περὶ τούτου ἡμεῖς ἐπιμελούμενοι οὐδὲν ἂν εὐσεβέστερον πράττοιμεν, οὐδ' ἀμελοῦντες ἀσεβέστερον. ὥς δὴ δεῖ γίγνεσθαι, καὶ τὸ δίκαιον ἢ ἔχει, ἐγὼ φράσω. ἦλθον ἐγὼ εἰς Σικελίαν δόξαν ἔχων πολὺ τῶν ἐν φιλοσοφίᾳ διαφέρειν, βουλόμενος δὲ ἐλθὼν εἰς Συρακούσας συμμάρτυρα λαβεῖν σέ, ἵνα μοι τιμῶτο φιλοσοφία καὶ παρὰ τῷ πλήθει. τοῦτο δ' οὐκ εὐαγές μοι ἀπέβη. τὸ δ' αἴτιον οὐ λέγω

ὅπερ ἂν πολλοὶ εἴποιεν, ἀλλ' ὅτι ἐφαίνου οὐ πάνυ ἐμοὶ πιστεύειν σύ, ἀλλ' ἐμὲ μὲν πως ἀποπέμψασθαι ἐθέλεις, ἑτέρους δὲ μεταπέμψασθαι, καὶ ζητεῖν τὸ πρᾶγμα τί τὸ ἐμόν ἐστιν, ἀπιστῶν, ὥς ἐμοὶ δοκεῖ καὶ οἱ ἐπὶ τούτοις βοῶντες πολλοὶ ἦσαν, λέγοντες ὥς σὺ ἐμοῦ μὲν

312b

What, then, is the right thing to do next? If you have total contempt for philosophy, then bid it farewell, and if you have heard better instruction than mine from elsewhere, or have discovered better yourself, then respect those discoveries. But if my teachings are pleasing to you, you should also have special respect for me. So now, as in the beginning, you should take the lead and I shall follow. For if I am respected by you I shall have respect for you, but if I am not respected, I shall keep quiet. To sum up then, if you show respect, it is a credit to us both, whereas if I show respect, it is a reproach to us both.

καταπεφρόνηκας, ἄλλα δ' ἐσπούδακας. ταῦτα δὴ διαβεβόηται. ὃ δὴ μετὰ ταῦτα δίκαιόν ἐστι ποιεῖν, ἄκουε, ἵνα σοι καὶ ἀποκρίνωμαι ὃ σὺ ἐρωτᾷς, πῶς χρῆ ἔχειν ἐμὲ καὶ σὲ πρὸς ἀλλήλους. εἰ μὲν ὅλως φιλοσοφίας καταπεφρόνηκας, ἔαν χαίρειν, εἰ δὲ παρ' ἑτέρου ἀκήκοας ἢ αὐτὸς βελτίονα ἡύρηκας τῶν παρ' ἐμοί, ἐκεῖνα τίμα· εἰ δ' ἄρα τὰ παρ' ἡμῶν σοι ἀρέσκει, τιμητέον καὶ ἐμὲ μάλιστα. νῦν οὖν, ὥσπερ καὶ ἐξ ἀρχῆς, σὺ καθηγοῦ, ἔψομαι δὲ ἐγώ· τιμώμενος γὰρ ὑπὸ σοῦ τιμήσω σέ, μὴ τιμώμενος δὲ ἡσυχίαν ἔξω. ἔτι δὲ σὺ μὲν ἐμὲ τιμῶν καὶ τούτου καθηγούμενος φιλοσοφίαν δόξεις τιμᾶν, καὶ αὐτὸ τοῦτο, ὅτι διεσκόπεις καὶ ἄλλους, πρὸς πολλῶν εὐδοξίαν σοι οἴσει ὥς φιλοσόφῳ ὄντι. ἐγὼ δὲ σὲ τιμῶν μὴ τιμῶντα πλοῦτον δόξω θαυμάζειν τε καὶ διώκειν, τοῦτο δ' ἴσμεν ὅτι παρὰ πᾶσιν ὄνομα οὐ καλὸν ἔχει· ὥς δ' ἐν κεφαλαίῳ εἶπεῖν, σοῦ μὲν τιμῶντος ἀμφοτέροις κόσμος,

312d

The sphere is not correct, as Archedemus will explain when he arrives. And he really needs to explain the other matter, more venerable and divine than the sphere, which was perplexing you when you dispatched him. Now, it must be related to you in riddles so that if anything happens to the writing tablet in the recesses of sea or land,

whoever reads it will not understand it. It says that everything is around the King of All, and everything is for the sake of that king, the cause of all that is good. Around the second are the second things, while the third things are around the third. The human soul hungers to learn about what sort of things these are by looking to the things that are kindred to itself, none of which are adequate. This question, dear son of Dionysius and Doris, or rather, the travail about it engendered in the soul, is responsible for all difficulties. And unless a person frees himself from this he shall never really encounter the truth.

ἐμοῦ δὲ ὄνειδος ἀμφοῖν. περὶ μὲν οὖν τούτων ταῦτα. τὸ δὲ σφαιρίον οὐκ ὀρθῶς ἔχει· δηλώσει δέ σοι Ἀρχέδημος, ἐπειδὴν ἔλθῃ. καὶ δὴ καὶ περὶ τοῦδε, ὃ δὴ τούτου τιμιώτερόν τ' ἐστὶν καὶ θειότερον, καὶ μάλα σφόδρ' αὐτῷ δηλωτέον, ὑπὲρ οὗ σὺ πέπομφας ἀπορούμενος. φῆς γὰρ δὴ κατὰ τὸν ἐκείνου λόγον, οὐχ ἱκανῶς ἀποδεδεῖχθαί σοι περὶ τῆς τοῦ πρώτου φύσεως. φραστέον δὴ σοι δι' αἰνιγμῶν, ἵν' ἂν τι ἢ δέλτος ἢ πόντου ἢ γῆς ἐν πτυχαῖς πάθῃ, ὃ ἀναγνοὺς μὴ γνῶ. ὥδε γὰρ ἔχει. περὶ τὸν πάντων βασιλέα πάντ' ἐστὶ καὶ ἐκείνου ἔνεκα πάντα, καὶ ἐκεῖνο αἴτιον ἀπάντων τῶν καλῶν· δεύτερον δὲ πέρι τὰ δεύτερα, καὶ τρίτον πέρι τὰ τρίτα. ἢ οὖν ἀνθρωπίνη ψυχὴ περὶ αὐτὰ ὀρέγεται μαθεῖν ποῖ' ἅττα ἐστίν, βλέπουσα εἰς τὰ αὐτῆς συγγενῆ, ὧν οὐδὲν ἱκανῶς ἔχει. τοῦ δὴ βασιλέως πέρι καὶ ὧν εἶπον, οὐδὲν ἐστὶν τοιοῦτον—τὸ δὴ μετὰ τοῦτο ἢ ψυχὴ φησιν—ἀλλὰ ποῖόν τι μήν; τοῦτ' ἐστίν, ὃ παῖ Διονυσίου καὶ Δωρίδος, τὸ ἐρώτημα ὃ πάντων αἰτίον ἐστὶν κακῶν, μᾶλλον δὲ ἢ περὶ τούτου ὥδις ἐν τῇ ψυχῇ ἐγγιγνομένη, ἣν εἰ μή τις ἐξαيرهθήσεται, τῆς ἀληθείας ὄντως οὐ μή ποτε τύχῃ. σὺ δὲ τοῦτο πρὸς ἐμὲ ἐν τῷ κήπῳ ὑπὸ ταῖς δάφναις αὐτὸς ἔφησθα ἐννενοηκέναι

313b

But you told me in the garden under the laurels that you had thought of this yourself and that it was your discovery, and I replied that if this proved to be the case, you would be sparing me from lengthy discussions. Since although you think you are in possession of unassailable proofs, you have not established them securely, and so for

you it flits around about the appearance, now in one direction, now in another. But the reality is not like this.

καὶ εἶναι σὸν εὐρύημα· καὶ ἐγὼ εἶπον ὅτι τοῦτο εἰ φαίνοιτό σοι οὕτως ἔχειν, πολλῶν ἂν εἴης λόγων ἐμὲ ἀπολελυκώς. οὐ μὴν ἄλλω γέ ποτ' ἔφην ἐντετυχηκέναι τοῦθ' ἡύρηκότι, ἀλλὰ ἡ πολλή μοι πραγματεία περὶ τοῦτ' εἴη σὺ δὲ ἴσως μὲν ἀκούσας του, τάχα δ' ἂν θείᾳ μοίρᾳ κατὰ τοῦθ' ὀρμήσας, ἔπειτα αὐτοῦ τὰς ἀποδείξεις ὥς ἔχων βεβαίως οὐ κατέδησας, ἀλλ' ἄττει σοι τοτὲ μὲν οὕτως, τοτὲ δὲ ἄλλως περὶ τὸ φανταζόμενον, τὸ δὲ οὐδέν ἐστιν τοιοῦτον. καὶ τοῦτο οὐ σοὶ μόνῳ γέγονεν, ἀλλ' εὖ ἴσθι μηδένα πώποτε μου τὸ πρῶτον ἀκούσαντα ἔχειν ἄλλως πως ἢ οὕτως κατ' ἀρχάς, καὶ ὁ μὲν πλείω ἔχων πράγματα, ὁ δὲ ἐλάττω, μόγις ἀπαλλάττονται, σχεδὸν δὲ οὐδεὶς ὀλίγα. τούτων δὴ γεγονότων καὶ ἐχόντων οὕτω, σχεδὸν κατὰ τὴν ἐμὴν δόξαν ἡύρηκαμεν ὃ σὺ ἐπέστειλας, ὅπως δεῖ πρὸς ἀλλήλους ἡμᾶς ἔχειν. ἐπεὶ γὰρ βασανίζεις αὐτὰ συγγιγνόμενός τε ἄλλοις καὶ παραθεώμενος

313d

Now that all this has happened, we have more or less found the answer to the question in your letter as to how we should behave towards one another. For since you have tested my arguments by associating with others and comparing my arguments to theirs, if your test is a true one they shall begin to grow within you, and you shall be familiar with them and with us. You were right in sending Archedemus, and if you do this two or three times, and sufficiently test the answers sent from me, I would be surprised if your present difficulties did not take on a very different aspect than now.

παρὰ τὰ τῶν ἄλλων καὶ αὐτὰ καθ' αὐτά, νῦν σοι ταῦτά τε, εἰ ἀληθὴς ἡ βάσανος, προσφύσεται, καὶ οἰκεῖος τούτοις τε καὶ ἡμῖν ἔσῃ. πῶς οὖν αὐτά τ' ἔσται καὶ πάντα ἃ εἰρήκαμεν; τὸν Ἀρχέδημον νῦν τε ὀρθῶς ἐποίησας πέμψας, καὶ τὸ λοιπόν, ἐπειδὴν ἔλθῃ πρὸς σέ καὶ ἀπαγγέλῃ τὰ παρ' ἐμοῦ, μετὰ ταῦτα ἴσως ἄλλαι σε ἀπορίαι λήφονται. πέμψεις οὖν αὖθις, ἂν ὀρθῶς βουλευῇ, παρ' ἐμὲ τὸν Ἀρχέδημον, ὁ δ' ἐμπορευσάμενος ἥξει πάλιν· καὶ τοῦτο ἔὰν δις ἢ τρίς ποιήσης καὶ

βασανίσης τὰ παρ' ἐμοῦ πεμφθέντα ἱκανῶς, θαυμάζοιμ' ἂν εἰ μὴ τὰ νῦν ἀπορούμενα πολὺ σοι διοίσει ἢ νῦν. θαρροῦντες οὖν ποιεῖτε οὕτως· οὐ μὴ γάρ ποτε τῆς ἐμπορίας ταύτης οὔτε σὺ στείλῃς οὔτε Ἀρχέδημος ἐμπορεύσεται καλλίω

314a

However, you must be careful that these communications are never disclosed to uneducated folk, for to most people hardly any words sound more laughable than these, while on the other hand, to those with a natural affinity, none are more wonderfully inspiring. And being frequently repeated and constantly heard over many years, they are with much effort gradually rendered as pure as gold. There are people, many of them, who have heard these words and are now at a point where they say that what had once seemed utterly unbelievable to them now appears most credible and obvious. The greatest safeguard is to avoid writing and to learn by heart, for it is inevitable that what is written down will be disclosed. That is why I have never yet written about these matters, nor is there a written work of Plato, nor will there ever be, and those writings that are now said to be mine belong to a Socrates become fair and young. Farewell and believe. And now, first read this letter many times, then commit it to the flames.

καὶ θεοφιλεστέραν. εὐλαβοῦ μέντοι μὴ ποτε ἐκπέσῃ ταῦτα εἰς ἀνθρώπους ἀπαιδεύτους· σχεδὸν γάρ, ὡς ἐμοὶ δοκεῖ, οὐκ ἔστιν τούτων πρὸς τοὺς πολλοὺς καταγελαστότερα ἀκούσματα, οὐδ' αὖ πρὸς τοὺς εὐφυεῖς θαυμαστότερα τε καὶ ἐνθουσιαστικώτερα. πολλὰκις δὲ λεγόμενα καὶ ἀεὶ ἀκούόμενα καὶ πολλὰ ἔτη, μόγις ὥσπερ χρυσὸς ἐκκαθαίρεται μετὰ πολλῆς πραγματείας. ὃ δὲ θαυμαστὸν αὐτοῦ γέγονεν, ἄκουσον. εἰσὶν γὰρ ἄνθρωποι ταῦτα ἀκηκοότες καὶ πλείους, δυνατοὶ μὲν μαθεῖν, δυνατοὶ δὲ μνημονεῦσαι καὶ βασανίσαντες πάντῃ πάντως κρῖναι, γέροντες ἤδη καὶ οὐκ ἐλάττω τριάκοντα ἐτῶν ἀκηκοότες, οἱ νῦν ἄρτι σφίσι φασὶν τὰ μὲν τότε ἀπιστότατα δόξαντα εἶναι νῦν πιστότατα καὶ ἐναργέστατα φαίνεσθαι, ἃ δὲ τότε πιστότατα, νῦν τοῦναντίον. πρὸς ταῦτ' οὖν σκοπῶν εὐλαβοῦ μὴ ποτέ σοι μεταμελήσῃ τῶν νῦν ἀναξίως ἐκπεσόντων. μεγίστη δὲ φυλακὴ τὸ μὴ

γράφειν ἀλλ' ἐκμανθάνειν· οὐ γὰρ ἔστιν τὰ γραφέντα μὴ οὐκ ἐκπεσεῖν. διὰ ταῦτα οὐδὲν πώποτ' ἐγὼ περὶ τούτων γέγραφα, οὐδ' ἔστιν σύγγραμμα Πλάτωνος οὐδὲν οὐδ' ἔσται, τὰ δὲ νῦν λεγόμενα Σωκράτους ἐστὶν καλοῦ καὶ νέου γεγονότος. ἔρρωσο καὶ πείθου, καὶ τὴν ἐπιστολὴν ταύτην νῦν πρῶτον πολλάκις ἀναγνούς κατακάουσον. ταῦτα μὲν ταύτῃ. περὶ δὲ Πολυξένου ἐθαύμασας ὅτι

314d

Enough of this. As for Polyxenus, you were surprised that I sent him to you, but I give the same report now as in the past about Lycrophron and the others who are with you. When it comes to dialogue you are far superior to them by nature and in your method of argument. Indeed, it seems to me that you treat them and reward them in a measured way. If you have use for Phylition, employ him yourself by all means, but if possible please send him to Speusippus and let him employ the man. Speusippus himself asks you to do this too. You did well to release that man from the quarries. And the truth deserves to be spoken about Lysicleides, for he is the only Sicilian who, on arriving in Athens, did not misrepresent the relationship between the two of us. He continues, rather, to speak well and to find something good to say about what transpired.

πέμψαιμί σοι· ἐγὼ δὲ καὶ περὶ Λυκόφρονος καὶ τῶν ἄλλων τῶν παρὰ σοὶ ὄντων λέγω καὶ πάλαι καὶ νῦν τὸν αὐτὸν λόγον, ὅτι πρὸς τὸ διαλεχθῆναι καὶ φύσει καὶ τῇ μεθόδῳ τῶν λόγων πάμπλου διαφέρεις αὐτῶν, καὶ οὐδεὶς αὐτῶν ἐκὼν ἐξελέγχεται, ὥς τινες ὑπολαμβάνουσιν, ἀλλ' ἄκοντες, καὶ δοκεῖς μέντοι πάνυ μετρίως κεχρησθῆαι τε αὐτοῖς καὶ δεδωρῆσθαι. ταῦτα μὲν περὶ τούτων, πολλὰ ὡς περὶ τοιούτων· Φιλιστίωνι δέ, εἰ μὲν αὐτὸς χρῆ, σφόδρα χρῶ, εἰ δὲ οἶόν τε, Σπευσίππῳ χρῆσον καὶ ἀπόπεμψον. δεῖται δὲ σοῦ καὶ Σπεύσιππος· ὑπέσχετο δέ μοι καὶ Φιλιστίων, εἰ σὺ ἀφείης αὐτόν, ἥξειν προθύμως Ἀθήναζε. τὸν ἐκ τῶν λατομιῶν εὖ ἐποίησας ἀφείς, ἐλαφρὰ δὲ ἡ δέησις καὶ περὶ τῶν οἰκετῶν αὐτοῦ καὶ περὶ Ἠγησίππου τοῦ Ἀρίστωνος· ἐπέστειλας γάρ μοι, ἂν τις ἀδικῇ ἢ τοῦτον ἢ ἐκείνους καὶ σὺ αἴσθῃ, μὴ ἐπιτρέψειν. καὶ περὶ Λυσικλείδου τάληθές εἶπεῖν ἄξιον· μόνος γὰρ τῶν ἐκ Σικελίας Ἀθήναζε

ἀφικομένων οὐδὲν μετεβάλετο περὶ τῆς σῆς καὶ ἐμῆς συνουσίας, ἀλλ’ αἰεὶ τι ἀγαθὸν καὶ ἐπὶ τὰ βελτίω λέγων περὶ τῶν γεγονότων διατελεῖ. Πλάτων Διονυσίῳ χαίρειν ἐπιστείλας ἄρ’ ὀρθῶς ἂν

315b

EH: THIRD EPISTLE Plato to Dionysius: may you have joy

315b

Having written thus, may I, perhaps, have hit upon the best mode of address? Or might it be better to follow my usual practice and write “may you do well”, which is the greeting I habitually use in letters to friends? You yourself, of course, addressed the god at Delphi with this fawning utterance, writing, “I wish you joy and that you may preserve a pleasant tyrant’s life,” whereas I would not greet any human, or indeed a god, by calling upon them to do this. In the case of gods, my injunction would run contrary to their nature, for the divine is situated at a far remove from pleasure and pain. And in the case of humanity, pleasure and pain are for the most part harmful, engendering dullness, forgetfulness, folly and arrogance in the soul.

τυγχάνοιμι τῆς βελτίστης προσήσεως; ἢ μᾶλλον κατὰ τὴν ἐμὴν συνήθειαν γράφων εὖ πράττειν, ὥσπερ εἴωθα ἐν ταῖς ἐπιστολαῖς τοὺς φίλους προσαγορεύειν; σὺ μὲν γὰρ δὴ καὶ τὸν θεόν, ὡς ἡγγειλαν οἱ τότε θεωροῦντες, προσεῖπες ἐν Δελφοῖς αὐτῷ τούτῳ θωπεύσας τῷ ῥήματι, καὶ γέγραφας, ὡς φασί, χαῖρε καὶ ἡδόμενον βίοτον διάσωζε τυράννου· ἐγὼ δὲ οὐδὲ ἀνθρώπῳ κλήσει, μήτι δὴ θεῷ, παρακελευσαίμην ἂν δρᾶν τοῦτο, θεῷ μὲν, ὅτι παρὰ φύσιν προστάττοιμ’ ἂν, πόρρω γὰρ ἡδονῆς ἴδρυται καὶ λύπης τὸ θεῖον, ἀνθρώπῳ δέ, ὅτι τὰ πολλὰ βλάβην ἡδονῇ καὶ λύπῃ γεννᾷ, δυσμάθειαν καὶ λήθην καὶ ἀφροσύνην καὶ ὕβριν τίκτουσα ἐν τῇ ψυχῇ. καὶ ταῦτα μὲν οὕτως εἰρήσθω παρ’ ἐμοῦ περὶ τῆς προσήσεως· σὺ δ’ ἀναγνοὺς αὐτά, ὅπῃ βούλει δέξασθαι, ταύτῃ δέχου. φασὶν δ’ οὐκ ὀλίγοι λέγειν σε πρὸς τινὰς τῶν παρὰ σέ

315d

I am informed, by no small number of people, that you told some of the ambassadors in your circle that I once overheard you saying that you

were going to colonise the Greek cities in Sicily, and lighten the burden of the Syracusans by changing the rulership to kingship instead of tyranny. But according to you, I prevented you from doing all this at the time, whereas I am now instructing Dion to enact these very measures, thus using your own ideas to take your rulership away from you. But you do me an injustice when you speak contrary to the facts, for I have been slandered enough by Philistides and many others. But you yourself know full well that I willingly co-operated with you on a few of your political measures in the beginning when I thought this might do some good.

πρεσβευόντων ὡς ἄρα σοῦ ποτε λέγοντος ἀκούσας ἐγὼ μέλλοντος τάς τε Ἑλληνίδας πόλεις ἐν Σικελίᾳ οἰκίζειν καὶ Συρακουσίους ἐπικουφίσαι, τὴν ἀρχὴν ἀντὶ τυραννίδος εἰς βασιλείαν μεταστήσαντα, ταῦτ' ἄρα σὲ μὲν τότε διεκώλυσα, ὡς σὺ φῆς, σοῦ σφόδρα προθυμουμένου, νῦν δὲ Δίωνα διδάσκειμι δρᾶν αὐτὰ ταῦτα, καὶ τοῖς διανοήμασιν τοῖς σοῖς τὴν σὴν ἀρχὴν ἀφαιρούμεθά σε. σὺ δ' εἰ μὲν τι διὰ τοὺς λόγους τούτους ὠφελῇ, γινώσκεις αὐτός, ἀδικεῖς δ' οὖν ἐμὲ τάναντία τῶν γενομένων λέγων. ἄδην γὰρ ὑπὸ Φιλιστίδου καὶ ἄλλων πολλῶν πρὸς τοὺς μισθοφόρους καὶ εἰς τὸ Συρακουσίων πλῆθος διεβλήθην διὰ τὸ μένειν ἐν ἀκροπόλει, τοὺς δ' ἔξωθεν, εἴ τι γίγνοιτο ἀμάρτημα, πᾶν εἰς ἐμὲ τρέπειν, σὲ φάσκοντας πάντα ἐμοὶ πεῖθεσθαι. σὺ δ' αὐτὸς οἶσθα σαφέστατα τῶν πολιτικῶν ἐμὲ σοὶ κοινῇ πραγματευσάμενον ἐκόντα ὀλίγα δὴ κατ' ἀρχάς, ὅτε τι πλέον ποιεῖν ἂν ᾔσθην, ἄλλα τε βραχέα ἅττα καὶ τὰ περὶ τῶν νόμων προοίμια σπουδάσαντα μετρίως, χωρὶς ὧν σὺ προσέγραψας ἢ τις ἕτερος· ἀκούω γὰρ ὕστερον ὑμῶν τινὰς αὐτὰ διασκευρεῖν, δηλὰ μὴν ἐκάτερα ἔσται τοῖς τὸ ἐμὸν ἦθος δυναμένοις κρίνειν. ἀλλ' οὖν, ὅπερ ἀρτίως εἶπον, οὐ διαβολῆς προσδέομαι πρὸς τε Συρακουσίους καὶ εἰ δὴ τινὰς ἐτέρους πείθεις λέγων αὐτά, ἀλλὰ πολὺ μᾶλλον ἀπολογίας πρὸς τε τὴν προτέραν γενομένην διαβολὴν καὶ τὴν νῦν μετ' ἐκείνην μεῖζω φουομένην καὶ σφοδροτέραν. πρὸς δύο δὴ μοι διττὰς ἀναγκαῖον ποιήσασθαι τὰς ἀπολογίας, πρῶτον μὲν ὡς εἰκότως σοι ἔφυγον κοινωνεῖν περὶ τὰ τῆς πόλεως πράγματα, τὸ δὲ δεύτερον ὡς

οὐκ ἐμὴν ταύτην εἵρηκας συμβουλήν οὐδὲ διακώλυσιν, μέλλοντί σοι κατοικίσειν Ἑλληνίδας

316c

I came to Syracuse at the behest of yourself and Dion, who was a long-standing, tried and trusted friend of mine. He was middle-aged and settled, two prerequisites for those of even a little intelligence when they are about to give advice on affairs as important as yours at the time. You, on the other hand, were very young and very inexperienced in those matters in which you needed experience. Afterwards, some person or some god or some random event, with your involvement, expelled Dion and you alone remained. Do you think I would associate with you politically when, having lost my wise associate, I beheld only the unwise one left behind, surrounded by lots of degenerate men, not ruling but thinking he was ruling? I bade farewell to political affairs thereafter, being wary of the slanders and jealousies, and I endeavoured by all means to make the two of you the best of friends.

πόλεις ἐμποδὼν ἐμὲ γεγενῆσθαι. τὴν οὖν ἀρχὴν ὧν εἶπον περὶ προτέρων ἄκουε πρότερον. ἦλθον καλούμενος εἰς Συρακούσας ὑπὸ τε σοῦ καὶ Δίωνος, τοῦ μὲν δεδοκιμασμένου παρ' ἐμοί καὶ ξένου πάλαι γεγονότος, ἐν ἡλικίᾳ δὲ ὄντος μέσῃ τε καὶ καθεστηκυῖα, ὧν δὴ παντάπασιν χρεῖα τοῖς νοῦν καὶ σμικρὸν κεκτημένοις, μέλλουσιν περὶ τοσούτων ὅσα ἦν τότε τὰ σὰ βουλευέσθαι, σοῦ δὲ ὄντος μὲν σφόδρα νέου, πολλῆς δὲ ἀπειρίας οὔσης περὶ σὲ τούτων ὧν ἔμπειρον ἔδει γεγονέναι, καὶ σφόδρα ἀγνώτος ἐμοί. τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο εἶτ' ἄνθρωπος εἶτε θεὸς εἶτε τύχη τις μετὰ σοῦ Δίωνα ἐξέβαλεν, καὶ ἐλείφθης μόνος. ἄρ' οὖν οἶμι μοι τότε πολιτικῶν εἶναι κοινωνίαν πρὸς σέ, τὸν μὲν ἔμφονα κοινωνὸν ἀπολωλεκότι, τὸν δὲ ἄφρονα ὀρώντι μετὰ πονηρῶν καὶ πολλῶν ἀνθρώπων καταλειμμένον, οὐκ ἄρχοντα, οἰόμενον δ' ἄρχειν, ὑπὸ δὲ τοιούτων ἀνθρώπων ἀρχόμενον; ἐν οἷς τί χρῆν ποιεῖν ἐμέ; μῶν οὐχ ὅπερ ἐποιοῦν ἀναγκαῖον, ἐκ τῶν λοιπῶν τὰ μὲν πολιτικὰ χαίρειν ἔαν, εὐλαβούμενον τὰς ἐκ τῶν φθόνων διαβολάς, ὑμᾶς δὲ πάντως, καίπερ ἀλλήλων χωρὶς γεγονότας καὶ διαφόρους ὄντας, πειρᾶσθαι φίλους ἀλλήλοις ὅτι μάλιστα ποιεῖν; τούτων δὴ καὶ σὺ

μάρτυς, ὅτι τοῦτο αὐτὸ συντείνων οὐκ ἀνῆκα πώποτε· καὶ μόγις μὲν, ὅμως δ', ὠμολογήθη νῶν

317a

And although it was difficult, the two of us nevertheless agreed that I should sail home since you were involved in a war, and that when peace came, Dion and I were to return to Syracuse and you were to send for us. When peace came you sent for me, but not in accordance with the agreement. You wrote that I was to come alone, and you said you would send for Dion later. Because of this I did not go. After this, a year later, a trireme arrived along with letters from you, and the chief purport of what was contained in the letters was that if I were to come to Syracuse, Dion's affairs would be organised in accord with my wishes, whereas if I did not, the outcome would be the very opposite.

πλεῦσαι μὲν οἴκαδε ἐμέ, ἐπειδὴ πόλεμος ὑμᾶς κατεῖχεν, εἰρήνης δ' αὖ γενομένης ἐλθεῖν ἐμέ τε καὶ Δίωνα εἰς Συρακούσας, σὲ δὲ καλεῖν ἡμᾶς. καὶ ταῦτα μὲν οὕτως ἐγένετο τῆς ἐμῆς εἰς Συρακούσας ἀποδημίας περὶ τῆς πρώτης καὶ τῆς πάλιν οἴκαδε σωτηρίας· τὸ δὲ δεύτερον εἰρήνης γενομένης ἐκάλεῖς με οὐ κατὰ τὰς ὁμολογίας, ἀλλὰ μόνον ἤκειν ἐπέστειλας, Δίωνα δ' εἰς αὐθις ἔφησθα μεταπέμψεσθαι. διὰ ταῦτα οὐκ ἦλθον, ἀλλὰ καὶ Δίῳνι τότ' ἀπηχθόμην· ᾤετο γὰρ εἶναι βέλτιον ἐλθεῖν ἐμέ καὶ ὑπακοῦσαί σοι. τὸ δὲ μετὰ ταῦτα ὕστερον ἐνιαυτῷ τριήρης ἀφίκετο καὶ ἐπιστολαὶ παρὰ σοῦ, τῶν δ' ἐν ταῖς ἐπιστολαῖς γραμμάτων ἦρχεν ὥς, ἂν ἀφίκωμαι, τὰ Δίῳνός μοι γενήσοιτο πράγματα πάντα κατὰ νοῦν τὸν ἐμόν, μὴ ἀφικομένου δέ, τάναντία. αἰσχύνομαι δὴ λέγειν ὅσαι τότε ἐπιστολαὶ παρὰ σοῦ καὶ παρ' ἄλλων ἦλθον

317c

You know of course what happened after I arrived. In fact, I asked, in accord with the agreement in our letters, firstly, that Dion be restored and that you be reconciled with him. Secondly, I asked that Dion's relatives retain his property and that the annual revenue usually sent to him should continue to be sent. When none of these requests were granted, I asked if I could depart. You then started persuading me to stay for the year, saying that you were selling all Dion's property and

were going to send half of the proceeds to Corinth. But, you surprising man, you then topped all of your promises most insolently. For when you expelled Heraclides, an action that neither the Syracusans nor I myself regarded as just, you said that it had been obvious to you for a long time that I thought nothing of you, but only of Dion and his friends.

διὰ σὲ ἐξ Ἰταλίας καὶ Σικελίας, καὶ παρ' ὅσους τῶν ἐμῶν οἰκείων καὶ τῶν γνωρίμων, καὶ πᾶσαι διακελευόμεναί μοι ἰέναι καὶ δεόμεναι σοὶ πάντως ἐμὲ πείθεσθαι. ἐδόκει δὴ πᾶσιν, ἀρξαμένοις ἀπὸ Δίωνος, δεῖν ἐμὲ πλεῦσαι καὶ μὴ μαλθακίζεσθαι. καίτοι τήν θ' ἡλικίαν αὐτοῖς προυτεινόμενην καὶ περὶ σοῦ διισχυριζόμενην ὥς οὐχ οἷός τ' ἔσσιο ἀνταρκεῖσαι τοῖς διαβάλλουσιν ἡμᾶς καὶ βουλομένοις εἰς ἔχθραν ἐλθεῖν—ἐώρων γὰρ καὶ τότε καὶ νῦν ὁρῶ τὰς μεγάλας οὐσίας καὶ ὑπερόγκους τῶν τε ἰδιωτῶν καὶ τῶν μονάρχων σχεδόν, ὅσῳ περ ἂν μείζους ᾤσιν, τοσοῦτ' ὧς πλείους καὶ μείζους τοὺς διαβάλλοντας καὶ πρὸς ἡδονὴν μετὰ αἰσχροῦς βλάβης ὁμιλοῦντας τρεφούσας, οὗ κακὸν οὐδὲν μείζον γεννᾷ πλοῦτός τε καὶ ἡ τῆς ἄλλης ἐξουσίας δύναμις—ὅμως δ' οὖν πάντα ταῦτα χαίρειν ἔασας ἦλθον, διανοηθεὶς ὥς οὐδένα δεῖ τῶν ἐμῶν φίλων ἐμὲ αἰτιᾶσθαι ὥς διὰ τὴν ἐμὴν ῥαθυμίαν τὰ σφέτερα πάντα ἐξὸν μὴ ἀπολέσθαι διώλετο· ἐλθὼν δέ—οἶσθα γὰρ δὴ σὺ πάντα τὰν τεύθεν ἤδη γενόμενα—ἐγὼ μὲν ἡξίουں δήπου κατὰ τὴν ὁμολογίαν τῶν ἐπιστολῶν πρῶτον μὲν κατάγειν Δίωνα οἰκειωσάμενον, φράζων τὴν οἰκειότητα, ἦν εἰ ἐμοὶ τότε ἐπέιθου, τάχ' ἂν βέλτιον τῶν νῦν γεγονότων ἔσχεν καὶ σοὶ καὶ Συρακούσαις καὶ τοῖς ἄλλοις Ἑλλησιν, ὥς ἡ ἐμὴ δόξα μαντεύεται· ἔπειτα τὰ Δίωνος τοὺς οἰκείους ἔχειν ἡξίουں καὶ μὴ διανείμασθαι τοὺς διανειμαμένους, οὓς οἶσθα σύ πρὸς δὲ τούτοις ὥμην δεῖν τὰ κατ' ἐνιαυτὸν ἕκαστον εἰωθότα αὐτῷ κομίζεσθαι καὶ μᾶλλον ἐγὼ ἔτι καὶ οὐχ ἥττον ἐμοῦ παραγενομένου πέμπεσθαι. τούτων οὐδενὸς τυγχάνων, ἡξίουں ἀπιέναι. τὸ μετὰ ταῦτα ἔπειθές με μείναι τὸν ἐνιαυτόν, φάσκων τὴν Δίωνος ἀποδόμενος οὐσίαν πᾶσαν τὰ μὲν ἡμίσεα ἀποπέμψειν εἰς Κόρινθον, τὰ δ' ἄλλα τῷ παιδὶ καταλείψειν αὐτοῦ. πολλὰ ἔχων εἰπεῖν ὣν ὑποσχόμενος οὐδὲν ἐποίησας, διὰ τὸ πλῆθος αὐτῶν συντέμνω. τὰ γὰρ δὴ χρήματα πάντα ἀποδόμενος, οὐ πείσας

Δίωνα, φάσκων οὐ πωλήσειν ἄνευ τοῦ πείθειν, τὸν κολοφῶνα, ὃ θαυμάσιε, ταῖς ὑποσχέσεσιν ἀπάσαις νεανικώτατον ἐπέθηκας· μηχανὴν γὰρ οὔτε καλὴν οὔτε κομψὴν οὔτε δικαίαν οὔτε συμφέρουσιν ἡῤρες, ἐμὲ ἐκφοβεῖν ὥς ἀγνοοῦντα τὰ τότε γιγνόμενα, ἵνα μὴδὲ ἐγὼ ζητοίην τὰ χρήματα ἀποπέμπεσθαι. ἡνίκα γὰρ Ἑρακλείδην ἐξέβαλες, οὔτε Συρακοσίοις δοκοῦν δικαίως οὔτ' ἐμοί, διότι μετὰ Θεοδότου καὶ Εὐρυβίου συνεδεήθην σου μὴ ποιεῖν ταῦτα, ταύτην λαβὼν ὥς ἱκανὴν πρόφασιν, εἶπες ὅτι καὶ πάλαι σοι δῆλος εἶην σοῦ μὲν οὐδὲν φροντίζων, Δίωνος δὲ καὶ τῶν Δίωνος φίλων καὶ οἰκείων, καὶ ἐπειδὴ νῦν Θεοδότης καὶ Ἑρακλείδης ἐν διαβολαῖς εἶεν, οἰκείοι Δίωνος ὄντες, πᾶν μηχανώμην ὅπως οὗτοι μὴ δώσουσιν δίκην. καὶ ταῦτα μὲν ταύτῃ περὶ τὰ πολιτικὰ κοινωνίας τῆς ἐμῆς καὶ σῆς· καὶ εἴ τινα ἑτέραν ἀλλοτριότητα ἐνεῖδες ἐν ἐμοὶ πρὸς σέ, εἰκότως οἶμι ταύτῃ πάντα ταῦτα γεγονέναι. καὶ μὴ θαύμαζε· κακὸς γὰρ ἂν ἔχοντί γε νοῦν ἄνδρι φαινοίμην ἐνδίκως, πεισθεὶς ὑπὸ τοῦ μεγέθους τῆς σῆς ἀρχῆς τὸν μὲν παλαιὸν φίλον καὶ ξένον κακῶς πράττοντα διὰ σέ, μὴδὲν σοῦ χεῖρω, ἵνα οὕτως εἴπω,

318e

The argument comes more or less to the second statement against which I must defend myself. I confirm that, with Archedemus present in the garden, along with Aristocritus, some twenty days before I left Syracuse for home, you said then what you are now saying in your criticism of me, that I favoured Heraclides and all the others more than yourself. And you asked me if I remembered when I first arrived calling upon you to colonise the Greek cities. I agreed that I did remember and that I still thought this to be the best policy. But I must also repeat what was said next. For I then asked you whether this was the only piece of advice I gave you or whether there was something else besides this. And you answered me most angrily and contemptuously. You said, I recall, with much feigned laughter, “You bade me to do all of these things after I had been educated, or not do them at all.” I replied that your recollection was excellent.

τοῦτον μὲν προδοῦναι, σὲ δὲ τὸν ἀδικοῦντα ἐλέσθαι καὶ πᾶν δρᾶν ὅπῃ σὺ προσέταττες, ἔνεκα χρημάτων δήλον ὅτι· οὐδὲν γὰρ ἂν ἕτερον ἔφησεν αἰτιόν τις εἶναι τῆς ἐμῆς μεταβολῆς, εἰ μετεβαλόμην. ἀλλὰ ταῦτα μὲν ταύτῃ γενόμενα τὴν ἐμὴν καὶ σὴν λυκοφιλίαν καὶ ἀκοινωνιάν διὰ σὲ ἀπηργάσατο. σχεδὸν δ' εἰς λόγον ὁ λόγος ἤκει μοι συνεχῆς τῷ νυνδὴ γενόμενος, περὶ οὗ μοι τὸ δεύτερον ἀπολογητέον ἔφην εἶναι. σκόπει δὴ καὶ πρόσεχε πάντως, ἂν σοί τι ψεύδεσθαι δόξω καὶ μὴ τάληθῇ λέγειν. φημί γάρ σε Ἀρχεδήμου παρόντος ἐν τῷ κήπῳ καὶ Ἀριστοκρίτου, σχεδὸν ἡμέραις πρότερον εἴκοσι τῆς ἐμῆς ἐκ Συρακουσῶν οἴκαδ' ἀποδημίας, ἃ νῦν δὴ λέγεις ἐμοὶ μεμφόμενος, ὡς Ἑρακλείδου τέ μοι καὶ τῶν ἄλλων πάντων μᾶλλον ἢ σοῦ μέλοι. καί με τούτων ἐναντίον διηρώτησας εἰ μνημονεύω, κατ' ἀρχὰς ὅτ' ἦλθον, κελεύων σε τὰς πόλεις τὰς Ἑλληνίδας κατοικίζειν· ἐγὼ δὲ συνεχώρουν μεμνησθαι καὶ ἔτι νῦν μοι δοκεῖν ταῦτ' εἶναι βέλτιστα. ρητέον δέ, ὦ Διονύσιε, καὶ τοῦπι τούτῳ τότε λεχθέν. ἡρόμην γὰρ δὴ σε πότερον αὐτὸ τοῦτό σοι συμβουλευσάμην μόνον ἢ τι καὶ ἄλλο πρὸς τούτῳ· σὺ δὲ καὶ μάλ' ἀπεκρίνω μεμνημένως καὶ ὕβριστικῶς εἰς ἐμέ, ὡς ᾧ—διὸ τὸ τότε σοι ὕβρισμα νῦν ὕπαρ ἄντ' ὀνειράτος γέγονεν—εἵπες δὲ καὶ μάλα πλαστῶς γελῶν, εἰ μέμνημαι, ὡς παιδευθέντα με ἐκέλευες ποιεῖν πάντα ταῦτα ἢ μὴ ποιεῖν. ἔφην ἐγὼ κάλλιστα μνημονεῦσαί σε. οὐκοῦν παιδευθέντα, ἔφησθα, γεωμετρεῖν, ἢ πῶς; κἀγὼ τὸ μετὰ ταῦτα ὃ ἐπῆει μοι εἰπεῖν οὐκ εἶπον, φοβούμενος μὴ σμικροῦ ῥήματος ἔνεκα τὸν ἔκπλουν ὃν προσεδόκων, μή μοι στενὸς γίγνοιτο ἄντ' εὐρυχωρίας. ἀλλ' οὖν ὦν ἔνεκα πάντ' εἴρηται ταῦτ' ἐστί· μή με διάβαλλε λέγων ὡς οὐκ εἶων ἐγὼ σε πόλεις Ἑλληνίδας ἐρρούσας

319d

Now, the reason I am saying all this is as follows. Do not slander me by saying that I did not allow you to colonise the Greek cities ruined by the non-Greeks, or to lighten the burden of the Syracusans by introducing kingly rule in place of the tyranny. For in my case, no lie you could ever tell about me is less appropriate than these slanders. And indeed, there is no difficulty in stating plainly that the implementation of these measures was the best course for you, the

Syracusans, and for all Sicilians. But, my friend, if you deny saying these things, even though you said them, then justice lies with me. But if you agree that you said them, you should then regard Stesichorus as wise, imitate his recantation, and renounce your false account for the true one.

ὕπὸ βαρβάρων οἰκίζειν, οὐδὲ Συρακουσίους ἐπικουφίσαι βασιλείαν ἀντὶ τυραννίδος μεταστήσαντα. τούτων γὰρ οὐθ' ἦττον ἐμοὶ πρέποντα ἔχοις ἂν ποτε λέγων μου καταψεύσασθαι, πρὸς δὲ τούτοις ἔτι σαφεστέρους τούτων εἰς ἔλεγχον λόγους ἐγὼ δοίην ἅν, εἴ τις ἱκανή που φαίνοιτο κρίσις, ὥς ἐγὼ μὲν ἐκέλευον, σὺ δ' οὐκ ἤθελες πράττειν αὐτά· καὶ μὴν οὐ χαλεπὸν εἰπεῖν ἐναργῶς ὥς ἦν ταῦτα ἄριστα πραχθέντα καὶ σοὶ καὶ Συρακοσίοις καὶ Σικελιώταις πᾶσιν. ἀλλ' ὦ τᾶν, εἰ μὲν μὴ φῆς εἰρηκέναι εἰρηκῶς ταῦτα, ἔχω τὴν δίκην· εἰ δ' ὁμολογεῖς, τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο ἡγησάμενος εἶναι σοφὸν τὸν Στησίχορον, τὴν παλινωδίαν αὐτοῦ μιμησάμενος, ἐκ τοῦ ψεύδους εἰς τὸν ἀληθῆ λόγον μεταστήσῃ.

320a

EH: FOURTH EPISTLE Plato to Dion of Syracuse: may you do well

320a

I believe that my eager interest in the unfolding events has been evident all along, and also my serious concern that they be brought to a conclusion, mainly because of my high regard for noble deeds. For I think it is only right that those who are actually reasonable and who act accordingly should get the recognition they deserve. And although for the moment, thank God, things are going well, the greatest struggle is still to come. For although various others may seem to excel in courage, speed and strength, anyone would agree that those who claim to honour such qualities as truth, justice, and high-mindedness, and decorum in their display of all these, are naturally superior to others.

Πλάτων Δίῳνι Συρακοσίῳ εὖ πράττειν. οἶμαι μὲν φανεράν εἶναι διὰ παντὸς τοῦ χρόνου τὴν ἐμὴν προθυμίαν περὶ τὰς συμβεβηκυίας πράξεις, καὶ ὅτι πολλὴν εἶχον περὶ αὐτῶν σπουδὴν εἰς τὸ

συμπερανθῆναι, οὐκ ἄλλου τινὸς ἔνεκα μᾶλλον ἢ τῆς ἐπὶ τοῖς καλοῖς φιλοτιμίας· νομίζω γὰρ δίκαιον εἶναι τοὺς ὄντας τῇ ἀληθείᾳ ἐπιεικεῖς καὶ πράττοντας τοιαῦτα τυγχάνειν δόξης τῆς προσηκούσης. τὰ μὲν οὖν εἰς τὸ παρόν, σὺν θεῷ εἰπεῖν, ἔχει καλῶς, τὰ δὲ περὶ τῶν μελλόντων ὁ μέγιστός ἐστιν ἄγών. ἀνδρεία μὲν γὰρ καὶ τάχει καὶ ῥώμῃ διενεγκεῖν δόξειεν ἂν καὶ ἐτέρων εἶναι τινων, ἀληθείᾳ δὲ καὶ δικαιοσύνῃ καὶ μεγαλοπρεπείᾳ

320c

We need to make it obvious that we are the sort of people we say we are, especially since, God willing, it will be easy to do so. For other people, it proves necessary to wander abroad if they are to be well known, but with you the position is that people everywhere all look towards one place, and in that place they look most of all towards yourself. So, with the eyes of the world upon you, prepare to take on the role of a Lycurgus or a Cyrus of old. This is especially important since many people are saying that with Dionysius out of the way, there is a strong possibility that your endeavours will come to naught because of the rivalry between yourself, Heraclides, Theodotus, and other notable ambitious characters. Let us hope above all that no one behaves like this, but if anyone does so, you must assume the role of a healer.

καὶ τῇ περὶ πάντα ταῦτα εὐσχημοσύνῃ, συμφαίῃ τις ἂν τοὺς ἀντιποιοιμένους τὰ τοιαῦτα τιμᾶν εἰκότως τῶν ἄλλων διαφέρειν. νῦν οὖν δῆλον μὲν ἐστὶν ὃ λέγω, ἀναμιμνήσκειν δὲ ὅμως δεῖ ἡμᾶς αὐτοὺς ὅτι προσήκει πλεον ἢ παίδων τῶν ἄλλων ἀνθρώπων διαφέρειν τοὺς οἶσθα δήπου. φανεροὺς οὖν δεῖ ἡμᾶς γενέσθαι ὅτι ἐσμὲν τοιοῦτοι οἰοίπερ φαμέν, ἄλλως τε καὶ ἐπειδὴ, σὺν θεῷ εἰπεῖν, ῥάδιον ἔσται. τοῖς μὲν γὰρ ἄλλοις συμβέβηκεν ἀναγκαῖον εἶναι πλανηθῆναι πολὺν τόπον, εἰ μέλλουσιν γνωσθῆναι· τὸ δὲ νῦν ὑπάρχον περὶ σὲ τοιοῦτόν ἐστιν, ὥς τοὺς ἐξ ἀπάσης τῆς οἰκουμένης, εἰ καὶ νεανικώτερόν ἐστιν εἰπεῖν, εἰς ἓνα τόπον ἀποβλέπειν, καὶ ἐν τούτῳ μάλιστα πρὸς σέ. ὥς οὖν ὑπὸ πάντων ὁρώμενος παρασκευάζου τόν τε Λυκοῦργον ἐκείνον ἀρχαῖον

ἀποδείξων καὶ τὸν Κῦρον, καὶ εἴ τις ἄλλος πώποτε ἔδοξεν ἥθει καὶ πολιτείᾳ διενεγκεῖν, ἄλλως τε καὶ ἐπειδὴ πολλοὶ καὶ σχεδὸν

320e

Perhaps the fact that I am saying this appears comical to you since you yourself are not unaware of these details. But I observe that in the theatres, the actors are spurred on even by the children, not to mention their friends, provided the actor thinks the encouragement is serious and well-intentioned. So, you yourselves should now act out your parts, and if you need anything just write to us. And now, in spite of the fact that letters arrived in Sparta and Aegina from Theodorus and Heraclides, we still hear much but know nothing. But also bear in mind that you seem to some people to lack the appropriate level of care. So, do not overlook the fact that pleasing other people is a means to acting successfully whereas self-will is the housemate of loneliness. Good fortune.

ἅπαντες οἱ τῇδε λέγουσιν ὥς πολλή ἐστιν ἐλπίς ἀναιρεθέντος Διονυσίου διαφθαρῆναι τὰ πράγματα διὰ τὴν σὴν τε καὶ Ἡρακλείδου καὶ Θεοδότου καὶ τῶν ἄλλων γνωρίμων φιλοτιμίαν. μάλιστα μὲν οὖν μηδεὶς εἴη τοιοῦτος ἐὰν δ' ἄρα καὶ γίγνηται τις, σὺ φαίνου ἰατρεύων, καὶ πρὸς τὸ βέλτιστον

321a

EH: FIFTH EPISTLE Plato to Perdiccas: may you do well

321a

I advised Euphraeus, at your request, to spend time looking after your affairs. And it is only right that I give you friendly and so-called sacred advice about the other issues you mentioned and as to how you should now employ Euphraeus. The man is useful in many respects, but the greatest is one that you stand in need of because of your youth. For each political system has its own language, just like various animals, one belonging to democracy, another to oligarchy, another to monarchy. And although everyone claims to know these, most people, with few exceptions, fall short of fully understanding them. Now, whatever political system utters its own language towards gods or

men, and makes its actions conform to its utterance, thrives and is preserved. But if it imitates another, it is undone.

ἔλθοιτ' ἄν. ταῦτα δὲ ἴσως γελοῖόν σοι φαίνεται εἶναι τὸ ἐμὲ λέγειν, διότι καὶ αὐτὸς οὐκ ἀγνοεῖς· ἐγὼ δὲ καὶ ἐν τοῖς θεάτροις ὁρῶ τοὺς ἀγωνιστὰς ὑπὸ τῶν παίδων παροξυνομένους, μήτι δὴ ὑπὸ γε τῶν φίλων, οὓς ἄν τις οἴηται μετὰ σπουδῆς κατ' εὐνοίαν παρακελεύεσθαι. νῦν οὖν αὐτοὶ τε ἀγωνίζεσθε καὶ ἡμῖν εἴ του δεῖ ἐπιστέλλετε· τὰ δ' ἐνθάδε παραπλησίως ἔχει καθάπερ καὶ ὑμῶν παρόντων. ἐπιστέλλετε δὲ καὶ ὅτι πέπρακται ὑμῖν ἢ πράττοντες τυγχάνετε, ὥς ἡμεῖς πολλὰ ἀκούοντες οὐδὲν ἴσμεν· καὶ νῦν ἐπιστολαὶ παρὰ μὲν Θεοδότου καὶ Ἡρακλείδου ἤκουσιν εἰς Λακεδαίμονα καὶ Αἴγιναν, ἡμεῖς δέ, καθάπερ εἴρηται, πολλὰ ἀκούοντες περὶ τῶν τῆδε οὐδὲν ἴσμεν. ἐνθυμοῦ δὲ καὶ ὅτι δοκεῖς τισιν ἐνδεεστερώς τοῦ προσήκοντος θεραπευτικὸς εἶναι· μὴ οὖν λανθανέτω σε ὅτι διὰ τοῦ ἀρέσκειν τοῖς ἀνθρώποις καὶ τὸ

321c

Euphraeus should prove useful to you for these purposes at least, and he is also a good man in other respects too. So, by using him for these purposes you will benefit yourself and also be of enormous benefit to him. But if someone were to say, “It seems that Plato pretends to know what is of benefit to the democracy, but despite being allowed to address the populace and advise them as to what is best, he has never yet stood up and uttered a word,” you should respond: “Plato was born at a late stage in the history of his fatherland, and he came upon a populace already advanced in years and habituated by their predecessors to many practices incompatible with Plato’s advice. He would have been most delighted to give advice to the populace, had he not thought that he would be running risks in vain and accomplishing nothing worthwhile.” Good fortune.

πράττειν ἐστίν, ἢ δ' αὐθάδεια ἐρημία σύννοικος. εὐτύχει. Πλάτων Περδίκκᾳ εὖ πράττειν. Εὐφραΐῳ μὲν συνεβούλευσα, καθάπερ ἐπέστελλες, τῶν σῶν ἐπιμελούμενον περὶ ταῦτα διατρίβειν· δίκαιος δ' εἰμὶ καὶ σοὶ ξενικὴν καὶ ἱερὰν συμβουλὴν λεγομένην συμβουλεύειν

περί τε τῶν ἄλλων ὧν ἂν φράζῃς καὶ ὡς Εὐφραίῳ δεῖ τὰ νῦν χρῆσθαι. πολλὰ μὲν γὰρ ὁ ἀνὴρ χρήσιμος, μέγιστον δὲ οὐ καὶ σὺ νῦν ἐνδεὴς εἶ διὰ τε τὴν ἡλικίαν καὶ διὰ τὸ μὴ πολλοὺς αὐτοῦ περὶ συμβούλους εἶναι τοῖς νέοις. ἔστιν γὰρ δὴ τις φωνὴ τῶν πολιτειῶν ἐκάστης καθαπερεὶ τινων ζώων, ἄλλη μὲν δημοκρατίας, ἄλλη δ' ὀλιγαρχίας, ἢ δ' αὖ μοναρχίας· ταύτας φαίεν μὲν ἂν ἐπίστασθαι πάμπολλοι, πλεῖστον δ' ἀπολείπονται τοῦ κατανοεῖν αὐτὰς πλὴν ὀλίγων δὴ τινων. ἦτις μὲν ἂν οὖν τῶν πολιτειῶν τὴν αὐτῆς φθέγγηται φωνὴν πρὸς τε θεοὺς καὶ πρὸς ἀνθρώπους, καὶ τῇ φωνῇ τὰς πράξεις ἐπομένας ἀποδιδῶ, θάλλει τε αἰεὶ καὶ σῶζεται, μιμουμένη δ' ἄλλην φθείρεται. πρὸς ταῦτ' οὖν Εὐφραΐος σοι γίγνοιτ' οὐχ ἥκιστα ἂν χρήσιμος, καίπερ καὶ πρὸς ἄλλα ὧν ἀνδρεῖος· τοὺς γὰρ τῆς μοναρχίας λόγους οὐχ ἥκιστ' αὐτὸν ἐλπίζω συνεξευρήσειν τῶν περὶ τὴν σὴν διατριβὴν ὄντων· εἰς ταῦτ' οὖν αὐτῷ χρώμενος ὀνήσῃ τε αὐτὸς καὶ ἐκεῖνον πλεῖστα ὠφελήσεις. ἐὰν δέ τις ἀκούσας ταῦτα εἴπῃ· Πλάτων, ὡς ἔοικεν, προσποιεῖται μὲν τὰ δημοκρατία συμφέροντα εἰδέναι, ἐξὸν δ' ἐν τῷ δήμῳ λέγειν καὶ συμβουλεύειν αὐτῷ τὰ βέλτιστα οὐ πώποτε ἀναστὰς ἐφθέγγατο, πρὸς ταῦτ' εἰπεῖν ὅτι Πλάτων ὁψὲ ἐν τῇ πατρίδι γέγονεν καὶ τὸν δῆμον κατέλαβεν ἤδη πρεσβύτερον καὶ εἰθισμένον ὑπὸ τῶν ἔμπροσθεν πολλὰ καὶ ἀνόμοια τῇ ἐκείνου συμβουλῇ πράττειν· ἐπεὶ πάντων ἂν ἥδιστα καθάπερ πατρὶ συνεβούλευεν αὐτῷ, εἰ μὴ μάτην μὲν κινδυνεύσειν ᾧετο, πλέον δ' οὐδὲν ποιήσειν. ταῦτὸν δὴ οἶμαι δρᾶσαι ἂν καὶ τὴν ἐμὴν συμβουλὴν. εἰ γὰρ δόξαιμεν ἀνιάτως ἔχειν, πολλὰ ἂν χαίρειν ἡμῖν εἰπὼν ἐκτὸς ἂν γίγνοιτο τῆς περὶ ἐμὲ καὶ τὰ ἐμὰ συμβουλῆς. εὐτύχει. Πλάτων Ἑρμείᾳ καὶ Ἑράστῳ καὶ Κορίσκῳ εὖ πράττειν· ἐμοὶ φαίνεται θεῶν τις ὑμῖν τύχην ἀγαθὴν, ἂν εὖ δέξησθε, εὐμενῶς καὶ ἱκανῶς παρασκευάζειν· οἰκεῖτε γὰρ δὴ γείτονές τε ὑμῖν αὐτοῖς καὶ χρεῖαν ἔχοντες ὥστε ἀλλήλους εἰς τὰ

322d

EH: SIXTH EPISTLE Plato to Hermias¹⁰, Erastus and Coriscus: may you do well

322d

It is apparent to me that some god has graciously and adequately provided you with good fortune, if you can receive it well. For you live as neighbours and your needs are such that you are of great benefit to one another. As for Hermias, neither abundance of horses nor other military resources nor accumulated gold would contribute more to his overall power than firm friends of sound character. And to Erastus and Coriscus, in spite of my age, I am saying they should supplement the noble wisdom of the forms with a wisdom and protective power that defends them against the wicked and the unjust. For they are lacking in experience because they have lived out much of their lives with us moderate folk who are not evil.

μέγιστα ὠφελεῖν. Ἑρμεία μὲν γὰρ οὔτε ἵππων πλῆθος οὔτε ἄλλης πολεμικῆς συμμαχίας οὐδ' αὖ χρυσοῦ προσγενομένου γένοιτ' ἂν μείζων εἰς τὰ πάντα δύναμις, ἢ φίλων βεβαίων τε καὶ ἥθος ἐχόντων ὑγίης· Ἐράστῳ δὲ καὶ Κορίσκῳ, πρὸς τῇ τῶν εἰδῶν σοφίᾳ τῇ καλῇ ταύτῃ, φήμ' ἐγώ, καίπερ γέρων ὢν, προσδεῖν σοφίας τῆς περὶ τοὺς πονηροὺς καὶ ἀδίκους φυλακτικῆς καὶ τινος ἀμυντικῆς δυνάμεως. ἄπειροι γάρ εἰσι διὰ τὸ μεθ' ἡμῶν μετρίων ὄντων καὶ οὐ κακῶν συχνὸν διατετριφέναι τοῦ βίου· διὸ δὴ τούτων προσδεῖν εἶπον, ἵνα μὴ ἀναγκάζωνται τῆς ἀληθινῆς μὲν ἀμελεῖν σοφίας, τῆς δὲ ἀνθρωπίνης τε καὶ ἀναγκαίας ἐπιμελεῖσθαι μειζόνως ἢ δεῖ. ταύτην δ' αὖ τὴν δύναμιν Ἑρμείας μοι φαίνεται φύσει τε, ὅσα

323a

So what am I saying? To you Hermias, since I am more familiar with Erastus and Coriscus than you are, I assert, declare and bear witness that you will not easily find more trustworthy characters than these neighbours of yours, and I advise you to cleave to these two men by every just means as a matter of no secondary importance. And again, I am advising Coriscus and Erastus to cleave to Hermias and try to develop your mutual closeness into a united relationship of friendship. But if one of you somehow seems to be severing this relationship, for nothing human is entirely firm, send me and my associates here a letter declaring the nature of the complaint. For I believe that unless

the breach happens to be grievous, any communications arriving from us here in justice and reverence would do more than any charm to unite you, and restore once again your previous ties of friendship and fellowship.

μήπω συγγεγονότι, καὶ τέχνη δι' ἐμπειρίας εἰληφέναι. τί οὖν δὴ λέγω; σοὶ μὲν, Ἑρμεία, πεπειραμένος Ἑράστου καὶ Κορίσκου πλέονα ἢ σύ, φημί καὶ μηνύω καὶ μαρτυρῶ μὴ ῥαδίως εὐρήσειν σε ἀξιοπιστότερα ἦθη τούτων τῶν γειτόνων· ἔχεσθαι δὴ παντὶ συμβουλευῶ δικαίῳ τρόπῳ τούτων τῶν ἀνδρῶν, μὴ πάρεργον ἡγουμένῳ. Κορίσκῳ δὲ καὶ Ἑράστῳ πάλιν Ἑρμείου ἀντέχεσθαι σύμβουλός εἰμι καὶ πειρᾶσθαι ταῖς ἀνθέξεσιν ἀλλήλων εἰς μίαν ἀφικέσθαι φιλίας συμπλοκὴν. ἂν δέ τις ὑμῶν ἄρα ταύτην πη λύειν δοκῇ—τὸ γὰρ ἀνθρώπινον οὐ παντάπασιν βέβαιον—δεῦρο παρ' ἐμὲ καὶ τοὺς ἐμοὺς πέμπετε μομφῆς κατήγορον ἐπιστολήν· οἶμαι γὰρ δίκη τε καὶ αἰδοῖ τοὺς παρ' ἡμῶν ἐντεῦθεν ἐλθόντας λόγους, εἰ μὴ τι τὸ λυθὲν μέγα τύχοι γεγόμενον, ἐπωδῆς ἡστινοσοῦν μᾶλλον ἂν συμφῶσαι καὶ συνδεῖσαι πάλιν εἰς τὴν προϋπάρχουσαν

323c

And if we all, yourselves and ourselves, apply philosophy to this fellowship as best we can, as the nature of each allows, the prophecies I am making will prevail. All three of you should read this letter, preferably together or in pairs, in fellowship to the best of your ability, as often as you can. Use it as a covenant and a supreme law, a just one, swearing earnestly, and at the same time poetically, with a playfulness akin to that earnestness. Swearing to the ruling god of everything that is now and is to come, supreme father of the ruling cause, whom we, if we genuinely engage in philosophy, shall all clearly know as far as possible for happy humans.

φιλότητά τε καὶ κοινωνίαν, ἣν ἂν μὲν φιλοσοφῶμεν ἅπαντες ἡμεῖς τε καὶ ὑμεῖς, ὅσον ἂν δυνώμεθα καὶ ἐκάστῳ παρείκη, κύρια τὰ νῦν κεχρησμοδημένα ἔσται. τὸ δὲ ἂν μὴ δρῶμεν ταῦτα οὐκ ἐρῶ· φήμην γὰρ ἀγαθὴν μαντεύομαι, καὶ φημί δὴ ταῦθ' ἡμᾶς πάντ' ἀγαθὰ ποιήσιν, ἂν

θεὸς ἐθέλη. ταύτην τὴν ἐπιστολὴν πάντας ὑμᾶς τρεῖς ὄντας ἀναγνῶναι χρή, μάλιστα μὲν ἀθρόους, εἰ δὲ μή, κατὰ δύο, κοινῇ κατὰ δύναμιν ὡς οἶόν τ' ἐστὶν πλειστάκις, καὶ χρῆσθαι συνθήκη καὶ νόμῳ κυρίῳ, ὃ ἐστὶν δίκαιον, ἐπομνύντας σπουδῇ τε ἅμα μὴ ἀμούσῳ καὶ τῇ τῆς σπουδῆς ἀδελφῇ παιδιᾷ, καὶ τὸν τῶν πάντων θεὸν ἡγεμόνα τῶν τε ὄντων καὶ τῶν μελλόντων, τοῦ τε ἡγεμόνος καὶ αἰτίου πατέρα κύριον ἐπομνύντας, ὃν, ἂν ὄντως φιλοσοφῶμεν, εἰσόμεθα πάντες σαφῶς εἰς δύναμιν ἀνθρώπων εὐδαιμόνων. Πλάτων τοῖς Δίωνος οἰκείοις τε καὶ ἐταίροις εὖ πράττειν. ἐπεστείλατέ μοι νομίζειν δεῖν τὴν διάνοιαν ὑμῶν εἶναι τὴν αὐτὴν ἣν εἶχεν καὶ δίων, καὶ δὴ καὶ κοινωνεῖν διεκελεύεσθαι

323e

EH: SEVENTH EPISTLE Plato to the relatives and associates of Dion:
may ye fare well

323e

You wrote to me that I should regard your thinking as being the same as that of Dion, and indeed you encouraged me to support you to the best of my ability in word and in deed. I reply that if you actually hold the same opinion and aspiration as that man, I promise to support you, but if you don't, this will require further consideration. And I can tell you from certain knowledge, without much need for conjecture, what his thinking and aspiration was. For when I arrived initially in Syracuse, aged about forty, Dion was the same age as Hipparinus is now, and he held the opinion then that he held to the very end. He thought that the Syracusans should be free people living under the very best laws.

324a

When I was young, my experience was the same as many others. I thought that as soon as I had become my own master I would immediately enter into the public life of the city. For the political system at the time, being criticised by many, was overthrown, and fifty-one men set themselves up as leaders of that overthrow. Some of these happened to be relatives or acquaintances of mine, and indeed they encouraged me to join them as their undertakings were

worthwhile. My feelings towards them were hardly surprising given my youth, for I thought they would administer the city by leading it out of an unjust manner of life to a just one.

μοι, καθ' ὅσον οἶός τέ εἰμι ἔργῳ καὶ λόγῳ. ἐγὼ δέ, εἰ μὲν δόξαν καὶ ἐπιθυμίαν τὴν αὐτὴν ἔχετε ἐκείνῳ, σύμφημι κοινωνήσῃν, εἰ δὲ μή, βουλευέσθαι πολλάκις. τίς δ' ἦν ἡ ἐκείνου διάνοια καὶ ἐπιθυμία, σχεδὸν οὐκ εἰκάζων ἀλλ' ὥς εἰδὼς σαφῶς εἴποιμ' ἄν. ὅτε γὰρ κατ' ἀρχὰς εἰς Συρακούσας ἐγὼ ἀφικόμην, σχεδὸν ἔτη τετταράκοντα γεγονώς, δίων εἶχε τὴν ἡλικίαν ἣν τὰ νῦν Ἰππαρίνος γέγονεν, καὶ ἦν ἔσχεν τότε δόξαν, ταύτην καὶ διετετέλεσεν ἔχων, Συρακοσίους οἶεσθαι δεῖν ἐλευθέρους εἶναι, κατὰ νόμους τοὺς ἀρίστους οἰκοῦντας ὥστε οὐδὲν θαυμαστὸν εἴ τις θεῶν καὶ τοῦτον εἰς τὴν αὐτὴν δόξαν περὶ πολιτείας ἐκείνῳ γενέσθαι σύμφρονα ποιήσειεν. τίς δ' ἦν ὁ τρόπος τῆς γενέσεως αὐτῆς, οὐκ ἀπάξιον ἀκοῦσαι νέῳ καὶ μὴ νέῳ, πειράσομαι δὲ ἐξ ἀρχῆς αὐτὴν ἐγὼ πρὸς ὑμᾶς διεξελθεῖν· ἔχει γὰρ καιρὸν τὰ νῦν. νέος ἐγὼ ποτε ὦν πολλοῖς δὴ ταῦτόν ἔπαθον· ᾤήθην, εἰ θᾶπτον ἑμαυτοῦ γενοίμην κύριος, ἐπὶ τὰ κοινὰ τῆς πόλεως

324c

And of course, I saw that these men did not take long to make the previous political arrangement look like a golden age. Among their various exploits, they also sent for Socrates, an elderly man who was dear to me, whom I would almost say unashamedly was the most just man alive at that time. They dispatched him, along with some others, to fetch one of our fellow citizens by force so that they could execute him. But he did not obey them, and he ran the risk of all sorts of consequences rather than getting involved in their unholy deeds. Seeing all this, and other actions that were just as bad, I was disgusted, and withdrew myself from the evils of that era.

εὐθὺς ἰέναι. καὶ μοι τύχαι τινὲς τῶν τῆς πόλεως πραγμάτων τοιαῖδε παρέπεσον. ὑπὸ πολλῶν γὰρ τῆς τότε πολιτείας λοιδορουμένης μεταβολὴ γίγνεται, καὶ τῆς μεταβολῆς εἰς καὶ πεντήκοντά τινες ἄνδρες προύστησαν ἄρχοντες, ἔνδεκα μὲν ἐν ἄστει, δέκα δ' ἐν Πειραιεῖ—περὶ τε

ἀγορὰν ἑκάτεροι τούτων ὅσα τ' ἐν τοῖς ἄστεσι διοικεῖν ἔδει—τριάκοντα δὲ πάντων ἄρχοντες κατέστησαν αὐτοκράτορες. τούτων δὴ τινες οἰκεῖοί τε ὄντες καὶ γνώριμοι ἐτύγχανον ἐμοί, καὶ δὴ καὶ παρεκάλουν εὐθύς ὡς ἐπὶ προσήκοντα πράγματά με. καὶ ἐγὼ θαυμαστὸν οὐδὲν ἔπαθον ὑπὸ νεότητος· ᾧήθην γὰρ αὐτοὺς ἔκ τινος ἀδίκου βίου ἐπὶ δίκαιον τρόπον ἄγοντας διοικήσιν δὴ τὴν πόλιν, ὥστε αὐτοῖς σφόδρα προσεῖχον τὸν νοῦν, τί πράττειν. καὶ ὁρῶν δήπου τοὺς ἄνδρας ἐν χρόνῳ ὀλίγῳ χρυσὸν ἀποδείξαντας τὴν ἔμπροσθεν πολιτείαν—τά τε ἄλλα καὶ φίλον ἄνδρα ἐμοὶ πρεσβύτερον Σωκράτη, ὃν ἐγὼ σχεδὸν οὐκ ἂν αἰσχυνοίμην εἰπὼν δικαιοτάτον εἶναι τῶν τότε, ἐπὶ τινὰ τῶν πολιτῶν μεθ' ἑτέρων ἔπεμπον, βία ἄξοντα ὡς ἀποθανούμενον,

325a

But as it happened, again with this companion of ours, Socrates, influential people prosecuted him, bringing a most despicable accusation against him. They charged him with impiety, while others convicted him, and condemned to death the very man who had refused to get involved in the impious plot against one of their own exiled friends. Watching these developments, and seeing the sort of people who were conducting our political affairs and the state of our laws and habits, the more I saw, as I advanced in years, just how difficult it appeared to be to manage civic affairs in the right way. For it is impossible to do this without friends and trustworthy associates, and to find such people readily available was not easy.

ἵνα δὴ μετέχοι τῶν πραγμάτων αὐτοῖς, εἴτε βούλοιτο εἴτε μή· ὁ δ' οὐκ ἐπέθετο, πᾶν δὲ παρεκινδύνευσεν παθεῖν πρὶν ἀνοσίων αὐτοῖς ἔργων γενέσθαι κοινωνός—ἃ δὴ πάντα καθορῶν καὶ εἴ τι· ἄλλα τοιαῦτα οὐ σμικρά, ἐδυσχεράνα τε καὶ ἐμαυτὸν ἐπανάγαγον ἀπὸ τῶν τότε κακῶν. χρόνῳ δὲ οὐ πολλῷ μετέπεσε τὰ τῶν τριάκοντά τε καὶ πᾶσα ἡ τότε πολιτεία· πάλιν δὲ βραδύτερον μὲν, εἴλκεν δέ με ὁμως ἡ περὶ τὸ πράττειν τὰ κοινὰ καὶ πολιτικὰ ἐπιθυμία. ἦν οὖν καὶ ἐν ἐκείνοις ἅτε τεταραγμένοις πολλὰ γιγνόμενα ἃ τις ἂν δυσχεράνειεν, καὶ οὐδέν τι θαυμαστὸν ἦν τιμωρίας ἐχθρῶν γίγνεσθαι τινῶν τισιν μείζους ἐν μεταβολαῖς· καίτοι πολλῇ γε ἐχρήσαντο οἱ τότε κατελθόντες ἐπεικεία.

κατὰ δέ τινα τύχην αὖ τὸν ἐταῖρον ἡμῶν Σωκράτη τοῦτον δυναστεύοντές τινες εἰσάγουσιν εἰς δικαστήριον, ἀνοσιωτάτην αἰτίαν ἐπιβαλόντες καὶ πάντων ἥκιστα Σωκράτει προσήκουσαν· ὡς ἀσεβῆ γὰρ οἱ μὲν εἰσήγαγον, οἱ δὲ κατεψηφίσαντο καὶ ἀπέκτειναν τὸν τότε τῆς ἀνοσίου ἀγωγῆς οὐκ ἐθελήσαντα μετασχεῖν περὶ ἓνα τῶν τότε φευγόντων φίλων, ὅτε φεύγοντες ἐδυστύχουν αὐτοί. σκοποῦντι δὴ μοι ταῦτά τε καὶ τοὺς ἀνθρώπους τοὺς πράττοντας τὰ πολιτικά, καὶ τοὺς νόμους γε καὶ ἔθη, ὅσω μᾶλλον διεσκόπουν ἡλικίας τε εἰς τὸ πρόσθε προύβαινον, τοσοῦτω χαλεπώτερον ἐφαίνετο ὀρθῶς εἶναι μοι τὰ πολιτικά

325d

And I was compelled to say, in praise of right philosophy, that from this it is possible to discern all that is just in the political realm and among individuals. So, the evils of the human race shall not cease until either the sort of people who engage in philosophy, rightly and truly, come to power in political affairs, or those who exercise power in cities, by some divine portion, actually engage in philosophy. This was my thinking when I arrived in Italy¹⁵ and Sicily for my first visit. When I got there, the so-called ‘happy life’, replete with Italian and Syracusan banquets, did not please me at all. They live their lives, gorging themselves on food twice a day, never sleeping alone at night. For with such habits as these no human being under heaven could ever become wise, nor could anyone ever become sound-minded.

διοικεῖν· οὔτε γὰρ ἄνευ φίλων ἀνδρῶν καὶ ἐταίρων πιστῶν οἷόν τ' εἶναι πράττειν—οὓς οὐθ' ὑπάρχοντας ἦν εὐρεῖν εὐπετές, οὐ γὰρ ἔτι ἐν τοῖς τῶν πατέρων ἦθεσιν καὶ ἐπιτηδεύμασιν ἡ πόλις ἡμῶν διωκεῖτο, καινούς τε ἄλλους ἀδύνατον ἦν κτᾶσθαι μετὰ τινος ῥαστώνης—τά τε τῶν νόμων γράμματα καὶ ἔθη διεφθείρετο καὶ ἐπεδίδου θαυμαστὸν ὅσον, ὥστε με, τὸ πρῶτον πολλῆς μεστὸν ὄντα ὁρμῆς ἐπὶ τὸ πράττειν τὰ κοινά, βλέποντα εἰς ταῦτα καὶ φερόμενα ὀρῶντα πάντη πάντως, τελευτῶντα ἱλιγγιᾶν, καὶ τοῦ μὲν σκοπεῖν μὴ ἀποστήναι μὴ ποτε ἄμεινον ἂν γίγνοιτο περὶ τε αὐτὰ ταῦτα καὶ δὴ καὶ περὶ τὴν πᾶσαν πολιτείαν, τοῦ δὲ πράττειν αὖ περιμένειν ἀεὶ καιροῦς, τελευτῶντα δὲ

νοῆσαι περὶ πασῶν τῶν νῦν πόλεων ὅτι κακῶς σύμψασαι πολιτεύονται—τὰ γὰρ τῶν νόμων αὐταῖς σχεδὸν ἀνιάτως ἔχοντά ἐστιν ἄνευ παρασκευῆς θαυμαστῆς τινος μετὰ τύχης—λέγειν τε ἠναγκάσθην, ἐπαινῶν τὴν ὀρθὴν φιλοσοφίαν, ὡς ἐκ ταύτης ἔστιν τὰ τε πολιτικὰ δίκαια καὶ τὰ τῶν ἰδιωτῶν πάντα κατιδεῖν· κακῶν οὖν οὐ λήξειν τὰ ἀνθρώπινα γένη, πρὶν ἂν ἡ τῶν φιλοσοφούντων ὀρθῶς γε καὶ ἀληθῶς γένος εἰς ἀρχὰς ἔλθῃ τὰς πολιτικάς ἢ τὸ τῶν δυναστευόντων ἐν ταῖς πόλεσιν ἔκ τινος μοίρας θείας ὄντως φιλοσοφήσῃ. ταύτην δὴ τὴν διάνοιαν ἔχων εἰς Ἱταλίαν τε καὶ Σικελίαν ἦλθον, ὅτε πρῶτον ἀφικόμην. ἐλθόντα δέ με ὁ ταύτῃ λεγόμενος αὖ βίος εὐδαίμων, Ἱταλιωτικῶν τε καὶ Συρακουσίων τραπεζῶν πλήρης, οὐδαμῇ οὐδαμῶς ἥρπεν, δῖς τε τῆς ἡμέρας ἐμπιμπλάμενον ζῆν καὶ μηδέποτε κοιμώμενον μόνον νύκτωρ, καὶ ὅσα τούτῳ ἐπιτηδεύματα συνέπεται τῷ βίῳ· ἐκ γὰρ τούτων τῶν ἔθων οὗτ' ἂν φρόνιμος οὐδεὶς ποτε γενέσθαι τῶν ὑπὸ τὸν οὐρανὸν ἀνθρώπων ἐκ νέου ἐπιτηδεύων δύναιτο—οὐχ οὕτως θαυμαστῇ φύσει κραθήσεται—σώφρων δὲ οὐδ' ἂν μελλῆσαι ποτὲ γενέσθαι, καὶ δὴ καὶ περὶ τῆς ἄλλης ἀρετῆς ὁ αὐτὸς λόγος ἂν εἴη, πόλις τε οὐδεμία ἂν ἡρεμήσῃ κατὰ νόμους οὐδ' οὐστινασοῦν ἀνδρῶν οἰομένων ἀναλίσκειν μὲν δεῖν πάντα εἰς ὑπερβολάς, ἀργῶν δὲ εἰς ἅπαντα ἡγουμένων αὖ δεῖν γίγνεσθαι πλὴν ἐς εὐωχίας καὶ πότους καὶ ἀφροδισίων σπουδὰς διαπονουμένας· ἀναγκαῖον δὲ εἶναι ταύτας τὰς πόλεις τυραννίδας τε καὶ ὀλιγαρχίας καὶ δημοκρατίας μεταβαλλούσας μηδέποτε λήγειν, δικαίου δὲ καὶ ἰσονόμου πολιτείας τοὺς ἐν αὐταῖς δυναστεύοντας μηδ' ὄνομα ἀκούοντας ἀνέχεσθαι. ταῦτα δὴ πρὸς τοῖς πρόσθε διανοοῦμενος, εἰς Συρακούσας

326e

Holding these views as well as the earlier ones, I travelled to Syracuse, perhaps by chance, although it seems that some higher power then set in train the events which have now unfolded concerning Dion and Syracuse. When I met Dion, who was young at the time, and I explained in discussion what I believed to be best for humanity, and advised him to act on these precepts, I seemed unaware that I was somehow or other bringing about the impending overthrow of the tyranny

without appreciating what I was doing. Now, Dion learnt very easily in general, and he listened with more keen attention than any young person I have ever come across to the subjects that my discourses dealt with. And he was willing to live the rest of his life in a different way from most of the Italians and Sicilians, for he had come to cherish excellence more than pleasure and general luxury.

διεπορεύθην, ἴσως μὲν κατὰ τύχην, ἔοικεν μὴν τότε μηχανωμένῳ τινὶ τῶν κρειττόνων ἀρχὴν βαλέσθαι τῶν νῦν γεγονότων πραγμάτων περὶ Δίωνα καὶ τῶν περὶ Συρακούσας· δέος δὲ μὴ καὶ πλειόνων ἔτι, ἐὰν μὴ νῦν ὑμεῖς ἐμοὶ πείθησθε τὸ δεύτερον συμβουλευόντι. πῶς οὖν δὴ λέγω πάντων ἀρχὴν γεγενῆσθαι τὴν τότε εἰς Σικελίαν ἐμὴν ἄφιξιν; ἐγὼ συγγενόμενος Δίῳνι τότε νέῳ κινδυνεύω, τὰ δοκοῦντα ἐμοὶ βέλτιστα ἀνθρώποις εἶναι μηνύων διὰ λόγων καὶ πράττειν αὐτὰ συμβουλευών, ἀγνοεῖν ὅτι τυραννίδος τινὰ τρόπον κατάλυσιν ἐσομένην μηχανώμενος ἐλάνθανον ἐμαυτόν. Δίῳν μὲν γὰρ δὴ, μάλ' εὐμαθὴς ὢν πρὸς τε τᾶλλα καὶ πρὸς τοὺς τότε ὑπ' ἐμοῦ λόγους γενομένους, οὕτως ὀξέως ὑπήκουσεν καὶ σφόδρα, ὥς οὐδεὶς πώποτε ὢν ἐγὼ προσέτυχον νέων, καὶ τὸν ἐπίλοιπον βίον ζῆν ἠθέλησεν διαφερόντως τῶν πολλῶν Ἰταλιωτῶν τε καὶ Σικελιωτῶν, ἀρετὴν περὶ πλείονος ἡδονῆς τῆς τε ἄλλης τρυφῆς ἡγαπηκώς· ὅθεν ἐπαχθέστερον τοῖς περὶ τὰ τυραννικά νόμιμα ζῶσιν ἐβίω μέχρι τοῦ θανάτου τοῦ περὶ Διονύσιον γενομένου. μετὰ δὲ τοῦτο διειροήθη μὴ μόνον ἐν αὐτῷ ποτ' ἂν γενέσθαι ταύτην τὴν διάνοιαν, ἣν

327c

After this, Dion concluded that such thinking, which he himself had arrived at through proper discourse, would not always be confined to himself. He thought that Dionysius might perhaps, with the assistance of the gods, become one of those who pursued such thinking. What's more, if such a development took place, the result would be a life of unbounded blessedness for himself and the rest of the Syracusans. Furthermore, Dion thought I should, by all means, get to Syracuse as soon as possible to join him in these endeavours. His request went as follows: "What greater opportunities are we waiting for than those

that have now been presented by some divine good fortune?" He described in detail the Italian and Sicilian empire, and his own influence therein, how young Dionysius was, and the intense desire he had for philosophy and education.

αὐτὸς ὑπὸ τῶν ὀρθῶν λόγων ἔσχεν, ἐγγιγνομένην δὲ αὐτὴν καὶ ἐν ἄλλοις ὁρῶν κατενόει, πολλοῖς μὲν οὐ, γιγνομένην δ' οὖν ἐν τισιν, ὧν καὶ Διονύσιον ἡγήσατο ἓνα γενέσθαι τάχ' ἂν συλλαμβανόντων θεῶν, γενομένου δ' αὖ τοῦ τοιούτου τόν τε αὐτοῦ βίον καὶ τὸν τῶν ἄλλων Συρακουσίων ἀμύχανον ἂν μακαριότητι συμβῆναι γενόμενον. πρὸς δὴ τούτοις ῥήθη δεῖν ἐκ παντὸς τρόπου εἰς Συρακούσας ὅτι τάχιστα ἐλθεῖν ἐμὲ κοινωνὸν τούτων, μεμνημένος τήν τε αὐτοῦ καὶ ἐμὴν συνουσίαν ὡς εὐπετῶς ἐξηργάσατο εἰς ἐπιθυμίαν ἐλθεῖν αὐτὸν τοῦ καλλίστου τε καὶ ἀρίστου βίου· ὃ δὴ καὶ νῦν εἰ διαπράξαιτο ἐν Διονυσίῳ ὡς ἐπεχείρησε, μεγάλας ἐλπίδας εἶχεν ἄνευ σφαγῶν καὶ θανάτων καὶ τῶν νῦν γεγονότων κακῶν βίον ἂν εὐδαίμονα καὶ ἀληθινὸν ἐν πάσῃ τῇ χώρᾳ κατασκευάσαι. ταῦτα δίων ὀρθῶς διανοηθεὶς ἔπεισε μεταπέμπεσθαι Διονύσιον ἐμέ, καὶ αὐτὸς ἐδεῖτο πέμπων ἡκεῖν ὅτι τάχιστα ἐκ παντὸς τρόπου, πρὶν τινὰς ἄλλους ἐντυχόντας Διονυσίῳ ἐπ' ἄλλον βίον αὐτὸν τοῦ βελτίστου παρατρέψαι. λέγων δὲ τάδε ἐδεῖτο, εἰ καὶ μακρότερα εἰπεῖν. τίνας γὰρ καιροὺς, ἔφη, μείζους περιμενοῦμεν τῶν νῦν παραγεγονότων θεῖα τινὶ τύχῃ; καταλέγων δὲ τήν τε ἀρχὴν τῆς Ἰταλίας καὶ Σικελίας

328a

In the end I decided on balance that it was necessary to go. If anyone was ever to attempt to implement those thoughts about laws and political systems, now was the time to make the attempt, for by sufficiently convincing just one person, I would have brought about all sorts of benefits. Emboldened by this thinking, I sailed away from my homeland, most of all from a sense of shame on my own part in case I might seem to myself, well and truly, to be some mere word, unwilling to engage in any action whatsoever. By going, I freed myself in the eyes of Zeus, the god of strangers, and put myself beyond reproach on the part of philosophy, which would have been criticised had I disgraced

myself through weakness of spirit and base cowardice. On arrival, to keep the story short, I found the circle around Dionysius full of all sorts of faction and slanders brought to the regime against Dion.

καὶ τὴν αὐτοῦ δύναμιν ἐν αὐτῇ, καὶ τὴν νεότητα καὶ τὴν ἐπιθυμίαν τὴν Διονυσίου, φιλοσοφίας τε καὶ παιδείας ὥς ἔχοι σφόδρα λέγων, τοὺς τε αὐτοῦ ἀδελφιδοῦς καὶ τοὺς οἰκείους ὥς εὐπαράκλητοι εἶεν πρὸς τὸν ὑπ' ἐμοῦ λεγόμενον αἰὲ λόγον καὶ βίον, ἱκανώτατοί τε Διονύσιον συμπαρακαλεῖν, ὥστε εἴπερ ποτὲ καὶ νῦν ἐλπίς πᾶσα ἀποτελεσθήσεται τοῦ τοὺς αὐτοὺς φιλοσόφους τε καὶ πόλεων ἄρχοντας μεγάλων συμβῆναι γενομένους. τὰ μὲν δὴ παρακελεύματα ἦν ταῦτά τε καὶ τοιαῦτα ἕτερα ἀμύπολλα, τὴν δ' ἐμὴν δόξαν τὸ μὲν περὶ τῶν νέων, ὅπῃ ποτὲ γενήσοιτο, εἶχεν φόβος—αἱ γὰρ ἐπιθυμίαι τῶν τοιούτων ταχεῖαι καὶ πολλάκις ἑαυταῖς ἐναντίαι φερόμεναι—τὸ δὲ Δίωνος ἦθος ἡπιστάμην τῆς ψυχῆς περὶ φύσει τε ἐμβριθεὶς ὃν ἡλικίας τε ἤδη μετρίως ἔχον. ὅθεν μοι σκοπούμενῳ καὶ διστάζοντι πότερον εἴη πορευτέον καὶ ὑπακουστέον ἢ πῶς, ὅμως ἔρρεψε δεῖν, εἴ ποτέ τις τὰ διανοηθέντα περὶ νόμων τε καὶ πολιτείας ἀποτελεῖν ἐγχειρήσοι, καὶ νῦν πειρατέον εἶναι· πείσας γὰρ ἓνα μόνον ἱκανῶς πάντα ἐξειργασμένος ἐσοίμην ἀγαθὰ. ταύτῃ μὲν δὴ τῇ διανοίᾳ τε καὶ τόλμῃ ἀπῆρα οἴκοθεν, οὐχ ἢ τινες ἐδόξαζον, ἀλλ' αἰσχυνόμενος μὲν ἑμαυτὸν τὸ μέγιστον, μὴ δόξαιμί ποτε ἑμαυτῷ παντάπασι λόγος μόνον ἀτεχνῶς εἶναι τίς, ἔργου δὲ οὐδενὸς ἄν ποτε ἐκὼν ἀνθάψασθαι, κινδυνεύσειν δὲ προδοῦναι πρῶτον μὲν τὴν Δίωνος ξενίαν τε καὶ ἐταιρίαν ἐν κινδύνοις ὄντως γεγονότος οὐ σμικροῖς. εἴτ' οὖν πάθοι τι, εἴτ' ἐκπεσὼν ὑπὸ Διονυσίου καὶ τῶν ἄλλων ἐχθρῶν ἔλθοι παρ' ἡμᾶς φεύγων καὶ ἀνέροιτο εἰπὼν ὦ Πλάτων, ἦκω σοι φυγὰς οὐχ ὀπλιτῶν δεόμενος οὐδὲ ἱππέων ἐνδεὴς γενόμενος τοῦ ἀμύνασθαι τοὺς ἐχθρούς, ἀλλὰ λόγων καὶ πειθοῦς, ἥ σὲ μάλιστα ἡπιστάμην ἐγὼ δυνάμενον ἀνθρώπους νέους ἐπὶ τὰ ἀγαθὰ καὶ τὰ δίκαια προτρέποντα εἰς φιλίαν τε καὶ ἐταιρίαν ἀλλήλοις καθιστάναί ἐκάστοτε· ὦν ἐνδεία κατὰ τὸ σὸν μέρος νῦν ἐγὼ καταλιπὼν Συρακούσας ἐνθάδε πάρειμι. καὶ τὸ μὲν ἐμὸν ἔλαττον ὄνειδός σοι φέρει· φιλοσοφία δέ, ἣν ἐγκωμιάζεις αἰὲ καὶ ἀτίμως φῆς ὑπὸ τῶν λοιπῶν ἀνθρώπων φέρεσθαι, πῶς οὐ προδέδοται τὰ νῦν μετ' ἐμοῦ μέρος ὅσον ἐπὶ σοὶ γέγονεν; καὶ

Μεγαροῖ μὲν εἰ κατοικοῦντες ἐτυχάνομεν, ἦλθες δὴπου ἂν μοι βοηθὸς ἐφ' ᾧ σε παρεκάλουν, ἢ πάντων ἂν φαυλότατον ἡγοῦ σαυτόν· νῦν δ' ἄρα τὸ μῆκος τῆς πορείας καὶ τὸ μέγεθος δὴ τοῦ πλοῦ καὶ τοῦ πόνου ἐπαιτιώμενος οἶει δόξαν κακίας ἀποφευγεῖσθαι ποτε; πολλοῦ καὶ δεήσει. λεχθέντων δὲ τούτων τίς ἂν ἦν μοι πρὸς ταῦτα εὐσχήμων ἀπόκρισις; οὐκ ἔστιν. ἀλλ' ἦλθον μὲν κατὰ λόγον ἐν δίκη τε ὡς οἶόν τε ἀνθρώπῳ μάλιστα, διὰ τε τὰ τοιαῦτα καταλιπὼν τὰς ἐμαυτοῦ διατριβάς, οὔσας οὐκ ἀσχήμονας, ὑπὸ τυραννίδα δοκοῦσαν οὐ πρόπειν τοῖς ἐμοῖς λόγοις οὐδὲ ἐμοί· ἐλθὼν τε ἐμαυτὸν ἡλευθέρωσα Διὸς ξενίου καὶ τῆς φιλοσόφου ἀνέγκλητον μοίρας παρέσχον, ἐπονειδίστου γενομένης ἂν, εἴ τι καταμαλθακισθεὶς καὶ ἀποδειλιῶν αἰσχύνης μετέσχον κακῆς. ἐλθὼν δέ—οὐ γὰρ δεῖ μῆκύνειν—ἡῦρον στάσεως τὰ περὶ Διονύσιον μεστὰ σύμπαντα καὶ διαβολῶν

329c

Although I defended him to the best of my ability, there was little I could do. And within four months or so, Dionysius accused Dion of plotting against his tyranny, put him on a small boat, and expelled him ignominiously. After this, we, the friends of Dion, were afraid that one of us might be accused and punished for being an accomplice in Dion's plot. Being aware of how we felt, Dionysius received us all in a kindly spirit, and he reassured myself in particular, encouraging me to take heart and asking me in all sorts of ways to remain. For my departure from him would not have been to his credit, but my remaining with him would have been, and that is why he made a great pretence of imploring me to stay.

πρὸς τὴν τυραννίδα Δίωνος πέρι· ἡμυνον μὲν οὖν καθ' ὅσον ἡδυνάμην, σμικρὰ δ' οἷός τ' ἦ, μηνὶ δὲ σχεδὸν ἴσως τετάρτῳ Δίωνα Διονύσιος αἰτιώμενος ἐπιβουλεύειν τῇ τυραννίδι, σμικρὸν εἰς πλοῖον ἐμβιβάσας, ἐξέβαλεν ἀτίμως. οἱ δὲ Δίωνος τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο πάντες φίλοι ἐφοβούμεθα μή τινα ἐπαιτιώμενος τιμωροῖτο ὡς συναίτιον τῆς Δίωνος ἐπιβουλῆς· περὶ δ' ἐμοῦ καὶ διῆλθε λόγος τις ἐν Συρακούσαις, ὡς τεθνεὼς εἶην ὑπὸ Διονυσίου τούτων ὡς πάντων τῶν τότε γεγονότων αἵτιος. ὁ δὲ αἰσθανόμενος πάντας ἡμᾶς οὕτω διατεθέντας, φοβούμενος

μη μεῖζον ἐκ τῶν φόβων γένοιτό τι, φιλοφρόνως πάντας ἀνελάμβανεν, καὶ δὴ καὶ τὸν ἐμὲ παρεμυθεῖτό τε καὶ θαρρεῖν διεκελεύετο καὶ ἐδεῖτο πάντως μένειν· ἐγίγνετο γάρ οἱ τὸ μὲν ἐμὲ φυγεῖν ἀπ’ αὐτοῦ καλὸν οὐδέν, τὸ δὲ μένειν—διὸ δὴ καὶ σφόδρα προσεποιεῖτο δεῖσθαι. τὰς δὲ τῶν τυράννων δεήσεις ἴσμεν ὅτι μεμειγμέναι ἀνάγκαις

329e

But we know that the requests of tyrants are always mixed with compulsion, and so he made arrangements to prevent my departure, bringing me to the acropolis and housing me where no ship's captain would take me away, unless Dionysius himself sent them a written instruction to do so. As time went on, Dionysius became steadily more affectionate as he grew familiar with my manner and character, and he wanted me to praise him more than Dion and to regard him as a more special friend than Dion. But he was reluctant to learn discourses concerning philosophy in close company with myself, fearing the words of the slanderers. I endured all this, preserving my initial thinking with which I had arrived in Sicily, hoping that he would somehow come to desire the life of philosophy, but he succeeded in resisting this.

εἰσίν—ὁ δὴ μηχανώμενος διεκώλυέν μου τὸν ἔκπλουν, εἰς ἀκρόπολιν ἀγαγὼν καὶ κατοικίσας ὅθεν οὐδ’ ἂν εἷς ἔτι με ναύκληρος μὴ ὅτι κωλύοντος ἐξήγαγε Διονυσίου, ἀλλ’ οὐδ’ εἰ μὴ πέμπων αὐτὸς τὸν κελεύοντα ἐξαγαγεῖν ἐπέστελλεν, οὔτ’ ἂν ἔμπορος οὔτε τῶν ἐν ταῖς τῆς χώρας ἐξόδοις ἀρχόντων οὐδ’ ἂν εἷς περιεῖδέν με μόνον ἐκπορευόμενον, ὃς οὐκ ἂν συλλαβὼν εὐθέως παρὰ Διονύσιον πάλιν ἀπήγαγεν, ἄλλως τε καὶ διηγγελμένον ἤδη ποτὲ τοῦναντίον ἢ τὸ πρότερον πάλιν, ὥς Πλάτωνα Διονύσιος θαυμαστῶς ὥς ἀσπάζεται. τὸ δ’ εἶχεν δὴ πῶς; τὸ γὰρ ἀληθὲς δεῖ φράζειν. ἡσπάζετο μὲν αἰεὶ προϊόντος τοῦ χρόνου μᾶλλον κατὰ τὴν τοῦ τρόπου τε καὶ ἡθους συνουσίαν, ἑαυτὸν δὲ ἐπαινεῖν μᾶλλον ἢ Δίωνα ἐβούλετό με καὶ φίλον ἡγεῖσθαι διαφερόντως μᾶλλον ἢ ἑκείνον, καὶ θαυμαστῶς ἐφιλονίκηκε πρὸς τὸ τοιοῦτον· ἢ δ’ ἂν οὕτως ἐγένετο, εἴπερ ἐγίγνετο, κάλλιστα, ὥκνει ὥς δὴ μανθάνων καὶ ἀκούων τῶν περὶ φιλοσοφίαν λόγων οἰκτιροῦσθαι καὶ

ἐμοὶ συγγίγνεσθαι, φοβούμενος τοὺς τῶν διαβαλλόντων λόγους, μή πη παραποδοισθεῖη καὶ δίων δὴ πάντα εἶη διαπεπραγμένος. ἐγὼ δὲ πάντα ὑπέμενον, τὴν πρώτην διάνοιαν φυλάττων ἥπερ ἀφικόμεν, εἴ πως εἰς ἐπιθυμίαν ἔλθοι τῆς φιλοσόφου ζωῆς· ὁ δ' ἐνίκησεν ἀντιτείνων. καὶ ὁ πρῶτος δὴ χρόνος τῆς εἰς Σικελίαν ἐμῆς ἐπιδημίας

330c

These were all the circumstances involved in my visit to Sicily and my activities there on the first occasion. After this I departed, only to return once more at the most urgent request of Dionysius. But first I am to advise you about what you should do under the present circumstances. When advising a sick man whose lifestyle is injurious to his health, isn't it necessary in the first place to effect a change in his way of life, and give the rest of the advice only when he is willing to comply? But if he proves unwilling, I would regard someone who stops advising such a person as a manly physician, while someone who persists, I regard as an unmanly, unskilled physician. And the same holds for a city. But there are people who go completely away from the correct political system and have no desire whatsoever to follow in its path. They warn any adviser to leave the system as it is and not to disturb it, or they will put him to death. Anyone who persists in advising such people I regard as unmanly, and those who do not persist I regard as manly.

τε καὶ διατριβῆς διὰ πάντα ταῦτα συνέβη γενόμενος. μετὰ δὲ τοῦτο ἀπεδήμησά τε καὶ πάλιν ἀφικόμεν πάσῃ σπουδῇ μεταπεμπομένου Διονυσίου· ὧν δὲ ἔνεκα καὶ ὅσα ἔπραξα, ὡς εἰκότα τε καὶ δίκαια, ὑμῖν πρῶτον μὲν συμβουλευσας ἃ χρὴ ποιεῖν ἐκ τῶν νῦν γεγονότων, ὕστερον τὰ περὶ ταῦτα διέξειμι, τῶν ἐπανερωτώντων ἔνεκα τί δὴ βουλόμενος ἦλθον τὸ δεύτερον, ἵνα μὴ τὰ πάρεργα ὡς ἔργα μοι συμβαίνει λεγόμενα. λέγω δὴ τάδε ἐγώ—τὸν συμβουλευόντα ἀνδρὶ κάμνοντι καὶ δίκαιαν διαιτωμένῳ μοχθηρὰν πρὸς ὑγίειαν ἄλλο τι χρὴ πρῶτον μὲν μεταβάλλειν τὸν βίον, καὶ ἐθέλοντι μὲν πείθεσθαι καὶ τᾶλλα ἤδη παραινεῖν· μὴ ἐθέλοντι δέ, φεύγοντα ἀπὸ τῆς τοῦ τοιούτου συμβουλῆς ἄνδρα τε ἡγοίμην ἂν καὶ ἰατρικόν, τὸν δὲ ὑπομένοντα

τοῦναντίον ἄνανδρόν τε καὶ ἄτεχνον. ταῦτόν δὴ καὶ πόλει, εἴτε αὐτῆς εἷς εἴῃ κύριος εἴτε καὶ πλείους, εἰ μὲν κατὰ τρόπον ὀρθῇ πορευομένης ὁδῷ τῆς πολιτείας συμβουλευοιτό τι τῶν προσφόρων, νοῦν ἔχοντος τὸ τοῖς τοιούτοις συμβουλεύειν τοῖς δ' ἔξω τὸ παράπαν βαίνουσι τῆς ὀρθῆς πολιτείας καὶ μηδαμῇ ἐθέλουσιν αὐτῆς εἰς ἵχνος ἰέναι, προαγορεύουσιν δὲ τῷ συμβούλῳ τὴν μὲν πολιτείαν ἔαν καὶ μὴ κινεῖν, ὥς ἀποθανουμένῳ ἔαν κινῇ, ταῖς δὲ βουλήσεσιν καὶ ἐπιθυμίαις αὐτῶν ὑπηρετοῦντας συμβουλεύειν κελεύοιεν, τίνα τρόπον γίγνοιτ' ἂν ῥᾶστά τε καὶ τάχιστα εἰς τὸν αἰεὶ χρόνον, τὸν μὲν ὑπομένοντα συμβουλὰς τοιαύτας ἡγοίμην ἂν ἄνανδρον, τὸν δ' οὐχ ὑπομένοντα ἄνδρα. ταύτην δὴ τὴν διάνοιαν ἐγὼ κεκτημένος, ὅταν τίς μοι συμβουλευῇται περὶ τίνος τῶν μεγίστων περὶ τὸν αὐτοῦ βίον, οἷον περὶ χρημάτων κτήσεως ἢ περὶ σώματος ἢ ψυχῆς ἐπιμελείας, ἂν μὲν μοι τὸ καθ' ἡμέραν ἔν τινι τρόπῳ δοκῇ ζῆν ἢ συμβουλεύσαντος ἂν ἐθέλῃν πείθεσθαι περὶ ὧν ἀνακοινοῦται, προθύμως συμβουλεύω καὶ οὐκ ἀφοσιωσάμενος μόνον ἐπαυσάμην. ἔαν δὲ μὴ συμβουλευῇται μοι τὸ παράπαν ἢ συμβουλεύοντι δῆλος ἢ μηδαμῇ πεισόμενος, αὐτόκλητος ἐπὶ τὸν τοιοῦτον οὐκ ἔρχομαι συμβουλεύσων, βιασόμενος δὲ οὐδ' ἂν ὑὸς ἦ μου. δούλῳ δὲ συμβουλεύσαιμ' ἂν καὶ μὴ ἐθέλοντά γε προσβιάζοίμην·

331c

This, indeed, is the manner in which I would advise you, just as I, along with Dion, advised Dionysius, telling him firstly to live each day of his life in such a way as to be, most of all, master of himself, possessed of trustworthy friends and companions. This would ensure that he did not suffer the same fate as his own father, who annexed many great Sicilian cities that had been plundered by the non-Greeks, but was unable when he had colonised them to establish reliable political systems in any of them composed of men who were comrades. And there is no greater indicator of one's excellence or lack of excellence than being bereft of such people or not.

πατέρα δὲ ἢ μητέρα οὐχ ὅσιον ἡγοῦμαι προσβιάζεσθαι μὴ νόσῳ παραφροσύνης ἐχομένους, ἔαν δέ τινα καθεστῶτα ζῶσι βίον, ἑαυτοῖς ἀρέσκοντα, ἐμοὶ δὲ μή, μήτε ἀπεχθάνεσθαι μάτην νουθετοῦντα μήτε δὴ

κολακεύοντά γε ὑπηρετεῖν αὐτοῖς, πληρώσεις ἐπιθυμιῶν ἐκπορίζοντα ἄς αὐτὸς ἀσπαζόμενος οὐκ ἂν ἐθέλοιμι ζῆν. ταῦτὸν δὴ καὶ περὶ πόλεως αὐτοῦ διανοούμενον χρή ζῆν τὸν ἔμφρονα· λέγειν μὲν, εἰ μὴ καλῶς αὐτῷ φαίνοιτο πολιτεύεσθαι, εἰ μέλλοι μῆτε ματαίως ἐρεῖν μῆτε ἀποθανεῖσθαι λέγων, βίαν δὲ πατρίδι πολιτείας μεταβολῆς μὴ προσφέρειν, ὅταν ἄνευ φυγῆς καὶ σφαγῆς ἀνδρῶν μὴ δυνατόν ᾖ γίγνεσθαι τὴν ἀρίστην, ἡσυχίαν δὲ ἄγοντα εὐχεσθαι τὰ ἀγαθὰ αὐτῷ τε καὶ τῇ πόλει. κατὰ δὴ τοῦτον τὸν τρόπον ἐγὼ ὑμῖν τ' ἂν συμβουλευόιμι, συνεβούλευον δὲ καὶ Διονυσίῳ μετὰ Δίωνος, ζῆν μὲν τὸ καθ' ἡμέραν πρῶτον, ὅπως ἐγκρατῆς αὐτὸς αὐτοῦ ὅτι μάλιστα ἔσσεσθαι μέλλοι καὶ πιστοὺς φίλους τε καὶ ἐταίρους κτήσεσθαι, ὅπως μὴ πάθοι ἅπερ ὁ πατὴρ αὐτοῦ, ὃς παραλαβὼν Σικελίας πολλὰς καὶ μεγάλας πόλεις ὑπὸ τῶν βαρβάρων ἐκπεπορημένας, οὐχ οἷός τ' ἦν κατοικίσας πολιτείας ἐν ἐκάσταις καταστήσασθαι πιστὰς ἐταίρων ἀνδρῶν, οὔτε ἄλλων δὴ ποθεν ὀθνεῖων οὔτε ἀδελφῶν, οὓς ἔθρεψέν τε αὐτὸς νεωτέρους ὄντας, ἔκ τε ἰδιωτῶν ἄρχοντας καὶ ἐκ πενήτων πλουσίους ἐπεποιήκει διαφερόντως. τούτων κοινωνὸν τῆς ἀρχῆς οὐδένα οἷός τ' ἦν πειθοῖ καὶ διδαχῇ καὶ εὐεργεσίαις καὶ συγγενείαις ἀπεργασάμενος ποιήσασθαι, Δαρείου δὲ ἐπταπλασίῳ φαυλότερος ἐγένετο, ὃς οὐκ ἀδελφοῖς πιστεύσας οὐδ' ὑφ' αὐτοῦ τραφεῖσιν, κοινωνοῖς δὲ μόνον τῆς τοῦ Μήδου τε καὶ εὐνούχου χειρώσεως, διένειμέ τε μέρη μείζω ἕκαστα Σικελίας πάσης ἐπτά, καὶ πιστοῖς ἐχρήσατο τοῖς κοινωνοῖς καὶ οὐκ ἐπιτιθεμένοις οὔτε αὐτῷ οὔτε ἀλλήλοις, ἔδειξεν τε παράδειγμα οἷον χρή τὸν νομοθέτην καὶ βασιλέα τὸν ἀγαθὸν γίγνεσθαι νόμους γὰρ κατασκευάσας ἔτι καὶ νῦν διασέσωκεν τὴν Περσῶν ἀρχήν. ἔτι δὲ Ἀθηναῖοι πρὸς τούτοις, οὐκ αὐτοὶ κατοικίσαντες, πολλὰς τῶν Ἑλλήνων πόλεις ὑπὸ βαρβάρων ἐμβεβλημένας ἀλλ' οἰκουμένας παραλαβόντες, ὅμως ἐβδομήκοντα ἔτη διεφύλαξαν τὴν ἀρχὴν ἄνδρας φίλους ἐν ταῖς πόλεσιν ἐκάσταις κεκτημένοι. Διονύσιος δὲ εἰς μίαν πόλιν ἀθροίσας πᾶσαν Σικελίαν, ὑπὸ σοφίας πιστεύων οὐδενί, μόγις ἐσώθη· πένης γὰρ ἦν ἀνδρῶν φίλων καὶ πιστῶν, οὗ μείζον σημεῖον εἰς ἀρετὴν καὶ κακίαν οὐκ ἔστιν οὐδέν, τοῦ ἔρημον ἢ μὴ τοιούτων ἀνδρῶν εἶναι. ἃ δὴ καὶ Διονυσίῳ συνεβουλεύομεν ἐγὼ καὶ Δίων, ἐπειδὴ τὰ παρὰ τοῦ πατρὸς

332d

Since this was what had happened to his father, myself and Dion gave this advice to Dionysius, who had had no exposure to education or to appropriate company in the first place. He was advised to acquire other friends for himself from among his kindred, friends of a similar age with an affinity for excellence. But he was advised above all to acquire such affinity for himself, for he was remarkably deficient in this. Without speaking in such plain terms, for it was unsafe to do so, we hinted at this, and we maintained in argument that this is how any man is to save himself and those for whom he is responsible. Proceeding as we suggested, if he were then to colonise the abandoned Sicilian cities and bind them to himself and to one another against the leagues of non-Greeks, we told him that he would not merely double the size of his father's empire, but actually make it many times larger.

αὐτῷ συνεβεβήκει οὕτως, ἀνομιλήτῳ μὲν παιδείας, ἀνομιλήτῳ δὲ συνουσιῶν τῶν προσηκουσῶν γεγονέναι, πρῶτον ἔπειτα ταύτῃ ὀρμήσαντα φίλους ἄλλους αὐτῷ τῶν οἰκείων ἅμα καὶ ἡλικιωτῶν καὶ συμφώνους πρὸς ἀρετὴν κτήσασθαι, μάλιστα δ' αὐτὸν αὐτῷ, τούτου γὰρ αὐτὸν θαυμαστῶς ἐνδεᾶ γεγονέναι, λέγοντες οὐκ ἐναργῶς οὕτως —οὐ γὰρ ἦν ἀσφαλές— αἰνιττόμενοι δὲ καὶ διαμαχόμενοι τοῖς λόγοις ὥς οὕτω μὲν πᾶς ἀνὴρ αὐτόν τε καὶ ἐκείνους ὧν ἂν ἡγεμῶν γίγνηται σώσει, μὴ ταύτῃ δὲ τραπόμενος τάναντία πάντα ἀποτελεῖ πορευθεὶς δὲ ὥς λέγομεν, καὶ ἑαυτὸν ἔμφρονα τε καὶ σώφρονα ἀπεργασάμενος, εἰ τὰς ἐξηρηλωμένας Σικελίας πόλεις κατοικήσειεν νόμοις τε συνδήσειεν καὶ πολιτείαις, ὥστε αὐτῷ τε οἰκείας καὶ ἀλλήλαις εἶναι πρὸς τὰς τῶν βαρβάρων βοηθείας, οὐ διπλασίαν τὴν πατρῶαν ἀρχὴν μόνον ποιήσοι, πολλαπλασίαν δὲ ὄντως· ἔτοιμον γὰρ εἶναι τούτων γενομένων πολὺ μᾶλλον δουλώσασθαι Καρχηδονίους τῆς ἐπὶ Γέλωνος αὐτοῖς γενομένης δουλείας, ἄλλ' οὐχ ὥσπερ νῦν τούναντίον ὁ πατὴρ αὐτοῦ φόρον ἐτάξατο φέρειν τοῖς βαρβάροις. ταῦτα ἦν τὰ λεγόμενα καὶ παρακελεύόμενα ὑφ' ἡμῶν τῶν ἐπιβουλευόντων Διονυσίῳ, ὥς πολλαχόθεν ἐχώρουν οἱ τοιοῦτοι λόγοι, οἳ δὴ καὶ κρατήσαντες παρὰ Διονυσίῳ ἐξέβαλον μὲν Δίωνα, ἡμᾶς

333b

These were the words of exhortation to Dionysius from ourselves, who, according to reports pouring in from all quarters, were conspiring against him. Such reports eventually led to Dionysius' expulsion of Dion, and put us in a state of fear. Now, to deal briefly with a number of events, when Dion returned from the Peloponnese and Athens he taught Dionysius a practical lesson. When Dion had liberated the Syracusans and given them back their city on two occasions, they had the same attitude towards him as Dionysius had when Dion tried to educate him and train him to be a king worthy of authority. These allegations prevailed for the second time among the Syracusans, and their prevalence was a bizarre and shameful victory for those who were responsible for this.

δ' εἰς φόβον κατέβαλον· ἵνα δ' ἐκπεράνωμεν οὐκ ὀλίγα πράγματα τὰ ἐν ὀλίγῳ χρόνῳ, ἐλθὼν ἐκ Πελοποννήσου καὶ Ἀθηνῶν δίῳν ἔργῳ τὸν Διονύσιον ἐνουθέτησεν. ἐπειδὴ δ' οὖν ἡλευθέρωσέν τε καὶ ἀπέδωκεν αὐτοῖς δις τὴν πόλιν, ταῦτόν πρὸς Δίῳνα Συρακόσιοι τότε ἔπαθον ὅπερ καὶ Διονύσιος, ὅτε αὐτὸν ἐπεχειρεῖ παιδεύσας καὶ θρέψας βασιλέα τῆς ἀρχῆς ἄξιον, οὕτω κοινωνεῖν αὐτῷ τοῦ βίου παντός, ὁ δὲ τοῖς διαβάλλουσιν καὶ λέγουσιν ὡς ἐπιβουλεύων τῇ τυραννίδι δίῳν πράττει πάντα ὅσα ἔπραττεν ἐν τῷ τότε χρόνῳ, ἵνα ὁ μὲν παιδείᾳ δὴ τὸν νοῦν κληθεὶς ἀμελοῖ τῆς ἀρχῆς ἐπιτρέψας ἐκείνῳ, ὁ δὲ σφετερίσαιο καὶ Διονύσιον ἐκβάλοι ἐκ τῆς ἀρχῆς δόλῳ. ταῦτα τότε ἐνίκησεν καὶ τὸ δεύτερον ἐν Συρακοσίοις λεγόμενα, καὶ μάλα ἀτόπῳ τε καὶ αἰσχυρᾷ νίκη τοῖς τῆς νίκης αἰτίοις. οἷον γὰρ γέγονεν, ἀκοῦσαι χρὴ τοὺς

333d

I, a citizen of Athens, a companion of Dion, his ally, went to the tyrant with the aim of converting hostility into friendship, but I lost my struggle against the slanderers. Yet, when Dionysius tried to use money and honours to persuade me to testify, as a friend, to the appropriateness of his expulsion of Dion, he failed utterly in his endeavours. Later, as Dion was returning home, he attached himself to two brothers from Athens who had become his friends, not from a love

of wisdom but from ordinary companionship. And, indeed, these two friends, having joined him for his return, became his companions. But when they arrived in Sicily, once they saw that Dion was being slandered for plotting to become a tyrant by the very Sicilians he had liberated, not only did they betray their comrade and host, but they became more or less directly involved in his murder, for they stood by the murderers as allies, with weapons in their hands.

ἐμὲ παρακαλοῦντας πρὸς τὰ νῦν πράγματα. ἦλθον Ἀθηναῖος ἀνὴρ ἐγώ, ἐταῖρος Δίωνος, σύμμαχος αὐτῷ, πρὸς τὸν τύραννον, ὅπως ἀντὶ πολέμου φιλίαν ποιήσασιν· διαμαχόμενος δὲ τοῖς διαβάλλουσιν ἡττήθη. πείθοντος δὲ Διονυσίου τιμαῖς καὶ χρήμασιν γενέσθαι μετ’ αὐτοῦ ἐμὲ μάρτυρά τε καὶ φίλον πρὸς τὴν εὐπρέπειαν τῆς ἐκβολῆς τῆς Δίωνος αὐτῷ γίνεσθαι, τούτων δὴ τὸ πᾶν διήμαρτεν. ὕστερον δὲ δὴ κατιῶν οἴκαδε δίῳ ἀδελφῷ δύο προσλαμβάνει Ἀθήνηθεν, οὐκ ἐκ φιλοσοφίας γεγονότε φίλῳ, ἀλλ’ ἐκ τῆς περιτρεχούσης ἐταιρίας ταύτης τῆς τῶν πλείστων φίλων, ἣν ἐκ τοῦ ξενίζειν τε καὶ μυεῖν καὶ ἐποπτεύειν πραγματεύονται, καὶ δὴ καὶ τούτῳ τῷ συγκαταγαγόντε αὐτὸν φίλῳ ἐκ τούτων τε καὶ ἐκ τῆς πρὸς τὴν κάθοδον ὑπηρεσίας ἐγενέσθην ἐταίρῳ· ἐλθόντες δὲ εἰς Σικελίαν, ἐπειδὴ Δίωνα ἥσθοντο διαβεβλημένον εἰς τοὺς ἐλευθερωθέντας ὑπ’ αὐτοῦ Σικελιώτας ὡς ἐπιβουλεύοντα γενέσθαι τύραννον, οὐ μόνον τὸν ἐταῖρον καὶ ξένον προὔδοσαν, ἀλλ’ οἶον τοῦ φόνου αὐτόχειρες ἐγένοντο, ὅπλα ἔχοντες ἐν ταῖς χερσὶν αὐτοῖς τοῖς φονεῦσι παρεστῶτες ἐπίκουροι. καὶ τὸ μὲν αἰσχρὸν καὶ ἀνόσιον οὔτε παρίεμαι ἔγωγε οὔτε τι λέγω—πολλοῖς γὰρ καὶ ἄλλοις ὑμνεῖν ταῦτα ἐπιμελὲς καὶ εἰς τὸν ἔπειτα μελήσει χρόνον—τὸ δὲ Ἀθηναίων περὶ λεγόμενον, ὡς αἰσχύνῃ οὗτοι περιῆψαν τῇ πόλει, ἔξαιρουμαι· φημὶ γὰρ κάκεῖνον Ἀθηναῖον εἶναι ὃς οὐ προὔδωκεν τὸν αὐτὸν τοῦτον, ἐξὸν χρήματα καὶ ἄλλας τιμὰς πολλὰς λαμβάνειν. οὐ γὰρ διὰ βαναύσου φιλότητος ἐγεγόνει φίλος, διὰ δὲ ἐλευθέρας παιδείας κοινωνίαν, ἥ μόνῃ χρή πιστεύειν τὸν νοῦν κεκτημένον μᾶλλον ἢ συγγενεῖα ψυχῶν καὶ σωμάτων ὥστε οὐκ ἀξίω

All this has been said by way of advice to Dion's friends and associates. But I now give you some additional advice, delivering the same advice and the same argument for the third time to yourselves as the third recipients. This is what I say. Do not subjugate Sicily or any other city to human despots, but to laws. For subjugation is good neither for the subjugated nor for those who subjugate them, neither for themselves, their children nor their children's children. The first person I tried to convince of this was Dion, the second was Dionysius, and you yourselves are now third. Be persuaded then by me, for the sake of Zeus, the third, the saviour¹⁶, looking either to the case of Dionysius or of Dion, one of whom was unpersuaded and is now living an ignoble life while the other was persuaded and died a noble death.

ὄνείδους γεγόνατον τῇ πόλει τῷ Δίῳ ἀποκτείναντε, ὡς ἐλλογίμῳ πῶποτε ἄνδρε γενομένῳ. ταῦτα εἴρηται πάντα τῆς συμβουλῆς ἕνεκα τῶν Διωνείων φίλων καὶ συγγενῶν· συμβουλεύω δὲ δὴ τι πρὸς τούτοις τὴν αὐτὴν συμβουλὴν καὶ λόγον τὸν αὐτὸν λέγων ἤδη τρίτον τρίτοις ὑμῖν. μὴ δουλοῦσθαι Σικελίαν ὑπ' ἀνθρώποις δεσπόταις, μηδὲ ἄλλην πόλιν, ὃ γ' ἐμὸς λόγος, ἀλλ' ὑπὸ νόμοις οὔτε γὰρ τοῖς δουλουμένοις οὔτε τοῖς δουλωθεῖσιν ἄμεινον, αὐτοῖς καὶ παισὶ παίδων τε καὶ ἐκγόνοις, ἀλλ' ὀλέθριος πάντως ἢ πείρα, σμικρὰ δὲ καὶ ἀνελεύθερα ψυχῶν ἦθ' ἐὰν ταῦτα ἀρπάξῃ κέρδη φιλεῖ, οὐδὲν τῶν εἰς τὸν ἔπειτα καὶ εἰς τὸν παρόντα καιρὸν ἀγαθῶν καὶ δικαίων εἰδότα θείων τε καὶ ἀνθρωπίνων. ταῦτα πρῶτον μὲν Δίῳ ἐπεχείρησα ἐγὼ πείθειν, δεύτερον δὲ Διονύσιον, τρίτους δὲ ὑμᾶς νῦν. καὶ ἐμοὶ πείθεσθε Διὸς τρίτου σωτῆρος χάριν, εἴτα εἰς Διονύσιον βλέψαντες καὶ Δίῳ, ὧν ὁ μὲν μὴ πειθόμενος ζῇ τὰ νῦν οὐ καλῶς, ὁ δὲ πειθόμενος τέθνηκεν καλῶς· τὸ γὰρ τῶν καλλίστων ἐφιέμενον αὐτῷ τε καὶ πόλει πάσχειν ὅτι ἂν πάσχη πᾶν ὀρθὸν καὶ καλόν. οὔτε γὰρ πέφυκεν ἀθάνατος ἡμῶν οὐδεὶς, οὔτ' εἴ τῳ συμβαίῃ, γένοιτο ἂν εὐδαίμων, ὡς δοκεῖ τοῖς πολλοῖς· κακὸν γὰρ καὶ ἀγαθὸν οὐδὲν λόγου ἄξιόν

335a

We should always be truly persuaded by the ancient, sacred pronouncements which tell us that soul is immortal, that it has judges

and pays great retribution when someone quits the body. That is why we should regard it as a lesser evil to suffer great wrongs and injustices rather than perform them. With these arguments, and others like them, I set about persuading Dion, and I would have very good grounds for being angry with those who murdered the man, and similarly with Dionysius, for both parties did enormous damage to me, and in a sense to all of humanity in general. The murderers did this by destroying a man who was intent upon practising justice, while Dionysius, despite his great power throughout his entire empire, refused to practise justice.

ἐστὶν τοῖς ἀψύχοις, ἀλλ' ἢ μετὰ σώματος οὔση ψυχῇ τοῦτο συμβήσεται ἐκάστη ἢ κεχωρισμένη. πείθεσθαι δὲ ὄντως αἰεὶ χρή τοῖς παλαιοῖς τε καὶ ἱεροῖς λόγοις, οἳ δὴ μηνύουσιν ἡμῖν ἀθάνατον ψυχὴν εἶναι δικαστὰς τε ἴσχειν καὶ τίνειν τὰς μεγίστας τιμωρίας, ὅταν τις ἀπαλλαχθῇ τοῦ σώματος· διὸ καὶ τὰ μεγάλα ἁμαρτήματα καὶ ἀδικήματα σμικρότερον εἶναι χρή νομίζειν κακὸν πάσχειν ἢ δρᾶσαι, ὧν ὁ φιλοχρήματος πένης τε ἀνὴρ τὴν ψυχὴν οὔτε ἀκούει, ἐὰν τε ἀκούσῃ, καταγελῶν, ὡς οἶται, πανταχόθεν ἀναιδῶς ἀρπάζει πᾶν ὅτι περ ἂν οἴηται, καθάπερ θηρίον, φαγεῖν ἢ πιεῖν ἢ περὶ τὴν ἀνδραποδώδην καὶ ἀχάριστον, ἀφροδίσιον λεγομένην οὐκ ὀρθῶς, ἡδονὴν ποιεῖν αὐτῷ τοῦ μίμνῃ πλάσθαι, τυφλὸς ὢν καὶ οὐχ ὁρῶν, οἷς συνέπεται τῶν ἀρπαγμάτων ἀνοσιουργία, κακὸν ἡλίκον αἰεὶ μετ' ἀδικήματος ἐκάστου, ἣν ἀναγκαῖον τῷ ἀδικήσαντι συνεφέλκειν ἐπὶ τε γῇ στρεφομένῳ καὶ ὑπὸ γῆς νοστήσαντι πορείαν ἄτιμόν τε καὶ ἀθλίαν πάντως πανταχῇ. Δίωνα δὲ ἐγὼ λέγων ταῦτά τε καὶ ἄλλα τοιαῦτα ἔπειθον, καὶ τοῖς ἀποκτείνουσιν ἐκεῖνον δικαιότατ' ἂν ὀργιζοίμην ἐγὼ τρόπον τινὰ ὁμοιότατα καὶ Διονυσίῳ· ἀμφοτέροι γὰρ ἐμὲ καὶ τοὺς ἄλλους ὡς ἔπος εἰπεῖν ἅπαντας τὰ μέγιστα ἔβλαψαν ἀνθρώπους, οἳ μὲν τὸν βουλόμενον δικαιοσύνη χρῆσθαι διαφθείραντες, ὁ δὲ οὐδὲν ἐθελήσας χρήσασθαι δικαιοσύνη διὰ πάσης τῆς ἀρχῆς, μεγίστην δύναμιν ἔχων, ἐν ἣ γενομένη φιλοσοφία τε καὶ δύναμις ὄντως ἐν ταύτῳ διὰ πάντων ἀνθρώπων Ἑλλήνων τε καὶ βαρβάρων λάμψας ἂν ἰκανῶς δόξαν παρέστησεν πᾶσιν τὴν ἀληθῆ, ὡς οὐκ ἂν ποτε γένοιτο εὐδαίμων οὔτε πόλις οὔτ' ἀνὴρ οὐδεὶς, ὃς ἂν μὴ

μετὰ φρονήσεως ὑπὸ δικαιοσύνη διαγάγη τὸν βίον, ἥτοι ἐν αὐτῷ κεκτημένος ἢ ὁσίων ἀνδρῶν ἀρχόντων ἐν ἡθελαι τραφεῖς τε καὶ παιδευθεῖς ἐνδίκως. ταῦτα μὲν Διονύσιος ἔβλαψεν· τὰ δὲ ἄλλα σμικρὰ ἂν εἴη πρὸς ταῦτά μοι βλάβη. ὁ δὲ Δίωνα ἀποκτείνας οὐκ οἶδεν ταῦτὸν ἐξεργασμένος τούτῳ. Δίωνα γὰρ ἐγὼ σαφῶς οἶδα, ὡς οἶόν τε περὶ ἀνθρώπων ἀνθρωπον δυσχυρίζεσθαι, ὅτι, τὴν ἀρχὴν εἰ κατέσχευ, ὡς οὐκ ἂν ποτε ἐπ' ἄλλο γε

336a

Now, factions have no rest from their evils until those who have won power stop revisiting past evils through open warfare, expulsion and slaughter, and give up the search for revenge upon their enemies, and exercise some control over themselves by passing laws that are common to all, involving no more advantage to themselves than to the defeated parties. They should compel these people to have recourse to the laws by employing two necessary forces, reverence and fear. Otherwise there is no way that a city with internal factions will ever abate its evils. Rather, for cities constituted in this way, factions, enmity, hatred and suspicion, internal to themselves, tend to arise unrelentingly.

σχῆμα ἀρχῆς ἐτράπετο ἢ ἐπὶ τὸ Συρακούσας μὲν πρῶτον, τὴν πατρίδα τὴν ἑαυτοῦ, ἐπεὶ τὴν δουλείαν αὐτῆς ἀπὴλλαξεν φαιδρύνας ἐλευθέρως δ' ἐν σχήματι κατέστησεν, τὸ μετὰ τοῦτ' ἂν πάσῃ μηχανῇ ἐκόσμησεν νόμοις τοῖς προσήκουσιν τε καὶ ἀρίστοις τοὺς πολίτας, τό τε ἐφεξῆς τούτοις προθυμεῖτ' ἂν πρᾶξαι, πᾶσαν Σικελίαν κατοικίζειν καὶ ἐλευθέραν ἀπὸ τῶν βαρβάρων ποιεῖν, τοὺς μὲν ἐκβάλλων, τοὺς δὲ χειρούμενος ῥᾶον Ἰέρωνος· τούτων δ' αὖ γενομένων δι' ἀνδρὸς δικαίου τε καὶ ἀνδρείου καὶ σώφρονος καὶ φιλοσόφου, τὴν αὐτὴν ἀρετῆς ἂν πέρι γενέσθαι δόξαν τοῖς πολλοῖς, ἥπερ ἂν, εἰ Διονύσιος ἐπέισθη, παρὰ πᾶσιν ἂν ὡς ἔπος εἰπεῖν ἀνθρώποις ἀπέσωσεν γενομένη. νῦν δὲ ἢ πού τις δαίμων ἢ τις ἀλιτήριος ἐμπεσὼν ἀνομία καὶ ἀθεότητι καὶ τὸ μέγιστον τόλμαις ἀμαθίας, ἐξ ἧς πάντα κακὰ πᾶσιν ἐρρίζωται καὶ βλαστάνει καὶ εἰς ὕστερον ἀποτελεῖ καρπὸν τοῖς γεννήσασιν πικρότατον, αὕτη πάντα τὸ δεύτερον ἀνέτρεψεν τε καὶ ἀπώλεσεν. νῦν

δὲ δὴ εὐφημῶμεν χάριν οἴωνοῦ τὸ τρίτον. ὅμως δὲ μιμεῖσθαι μὲν συμβουλευῶν Δίωνα ὑμῖν τοῖς φίλοις τήν τε τῆς πατρίδος εὐνοίαν καὶ τὴν τῆς τροφῆς σώφρονα δίαίταν, ἐπὶ λωόνων δὲ ὀρνίθων τὰς ἐκείνου βουλήσεις πειρᾶσθαι ἀποτελεῖν—αἱ δὲ ἦσαν, ἀκηκόατε παρ' ἐμοῦ σαφῶς—τὸν δὲ μὴ δυνάμενον ὑμῶν Δωριστὶ ζῆν κατὰ τὰ πάτρια, διώκοντα δὲ τόν τε τῶν Δίωνος σφαγέων καὶ τὸν Σικελικὸν βίον, μήτε παρακαλεῖν μήτε οἶεσθαι πιστὸν ἄν τι καὶ ὑγιὲς πρᾶξαί ποτε, τοὺς δὲ ἄλλους παρακαλεῖν ἐπὶ πάσης Σικελίας κατοικισμὸν τε καὶ ἰσονομίαν ἔκ τε αὐτῆς Σικελίας καὶ ἐκ Πελοποννήσου συμπάσης, φοβεῖσθαι δὲ μηδὲ Ἀθῆνας· εἰσὶ γὰρ καὶ ἐκεῖ πάντων ἀνθρώπων διαφέροντες πρὸς ἀρετὴν, ξενοφόνων τε ἀνδρῶν μισοῦντες τόλμας. εἰ δ' οὖν ταῦτα μὲν ὕστερα γένοιτ' ἄν, κατεπεΐγουσιν δὲ ὑμᾶς αἱ τῶν στάσεων πολλαὶ καὶ παντοδαπαὶ φυόμεναι ἐκάστης ἡμέρας διαφοραί, εἰδέναι μὲν που χρή πάντα τινὰ ἄνδρα, ὃ καὶ βραχὺ δόξης ὀρθῆς μετέδωκεν θεία τις τύχη, ὥς οὐκ ἔστιν παῦλα κακῶν τοῖς στασιάσασιν, πρὶν ἂν οἱ κρατήσαντες μάχαις καὶ ἐκβολαῖς ἀνθρώπων καὶ σφαγαῖς μνησικακοῦντες καὶ ἐπὶ τιμωρίας παύσωνται τρεπόμενοι τῶν ἐχθρῶν, ἐγκρατεῖς δὲ ὄντες αὐτῶν, θέμενοι νόμους κοινούς μηδὲν μᾶλλον πρὸς ἡδονὴν αὐτοῖς ἢ τοῖς ἡττηθεῖσιν κειμένους, ἀναγκάσωσιν αὐτοὺς χρῆσθαι τοῖς νόμοις διτταῖς οὐσαις ἀνάγκαις, αἰδοῖ καὶ φόβῳ, φόβῳ μὲν διὰ τὸ κρείττους αὐτῶν εἶναι δεικνύντες τὴν βίαν, αἰδοῖ δὲ αὖ διὰ τὸ κρείττους φαίνεσθαι περὶ τε τὰς ἡδονὰς καὶ τοῖς νόμοις μᾶλλον ἐθέλοντές τε καὶ δυνάμενοι δουλεύειν. ἄλλως δὲ οὐκ ἔστιν ὥς ἂν ποτε κακῶν λήξαι

337b

So those who have won power should always, once they are truly desirous of security, select from among themselves the very best Greeks they can find, men who firstly are advanced in years, who have households of wives and children, and preferably ancestors aplenty, who are good, reputable and all sufficiently well off. Fifty such people should suffice for a city of ten thousand citizens. Once the laws have been enacted, it is all-important that the victors render themselves more subservient to the laws than the vanquished. Then everyone will

be safe, happiness will abound, and all the evils will be avoided. So, that's enough advice and direction about my first visit to Dionysius.

πόλις ἐν αὐτῇ στασιάσασα, ἀλλὰ στάσεις καὶ ἔχθραι καὶ μίση καὶ ἀπιστίαι ταῖς οὕτω διατεθείσαις πόλεσιν αὐταῖς πρὸς αὐτὰς αἰεὶ γίγνεσθαι φιλεῖ. τοὺς δὴ κρατήσαντας αἰεὶ χρή, ὅταν περ ἐπιθυμήσωσιν σωτηρίας, αὐτοὺς ἐν αὐτοῖς ἄνδρας προκρίναι τῶν Ἑλλήνων οὓς ἂν πυνθάνωνται ἀρίστους ὄντας, πρῶτον μὲν γέροντας, καὶ παῖδας καὶ γυναῖκας κεκτημένους οἶκοι καὶ προγόνους αὐτῶν ὅτι μάλιστα πολλοὺς τε καὶ ἀγαθοὺς καὶ ὀνομαστοὺς καὶ κτῆσιν κεκτημένους πάντας ἱκανὴν—ἀριθμὸν δὲ εἶναι μυριάνδρῳ πόλει πεντήκοντα ἱκανοὶ τοιοῦτοι—τούτους δὴ δεήσεσιν καὶ τιμαῖς ὅτι μεγίσταις οἴκοθεν μεταπέμψασθαι, μεταπεμψαμένους δὲ ὁμόσαντας δεῖσθαι καὶ κελεύειν θεῖναι νόμους, μήτε νικήσασιν μήτε νικηθεῖσιν νέμειν πλέον, τὸ δὲ ἴσον καὶ κοινὸν πάσῃ τῇ πόλει. τεθέντων δὲ τῶν νόμων ἐν τούτῳ δὴ τὰ πάντα ἐστίν. ἂν μὲν γὰρ οἱ νενικηκότες ἥττους αὐτοὺς τῶν νόμων μᾶλλον τῶν νενικημένων παρέχωνται, πάντ' ἔσται σωτηρίας τε καὶ εὐδαιμονίας μεστὰ καὶ πάντων κακῶν ἀποφυγὴ εἰ δὲ μή, μήτ' ἐμὲ μήτ' ἄλλον κοινωνὸν παρακαλεῖν ἐπὶ τὸν μὴ πειθόμενον τοῖς νῦν ἐπεσταλμένοις. ταῦτα γὰρ ἐστὶν ἀδελφὰ ὧν τε δίων ὧν τ' ἐγὼ ἐπεχειρήσαμεν Συρακούσαις εὖ φρονούντες συμπᾶσαι, δεύτερα μὲν πρῶτα δ' ἦν ἃ τὸ πρῶτον ἐπεχειρήθη μετ' αὐτοῦ Διονυσίου πραχθῆναι πᾶσιν κοινὰ ἀγαθὰ, τύχη δέ τις ἀνθρώπων κρείττων διεφόρησεν. τὰ δὲ νῦν ὑμεῖς πειρᾶσθε εὐτυχέστερον αὐτὰ ἀγαθῇ πρᾶξαι μοῖρα καὶ θεία τινὶ τύχῃ. συμβουλή μὲν δὴ καὶ ἐπιστολὴ εἰρήσθω καὶ ἡ παρὰ Διονύσιον ἐμὴ προτέρα ἄφιξις· ἡ δὲ δὴ ὑστέρα πορεία τε καὶ πλοῦς ὡς εἰκότως τε ἅμα καὶ ἐμμελῶς γέγονεν, ᾧ μέλει ἀκούειν ἔξεστι τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο. ὁ μὲν γὰρ δὴ πρῶτος χρόνος τῆς ἐν Σικελίᾳ διατριβῆς μοι διεπεράνθη, καθάπερ εἶπον, πρὶν συμβουλευεῖν τοῖς οἰκείοις καὶ ἐταίροις τοῖς περὶ Δίωνα· τὸ μετ' ἐκεῖνα δ' οὖν ἔπεισα ὅπῃ δὴ ποτ' ἐδυνάμην Διονύσιον ἀφεῖναι με, εἰρήνης δὲ γενομένης—ἦν γὰρ τότε πόλεμος ἐν Σικελίᾳ—συνωμολογήσαμεν ἀμφοτέρω. Διονύσιος μὲν ἔφη μεταπέμψεσθαι Δίωνα καὶ ἐμὲ πάλιν, καταστησάμενος τὰ περὶ τὴν ἀρχὴν ἀσφαλέστερον ἑαυτῷ, Δίωνα δὲ ἥξιον

338b

Once peace had been restored Dionysius began sending for me, and although he asked Dion to wait a further year, he made all sorts of requests for me to come. Dion kept asking and imploring me to travel, and indeed there was much report from Sicily that Dionysius had now become marvelously enthusiastic about philosophy once again. Nevertheless, it seemed safer at the time to stay well away from Dion and Dionysius, and I annoyed them both by replying that I was advanced in years. After this it seems that Archytas visited the court of Dionysius. In fact, before my departure I had forged a bond of hospitality and friendship between Archytas and his people in Tarentum and Dionysius.

διανοεῖσθαι μὴ φυγὴν αὐτῷ γεγονέναι τότε, μετάστασιν δέ· ἐγὼ δ' ἤξειν ὡμολόγησα ἐπὶ τούτοις τοῖς λόγοις. γενομένης δὲ εἰρήνης, μετεπέμπετό με, Δίωνα δὲ ἐπισχεῖν ἔτι ἐνιαυτὸν ἔδεῖτο, ἐμὲ δὲ ἤκειν ἐκ παντὸς τρόπου ἡξίου. δίων μὲν οὖν ἐκέλευέ τέ με πλεῖν καὶ ἔδεῖτο· καὶ γὰρ δὴ λόγος ἐχώρει πολὺς ἐκ Σικελίας ὡς Διονύσιος θαυμαστῶς φιλοσοφίας ἐν ἐπιθυμίᾳ πάλιν εἶη γεγονῶς τὰ νῦν· ὅθεν ὁ δίων συντεταμένως ἔδεῖτο ἡμῶν τῇ μεταπέμψει μὴ ἀπειθεῖν. ἐγὼ δὲ ἤδη μέν που κατὰ τὴν φιλοσοφίαν τοῖς νέοις πολλὰ τοιαῦτα γιγνόμενα, ὅμως δ' οὖν ἀσφαλέστερόν μοι ἔδοξεν χαίρειν τότε γε πολλὰ καὶ Δίωνα καὶ Διονύσιον ἔαν, καὶ ἀπηχθόμην ἀμφοῖν ἀποκρινάμενος ὅτι γέρων τε εἶην καὶ κατὰ τὰς ὁμολογίας οὐδὲν γίγνοιτο τῶν τὰ νῦν πραττομένων. ἔοικεν δὴ τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο Ἀρχύτης τε παρὰ Διονύσιον πρὶν ἀφικέσθαι—ἐγὼ γὰρ πρὶν ἀπιέναι ξενίαν καὶ φιλίαν Ἀρχύτῃ καὶ τοῖς ἐν

338d

In fact, Dionysius, on the third occasion, sent a trireme to make the journey easier for me, and he sent Archidamus, an associate of Archytas. He himself sent a very long letter, knowing full well of my relationship with Dion and Dion's eagerness that I make the journey and visit Syracuse. In fact, the letter dealt with all these considerations, beginning with: "Dionysius to Plato", followed by the usual civilities. And then, without further ado, it said, "If you are

persuaded by us and come forthwith to Sicily, then first and foremost Dion's affairs will be arranged for you in whatever way you wish. But if you don't travel, none of Dion's affairs will unfold to your satisfaction." Other letters kept arriving from Archytas and his people in Tarentum, praising the philosophy of Dionysius. So I felt that I should unequivocally test how matters actually stood.

Τάραντι καὶ Διονυσίῳ ποιήσας ἀπέπλεον—ἄλλοι τέ τινες ἐν Συρακούσαις ἦσαν Δίωνός τε ἅττα διακηκοότες καὶ τούτων τινὲς ἄλλοι, παρακουσμάτων τινῶν ἔμμεστοι τῶν κατὰ φιλοσοφίαν· οἱ δοκοῦσί μοι Διονυσίῳ πειρᾶσθαι διαλέγεσθαι τῶν περὶ τὰ τοιαῦτα, ὡς Διονυσίου πάντα διακηκοότος ὅσα διανοοῦμην ἐγώ. ὁ δὲ οὔτε ἄλλως ἐστὶν ἀφυῆς πρὸς τὴν τοῦ μανθάνειν δύναμιν φιλότιμός τε θαυμαστῶς ἤρεσκέν τε οὖν ἴσως αὐτῷ τὰ λεγόμενα ἡσχύοντό τε φανερὸς γιγνόμενος οὐδὲν ἀκηκοὼς ὅτ' ἐπεδήμουν ἐγώ, ὅθεν ἅμα μὲν εἰς ἐπιθυμίαν ἦει τοῦ διακοῦσαι ἐναργέστερον, ἅμα δ' ἡ φιλοτιμία κατήπειγεν αὐτόν—δι' ἃ δὲ οὐκ ἤκουσεν ἐν τῇ πρόσθεν ἐπιδημίᾳ, διεξήλθομεν ἐν τοῖς ἄνω ῥηθεῖσιν νυνδὴ λόγοις—ἐπειδὴ δ' οὖν οἴκαδ' ἐ' ἐσώθην καὶ καλοῦντος τὸ δεύτερον ἀπηνήθη, καθάπερ εἶπον νυνδὴ, δοκεῖ μοι Διονύσιος παντάπασιν φιλοτιμηθῆναι μή ποτέ τισιν δόξαιμι καταφρονῶν αὐτοῦ τῆς φύσεώς τε καὶ ἔξωθεν ἅμα καὶ τῆς διαίτης ἔμπειρος γεγονώς, οὐκέτ' ἐθέλειν δυσχεραίνων παρ' αὐτὸν ἀφικνεῖσθαι. δίκαιος δὲ λέγειν εἰμὶ τάληθές καὶ ὑπομένειν, εἴ τις ἄρα τὰ γεγονότα ἀκούσας καταφρονήσει τῆς ἐμῆς φιλοσοφίας, τὸν τύραννον δὲ ἡγήσεται νοῦν ἔχειν. ἔπεμψε μὲν γὰρ δὴ Διονύσιος τρίτον ἐπ' ἐμὲ τρίτην ῥαστώνης ἕνεκα τῆς πορείας, ἔπεμψεν δὲ Ἀρχέδημον, ὃν ἡγεῖτό με τῶν ἐν Σικελίᾳ περὶ πλείστου ποιεῖσθαι, τῶν Ἀρχύτῃ συγγεγονότων ἕνα, καὶ ἄλλους γνωρίμους τῶν ἐν Σικελίᾳ· οὗτοι δὲ ἡμῖν ἡγγελλον πάντες τὸν αὐτὸν λόγον, ὡς θαυμαστὸν ὅσον Διονύσιος ἐπιδεδωκώς εἴη πρὸς φιλοσοφίαν. ἔπεμψεν δὲ ἐπιστολὴν πάνυ μακράν, εἰδὼς ὡς πρὸς Δίωνα διεκείμην καὶ τὴν αὖ Δίωνος προθυμίαν τοῦ ἐμὲ πλεῖν καὶ εἰς Συρακούσας ἐλθεῖν· πρὸς γὰρ δὴ πάντα ταῦτα ἦν παρεσκευασμένη τὴν ἀρχὴν ἔχουσα ἢ ἐπιστολή, τῇδὲ περὶ φράζουσιν—Διονύσιος Πλάτωνι—τὰ νόμιμα ἐπὶ τούτοις εἰπὼν οὐδὲν τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο εἶπεν πρότερον ἢ ὡς ἂν

εἰς Σικελίαν πεισθεὶς ὑφ' ἡμῶν ἔλθῃς τὰ νῦν, πρῶτον μὲν σοι τὰ περὶ Δίωνα ὑπάρξει ταύτη γιγνόμενα ὅπηπερ ἂν αὐτὸς ἐθέλῃς—θελήσεις δὲ οἶδ' ὅτι τὰ μέτρια, καὶ ἐγὼ συγχωρήσομαι—εἰ δὲ μή, οὐδέν σοι τῶν περὶ Δίωνα ἔξει πραγμάτων οὔτε περὶ τᾶλλα οὔτε περὶ αὐτὸν κατὰ νοῦν γιγνόμενα. ταῦθ' οὕτως εἶπεν, τᾶλλα δὲ

339d

So, clothed in this reasoning, I went on my way with many fears and, as you might expect, a considerable foreboding. It really was a case of 'the third to the saviour'. Yet fortunately I came through safely once again, and for this, after God, I must be grateful to Dionysius, for although many people were intent upon my destruction, he prevented this. Once I had arrived there, I decided first of all to test whether Dionysius really was inflamed by the fire of philosophy. There is a way of putting such matters to the test which is not crude and really well suited to tyrants. It is necessary to point out to such people what the subject is in its entirety, the sort of subject it is, and how much complexity and effort it involves. Someone who hears this, if he be really philosophic, will believe that he has heard something wonderful and that he should now bestir himself. But those who are not really philosophic, having a mere coating of opinions, once they see how many subjects are involved and the extent of the exertion, they decide that philosophy is difficult and beyond their abilities.

μακρὰ ἂν εἴη καὶ ἄνευ καιροῦ λεγόμενα. ἐπιστολαὶ δὲ ἄλλαι ἐφοίτων παρά τε Ἀρχύτου καὶ τῶν ἐν Τάραντι, τὴν τε φιλοσοφίαν ἐγκωμιάζουσαι τὴν Διονυσίου, καὶ ὅτι, ἂν μὴ ἀφίκωμαι νῦν, τὴν πρὸς Διονύσιον αὐτοῖς γενομένην φιλίαν δι' ἐμοῦ, οὐ σμικρὰν οὔσαν πρὸς τὰ πολιτικά, παντάπασιν διαβαλοῖην. ταύτης δὴ τοιαύτης γενομένης ἐν τῷ τότε χρόνῳ τῆς μεταπέμψεως, τῶν μὲν ἐκ Σικελίας τε καὶ Ἰταλίας ἐλκόντων, τῶν δὲ Ἀθήνηθεν ἀτεχνῶς μετὰ δεήσεως οἷον ἐξωθούντων με, καὶ πάλιν ὁ λόγος ἦκεν ὁ αὐτός, τὸ μὴ δεῖν προδοῦναι Δίωνα μηδὲ τοὺς ἐν Τάραντι ξένους τε καὶ ἐταίρους, αὐτῷ δέ μοι ὑπῆν ὥς οὐδὲν θαυμαστὸν νέον ἄνθρωπον παρακούοντα ἀξίων λόγου πραγμάτων, εὐμαθῇ, πρὸς ἔρωτα ἐλθεῖν τοῦ βελτίστου βίου· δεῖν οὖν αὐτὸ ἐξελέγξαι

σαφῶς ὁποτέρως ποτὲ ἄρα ἔχοι, καὶ τοῦτ' αὐτὸ μηδαμῇ προδοῦναι μηδ' ἐμὲ τὸν αἵτιον γενέσθαι τηλικούτου ἀληθῶς ὀνειδούς, εἵπερ ὄντως εἴη τῷ ταῦτα λελεγμένα. πορεύομαι δὴ τῷ λογισμῷ τούτῳ κατακαλυψάμενος—πολλὰ δεδιὼς μαντευόμενός τε οὐ πάνυ καλῶς, ὡς ἔοικεν—ἐλθὼν δ' οὖν τὸ τρίτον τῷ σωτῆρι τοῦτό γε οὖν ἔπραξα ὄντως· ἐσώθην γάρ τοι πάλιν εὐτυχῶς, καὶ τούτων γε μετὰ θεὸν Διονυσίῳ χάριν εἶδέναι χρεών, ὅτι πολλῶν βουλευθέντων ἀπολέσαι με διεκώλυσεν καὶ ἔδωκέν τι μέρος αἰδοῖ τῶν περὶ ἐμὲ πραγμάτων. ἐπειδὴ δὲ ἀφικόμην, ὥμην τούτου πρῶτον ἔλεγχον δεῖν λαβεῖν, πότερον ὄντως εἴη Διονύσιος ἐξημμένος ὑπὸ φιλοσοφίας ὥσπερ πυρός, ἢ μάτην ὁ πολὺς οὗτος ἔλθοι λόγος Ἀθήναζε. ἔστιν δὴ τις τρόπος τοῦ περὶ τὰ τοιαῦτα πεῖραν λαμβάνειν οὐκ ἀγεννῆς ἀλλ' ὄντως τυράννοις πρέπων, ἄλλως τε καὶ τοῖς τῶν παρακουσμάτων μεστοῖς, ὃ δὴ καὶ γὰρ Διονύσιον εὐθὺς ἐλθὼν ἥσθόμην καὶ μάλα πεπονθότα. δεικνύναι δὴ δεῖ τοῖς τοιούτοις ὅτι ἔστι πᾶν τὸ πρᾶγμα οἷόν τε καὶ δι' ὅσων πραγμάτων καὶ ὅσον πόνον ἔχει. ὁ γὰρ ἀκούσας, ἐὰν μὲν ὄντως ἦ φιλόσοφος οἰκεῖός τε καὶ ἄξιός τοῦ πράγματος θεῖος ὢν, ὁδὸν τε ἡγεῖται θαυμαστὴν ἀκηκοέναι συντατέον τε εἶναι νῦν καὶ οὐ βιωτὸν ἄλλως ποιοῦντι· μετὰ τοῦτο δὲ συντείνας αὐτός τε καὶ τὸν ἡγούμενον τὴν ὁδόν, οὐκ ἀνίσιν πρὶν ἂν ἡ τέλος ἐπιθῇ πᾶσιν, ἢ λάβῃ δύναμιν ὥστε αὐτὸς αὐτὸν χωρὶς τοῦ δείξοντος δυνατὸς εἶναι ποδηγεῖν. ταύτη καὶ κατὰ ταῦτα διανοηθεὶς ὁ τοιοῦτος ζῇ, πράττων μὲν ἐν αἵσισιν ἂν ἢ πράξειςιν, παρὰ πάντα δὲ ἀεὶ φιλοσοφίας ἐχόμενος καὶ τροφῆς τῆς καθ' ἡμέραν ἥτις ἂν αὐτὸν μάλιστα εὐμαθῇ τε καὶ μνήμονα καὶ λογίζεσθαι δυνατὸν ἐν αὐτῷ νήφοντα ἀπεργάζηται· τὴν δὲ ἐναντίαν ταύτη μισῶν διατελεῖ. οἱ δὲ ὄντως μὲν μὴ φιλόσοφοι, δόξαις δ' ἐπικεχωσμένοι, καθάπερ οἱ τὰ σώματα ὑπὸ τῶν ἡλίων ἐπικεκαυμένοι, ἰδόντες τε ὅσα μαθήματά ἐστιν καὶ ὁ πόνος ἡλικός καὶ δίαίτα ἢ καθ' ἡμέραν ὡς πρέπουσα ἢ κοσμία τῷ πράγματι, χαλεπὸν ἡγησάμενοι καὶ ἀδύνατον αὐτοῖς, οὗτε δὲ

341a

Now, I can say this much about those who have written or shall write, claiming to have knowledge of the subjects I take seriously, having learned from myself or from others, or having made the discoveries

themselves. They could not, in my opinion, understand anything about the matter, for there is no writing of mine dealing with these subjects, nor will there ever be. Indeed, this cannot be expressed in words like other subjects, but from much engagement with the matter itself, and from living with it a light is kindled as though from a leaping spark, and once it has arisen in the soul it sustains itself thereafter. But if it had appeared to me that this was sufficiently capable of being written down and formulated in words for people in general, what task could I have undertaken in my life more exalted than this one: to write something enormously beneficial for mankind, and bring the nature of reality to light for all to behold?

ἐπιτηδεύειν δυνατοὶ γίνονται, ἔνιοι δὲ αὐτῶν πείθουσιν αὐτοὺς ὡς ἱκανῶς ἀκηκοότες εἰσὶν τὸ ὅλον, καὶ οὐδὲν ἔτι δέονταί τινων πραγμάτων. ἡ μὲν δὴ πεῖρα αὕτη γίγνεται ἡ σαφὴς τε καὶ ἀσφαλεστάτη πρὸς τοὺς τρυφῶντάς τε καὶ ἀδυνάτους διαπονεῖν, ὡς μηδέποτε βαλεῖν ἐν αἰτίᾳ τὸν δεικνύντα ἀλλ' αὐτὸν αὐτόν, μὴ δυνάμενον πάντα τὰ πρόσφορα ἐπιτηδεύειν τῷ πράγματι. οὕτω δὴ καὶ Διονυσίῳ τότε ἔρρηθη τὰ ρηθέντα. πάντα μὲν οὖν οὗτ' ἐγὼ διεξήλθον οὔτε Διονύσιος ἐδεῖτο· πολλὰ γὰρ αὐτὸς καὶ τὰ μέγιστα εἰδέναι τε καὶ ἱκανῶς ἔχειν προσεποιεῖτο διὰ τὰς ὑπὸ τῶν ἄλλων παρακοάς. ὕστερον δὲ καὶ ἀκούω γεγραφέναι αὐτὸν περὶ ὧν τότε ἤκουσε, συνθέντα ὡς αὐτοῦ τέχνην, οὐδὲν τῶν αὐτῶν ὧν ἀκούοι· οἶδα δὲ οὐδὲν τούτων. ἄλλους μὲν τινὰς οἶδα γεγραφότας περὶ τῶν αὐτῶν τούτων, οἵτινες δέ, οὐδ' αὐτοὶ αὐτούς, τοσόνδε γε μὴν περὶ πάντων ἔχω φράζειν τῶν γεγραφότων καὶ γραψόντων, ὅσοι φασὶν εἰδέναι περὶ ὧν ἐγὼ σπουδάζω, εἴτ' ἐμοῦ ἀκηκοότες εἴτ' ἄλλων εἴθ' ὡς εὐρόντες αὐτοί· τούτους οὐκ ἔστιν κατὰ γε τὴν ἐμὴν δόξαν περὶ τοῦ πράγματος ἐπαίειν οὐδέν. οὐκ οὐκ ἐμόν γε περὶ αὐτῶν ἔστιν σύγγραμμα οὐδὲ μήποτε γένηται· ρητὸν γὰρ οὐδαμῶς ἔστιν ὡς ἄλλα μαθήματα, ἀλλ' ἐκ πολλῆς συνουσίας γιγνομένης περὶ τὸ πρᾶγμα αὐτὸ καὶ τοῦ συζῆν ἐξαίφνης, οἷον ἀπὸ πυρὸς πηδήσαντος ἐξαφθὲν φῶς, ἐν τῇ ψυχῇ γενόμενον αὐτὸ ἑαυτὸ ἤδη τρέφει. καίτοι τοσόνδε γε οἶδα, ὅτι γραφέντα ἢ λεχθέντα ὑπ' ἐμοῦ βέλτιστ' ἂν λεχθείη· καὶ μὴν ὅτι γεγραμμένα κακῶς οὐχ ἤκιστ' ἂν ἐμὲ λυποῖ. εἰ δέ μοι

ἐφαίνετο γραπτέα θ' ἰκανῶς εἶναι πρὸς τοὺς πολλοὺς καὶ ῥητά, τί τούτου κάλλιον ἐπέπρακτ' ἂν ἡμῖν ἐν τῷ βίῳ ἢ τοῖς τε ἀνθρώποισι μέγα ὄφελος γράψαι καὶ τὴν φύσιν εἰς φῶς παῖσιν προαγαγεῖν; ἀλλ' οὔτε ἀνθρώποις ἡγοῦμαι τὴν ἐπιχείρησιν περὶ αὐτῶν λεγομένην ἀγαθόν, εἰ μὴ τισιν ὀλίγοις ὁπόσοι δυνατοὶ ἀνευρεῖν αὐτοὶ διὰ σμικρᾶς ἐνδείξεως, τῶν τε δὴ ἄλλων τοὺς μὲν καταφρονήσεως οὐκ ὀρθῆς ἐμπλήσειεν ἂν οὐδαμῇ ἐμμελῶς, τοὺς δὲ ὑψηλῆς καὶ χαύνης ἐλπίδος, ὥς

342a

But it occurs to me to speak at greater length about these issues. There is indeed a true argument that stands against anyone who ventures to write anything at all about this sort of thing. For any of the things that exist, there are in each case three things through which the knowledge of anything is necessarily acquired. The knowledge itself is fourth, and as a fifth we must propose the thing itself, which is cognisable and which truly is. First is a name, second is an account, third is an image, and fourth is knowledge. Take one example: there is something called a circle, which has the very name we have just uttered. Second is the account of this, composed of names and verbs – that which has its extremities everywhere equidistant from the centre. Third is that which is drawn and erased, turned on a lathe and destroyed, none of which happens to circle itself. Fourth is knowledge, true reason and opinion about these, which are not contained in utterances or in physical shapes, but in souls. Of these, reason comes closest in kinship and similarity to the fifth, the circle itself.

σέμν' ἅττα μεμαθηκότας. ἔτι δὲ μακρότερα περὶ αὐτῶν ἐν νῷ μοι γέγονεν εἰπεῖν· τάχα γὰρ ἂν περὶ ὧν λέγω σαφέστερον ἂν εἴη λεχθέντων αὐτῶν. ἔστι γάρ τις λόγος ἀληθείας, ἐναντίος τῷ τολμήσαντι γράφειν τῶν τοιούτων καὶ ὀτιοῦν, πολλάκις μὲν ὑπ' ἐμοῦ καὶ πρόσθεν ῥηθείς, ἔοικεν δ' οὖν εἶναι καὶ νῦν λεκτέος. ἔστιν τῶν ὄντων ἐκάστω, δι' ὧν τὴν ἐπιστήμην ἀνάγκη παραγίγνεσθαι, τρία, τέταρτον δ' αὐτή—πέμπτον δ' αὐτὸ τιθέναι δεῖ ὃ δὴ γνωστόν τε καὶ ἀληθῶς ἐστίν ὄν—ἐν μὲν ὄνομα, δεύτερον δὲ λόγος, τὸ δὲ τρίτον εἶδωλον, τέταρτον δὲ ἐπιστήμη. περὶ ἐν οὖν λαβὲ βουλόμενος μαθεῖν τὸ νῦν λεγόμενον, καὶ

πάντων οὕτω περί νόησον. κύκλος ἐστίν τι λεγόμενον, ὃ τοῦτ' αὐτό ἐστιν ὄνομα ὃ νῦν ἐφθέγγμεθα. λόγος δ' αὐτοῦ τὸ δεύτερον, ἐξ ὀνομάτων καὶ ῥημάτων συγκείμενος· τὸ γὰρ ἐκ τῶν ἐσχάτων ἐπὶ τὸ μέσον ἴσον ἀπέχον πάντη, λόγος ἂν εἴη ἐκείνου ὥπερ στρογγύλον καὶ περιφερὲς ὄνομα καὶ κύκλος. τρίτον δὲ τὸ ζωγραφούμενον τε καὶ ἐξαλειφόμενον καὶ τορνευόμενον καὶ ἀπολλύμενον· ὧν αὐτὸς ὁ κύκλος, ὃν περί πάντ' ἐστὶν ταῦτα, οὐδὲν πάσχει, τούτων ὡς ἕτερον ὄν. τέταρτον δὲ ἐπιστήμη καὶ νοῦς ἀληθής τε δόξα περὶ ταῦτ' ἐστίν· ὡς δὲ ἐν τοῦτο αὖ πᾶν θετέον, οὐκ ἐν φωναῖς οὐδ' ἐν σωματικῶν σχήμασιν ἀλλ' ἐν ψυχαῖς ἐνόν, ὃ δῆλον ἕτερόν τε ὃν αὐτοῦ τοῦ κύκλου τῆς φύσεως τῶν τε ἔμπροσθεν λεχθέντων τριῶν. τούτων δὲ ἐγγύτατα μὲν συγγενεῖα καὶ ὁμοιότητι τοῦ πέμπτου νοῦς πεπλησίακεν, τᾶλλα δὲ πλεον ἀπέχει. ταῦτ' ὃν δὴ περὶ τε εὐθέος ἅμα καὶ περιφεροῦς σχήματος καὶ χροᾶς, περὶ τε ἀγαθοῦ καὶ καλοῦ καὶ δικαίου, καὶ περὶ σώματος ἅπαντος σκευαστοῦ τε καὶ κατὰ φύσιν γεγονότος, πυρὸς ὕδατος τε καὶ τῶν τοιούτων πάντων, καὶ ζώου σύμπαντος περί καὶ ἐν ψυχαῖς ἦθους, καὶ περὶ ποιήματα καὶ παθήματα σύμπαντα· οὐ γὰρ ἂν τούτων μὴ τις τὰ τέτταρα λάβῃ ἀμῶς γέ πως, οὐποτε τελέως ἐπιστήμης τοῦ πέμπτου μέτοχος ἔσται. πρὸς γὰρ τούτοις ταῦτα οὐχ ἦττον ἐπιχειρεῖ τὸ ποῖόν τι περὶ ἕκαστον δηλοῦν ἢ τὸ ὃν ἐκάστου διὰ τὸ τῶν λόγων ἀσθενές· ὧν ἕνεκα νοῦν ἔχων οὐδεὶς τολμήσει ποτὲ εἰς αὐτὸ τιθέναι τὰ νενοημένα ὑπ' αὐτοῦ, καὶ ταῦτα εἰς ἀμετακίνητον, ὃ δὴ πάσχει τὰ γεγραμμένα τύποις. τοῦτο δὲ πάλιν αὖ τὸ νῦν λεγόμενον δεῖ μαθεῖν. κύκλος ἕκαστος τῶν ἐν ταῖς πράξεσι γραφομένων ἢ καὶ τορνευθέντων μεστὸς τοῦ ἐναντίου ἐστὶν τῷ πέμπτῳ—τοῦ γὰρ εὐθέος ἐφάπτεται πάντη—αὐτὸς δέ, φαμέν, ὁ κύκλος οὔτε τι σμικρότερον οὔτε μείζον τῆς ἐναντίας ἔχει ἐν αὐτῷ φύσεως. ὀνομά τε αὐτῶν φαμεν οὐδὲν οὐδενί

343b

Now, although the unsoundness of each of the four is an endless topic of discussion, what's most important is that there are two things: what something is and what it is like. And although soul does not seek to know what something is like but what it is, each of the four offers the soul that which it seeks not, and always provides something that is

easily refuted by the senses, thus filling almost everybody with perplexity and insecurity of all sorts. But instruction through all these, going upwards and downwards in each case, with effort brings knowledge to birth of that which is good by nature in one who is good by nature. That is why anyone who is serious about really serious matters should never commit them to writing and thus expose them to the rivalry and confusion of humanity in general.

βέβαιον εἶναι, κωλύειν δ' οὐδὲν τὰ νῦν στρογγύλα καλούμενα εὐθέα κεκληῖσθαι τά τε εὐθέα δὴ στρογγύλα, καὶ οὐδὲν ἤττον βεβαίως ἔξειν τοῖς μεταθεμένοις καὶ ἐναντίως καλοῦσιν. καὶ μὴν περὶ λόγου γε ὁ αὐτὸς λόγος, εἴπερ ἐξ ὀνομάτων καὶ ῥημάτων σύγκειται, μηδὲν ἱκανῶς βεβαίως εἶναι βέβαιον· μυρίος δὲ λόγος αὖ περὶ ἐκάστου τῶν τεττάρων ὡς ἀσαφές, τὸ δὲ μέγιστον, ὅπερ εἵπομεν ὀλίγον ἔμπροσθεν, ὅτι δυοῖν ὄντοιν, τοῦ τε ὄντος καὶ τοῦ ποιοῦ τινος, οὐ τὸ ποῖόν τι, τὸ δὲ τί, ζητούσης εἰδέναι τῆς ψυχῆς, τὸ μὴ ζητούμενον ἕκαστον τῶν τεττάρων προτεῖνον τῇ ψυχῇ λόγῳ τε καὶ κατ' ἔργα, αἰσθήσεσιν εὐέλεγκτον τό τε λεγόμενον καὶ δεικνύμενον ἀεὶ παρεχόμενον ἕκαστον, ἀπορίας τε καὶ ἀσαφείας ἐμπίμπλησι πάσης ὡς ἔπος εἰπεῖν πάντ' ἄνδρα. ἐν οἷσι μὲν οὖν μὴδ' εἰθισμένοι τὸ ἀληθὲς ζητεῖν ἔσμεν ὑπὸ πονηρᾶς τροφῆς, ἐξαρκεῖ δὲ τὸ προταθὲν τῶν εἰδώλων, οὐ καταγέλαστοι γιγνόμεθα ὑπ' ἀλλήλων, οἱ ἐρωτῶμενοι ὑπὸ τῶν ἐρωτῶντων, δυναμένων δὲ τὰ τέτταρα διαρρίπτειν τε καὶ ἐλέγχειν· ἐν οἷς δ' ἂν τὸ πέμπτον ἀποκρίνασθαι καὶ δηλοῦν ἀναγκάζωμεν, ὁ βουλόμενος τῶν δυναμένων ἀνατρέπειν κρατεῖ. καὶ ποιεῖ τὸν ἐξηγούμενον ἐν λόγοις ἢ γράμμασιν ἢ ἀποκρίσεσιν τοῖς πολλοῖς τῶν ἀκουόντων δοκεῖν μηδὲν γινώσκειν ὧν ἂν ἐπιχειρῇ γράφειν ἢ λέγειν, ἀγνοούντων ἐνίστε ὡς οὐχ ἡ ψυχὴ τοῦ γράψαντος ἢ λέξαντος ἐλέγχεται, ἀλλ' ἡ τῶν τεττάρων φύσις ἐκάστου, πεφυκυῖα φαύλως. ἡ δὲ διὰ πάντων αὐτῶν διαγωγῇ, ἄνω καὶ κάτω μεταβαίνουσα ἐφ' ἕκαστον, μόγις ἐπιστήμην ἐνέτεκεν εὖ πεφυκότος εὖ πεφυκότι· κακῶς δὲ ἂν φυῇ, ὡς ἡ τῶν πολλῶν ἕξις τῆς ψυχῆς εἷς τε τὸ μαθεῖν εἷς τε τὰ λεγόμενα ἤθη πέφυκεν, τὰ δὲ διέφθαρται, οὐδ' ἂν ὁ Λυγκεὺς ἰδεῖν ποιήσειεν τοὺς τοιούτους. ἐνὶ δὲ λόγῳ, τὸν μὴ συγγενῇ τοῦ πράγματος οὗτ' ἂν εὐμάθεια ποιήσειέν ποτε οὔτε μνήμη— τὴν

ἀρχὴν γὰρ ἐν ἀλλοτρίαις ἔξεσιν οὐκ ἐγγίγνεται—ὥστε ὁπόσοι τῶν δικαίων τε καὶ τῶν ἄλλων ὅσα καλὰ μὴ προσφυεῖς εἰσιν καὶ συγγενεῖς, ἄλλοι δὲ ἄλλων εὐμαθεῖς ἅμα καὶ μνήμονες, οὐδ' ὅσοι συγγενεῖς, δυσμαθεῖς δὲ καὶ ἀμνήμονες, οὐδένες τούτων μήποτε μάθωσιν ἀλήθειαν ἀρετῆς εἰς τὸ δυνατόν οὐδὲ κακίας. ἅμα γὰρ αὐτὰ ἀνάγκη μανθάνειν καὶ τὸ ψευδὸς ἅμα καὶ ἀληθὲς τῆς ὅλης οὐσίας, μετὰ τριβῆς πάσης καὶ χρόνου πολλοῦ, ὅπερ ἐν ἀρχαῖς εἶπον· μόγις δὲ τριβόμενα πρὸς ἀλληλα αὐτῶν ἕκαστα, ὀνόματα καὶ λόγοι ὅψεις τε καὶ αἰσθήσεις, ἐν εὐμένεσιν ἐλέγχοις ἐλεγχόμενα καὶ ἄνευ φθόνων ἐρωτήσεσιν καὶ ἀποκρίσεσιν χρωμένων, ἐξέλαμψε φρόνησις περὶ ἕκαστον καὶ νοῦς, συντείνων ὅτι μάλιστ' εἰς δύναμιν ἀνθρωπίνην. διὸ δὴ πᾶς ἀνὴρ σπουδαῖος τῶν ὄντων σπουδαίων πέρι πολλοῦ δεῖ μὴ γράψας ποτὲ ἐν ἀνθρώποις εἰς φθόνον καὶ ἀπορίαν καταβαλεῖ. ἐνὶ δὴ ἐκ τούτων δεῖ γινώσκειν λόγῳ, ὅταν ἴδῃ τίς του συγγράμματα γεγραμμένα εἴτε ἐν νόμοις νομοθέτου εἴτε ἐν ἄλλοις τισὶν ἄττ' οὖν, ὡς οὐκ ἦν τούτῳ ταῦτα σπουδαιότατα, εἴπερ ἔστ' αὐτὸς σπουδαῖος, κεῖται δέ που ἐν χώρᾳ τῇ καλλίστῃ τῶν τούτου· εἰ δὲ ὄντως αὐτῷ ταῦτ' ἐσπουδασμένα ἐν γράμμασιν

344d

Anyone who has followed this story and digression of mine will appreciate full well that whether Dionysius has written about the primary principles of nature, or some lesser or greater person has done so, then, according to my account, he has not learned or understood anything sound about the matters on which he has written. Nor did he write this down as an aid to memory, for once someone has grasped this with his soul there is no danger that he might forget it. If he did actually write, he did so out of base ambition, as if he was presenting his own ideas or as if he had received an education of which he was not worthy, all from a love of the fame associated with its possession.

ἐτέθη, ἐξ ἅρα δὴ τοι ἔπειτα, θεοὶ μὲν οὐ, βροτοὶ δὲ φρένας ὤλεσαν αὐτοί. τούτῳ δὴ τῷ μύθῳ τε καὶ πλάνῳ ὁ συνεπισπόμενος εὖ εἴσεται, εἴτ' οὖν Διονύσιος ἔγραψεν τι τῶν περὶ φύσεως ἄκρων καὶ πρώτων εἴτε τις ἐλάττων εἴτε μείζων, ὡς οὐδὲν ἀκηκοὺς οὐδὲ μεμαθηκὺς ἦν ὑγιὲς

ὧν ἔγραψεν κατὰ τὸν ἐμὸν λόγον· ὁμοίως γὰρ ἂν αὐτὰ ἐσέβeto ἐμοί, καὶ οὐκ ἂν αὐτὰ ἐτόλμῃσεν εἰς ἀναρμοστίαν καὶ ἀπρέπειαν ἐκβάλλειν. οὔτε γὰρ ὑπομνημάτων χάριν ἔγραψεν—οὐδὲν γὰρ δεινὸν μὴ τις αὐτὸ ἐπιλάβηται, ἐὰν ἅπαξ τῇ ψυχῇ περιλάβῃ πάντων γὰρ ἐν βραχυτάτοις κεῖται— φιλοτιμίας δὲ αἰσχροῦς, εἴπερ, ἔνεκα, εἴθ' ὥς αὐτοῦ τιθέμενος εἴθ' ὥς παιδείας δὴ μέτοχος ὦν, ἧς οὐκ ἄξιος ἦν ἀγαπῶν δόξαν τὴν τῆς μετοχῆς γενομένης. εἰ μὲν οὖν ἐκ τῆς μιᾶς συνουσίας Διονυσίῳ τοῦτο γέγονεν, τάχ' ἂν εἴη, γέγονεν δ' οὖν ὅπως, ἴτω Ζεὺς, φησὶν ὁ Θηβαῖος· διεξήλθον μὲν γὰρ ὥς εἰπόν τε ἐγὼ καὶ ἅπαξ μόνον, ὕστερον δὲ οὐ πώποτε ἔτι. ἐννοεῖν δὴ δεῖ τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο, ὅτῳ μέλει τὸ περὶ αὐτὰ γεγονὸς εὐρεῖν ὅπῃ ποτὲ γέγονεν, τίνι πότ' αἰτία τὸ δεύτερον καὶ τὸ τρίτον, πλεονάκις τε οὐ διεξῆμιν· πότερον Διονύσιος ἀκούσας μόνον ἅπαξ, οὕτως εἰδέναι τε οἶται καὶ ἱκανῶς οἶδεν, εἴτε αὐτὸς εὐρὼν ἢ καὶ μαθὼν ἔμπροσθεν παρ' ἐτέρων, ἢ φαῦλα εἶναι τὰ λεχθέντα, ἢ τὸ τρίτον οὐ καθ' αὐτόν, μείζονα δέ, καὶ ὄντως οὐκ ἂν δυνατὸς εἶναι φρονήσεώς τε καὶ ἀρετῆς ζῆν ἐπιμελούμενος. εἰ μὲν γὰρ φαῦλα, πολλοῖς μάρτυσι μαχεῖται τὰ ἐναντία λέγουσιν, οἳ περὶ τῶν τοιούτων πάμπλου Διονυσίου κυριώτεροι ἂν εἶεν κριταί· εἰ δὲ ἡρῆκεναι ἢ μεμαθηκέναι, ἄξια δ' οὖν εἶναι πρὸς παιδείαν ψυχῆς ἐλευθέρως,

345c

Not long afterwards, although Dionysius had previously allowed Dion to retain his possessions and to derive income from them, he then no longer allowed Dion's trustees to send anything to the Peloponnese, as if he had completely forgotten about his own letter. He now maintained that the property belonged not to Dion but to his son, who was his own nephew and under his legal guardianship. These were the developments during my stay up to this point. But when matters unfolded in this way, I saw exactly the extent of Dionysius' desire for philosophy, and I had good reason to be annoyed. I thought I should tell Dionysius that because Dion had been treated so badly, it would be impossible for me to stay.

πῶς ἂν, μὴ θαυμαστὸς ὦν ἄνθρωπος, τὸν ἡγεμόνα τούτων καὶ κύριον οὕτως εὐχερῶς ἡτίμασέν ποτ' ἂν; πῶς δ' ἡτίμασεν, ἐγὼ φράζοιμ' ἂν. οὐ

πολὺν χρόνον διαλιπὼν τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο, ἐν τῷ πρόσθεν Δίωνα ἐὼν τὰ ἑαυτοῦ κεκτῆσθαι καὶ καρποῦσθαι χρήματα, τότε οὐκέτ' εἶα τοὺς ἐπιτρόπους αὐτοῦ πέμπειν εἰς Πελοπόννησον, καθάπερ ἐπιλελησμένος τῆς ἐπιστολῆς παντάπασιν· εἶναι γὰρ αὐτὰ οὐ Δίωνος ἀλλὰ τοῦ ὑέος, ὄντος μὲν ἀδελφιδοῦ αὐτοῦ κατὰ νόμους ἐπιτροπεύοντος. τὰ μὲν δὴ πεπραγμένα μέχρι τούτου ταῦτ' ἦν ἐν τῷ τότε χρόνῳ, τούτων δὲ οὕτω γενομένων, ἐωράκη τε ἐγὼ ἀκριβῶς τὴν ἐπιθυμίαν τὴν Διονυσίου φιλοσοφίας, ἀγανακτεῖν τε ἐξῆν εἴτε βουλοίμην εἴτε μή. ἦν γὰρ θέρος ἤδη τότε καὶ ἔκπλοι τῶν νεῶν· ἐδόκει δὴ χαλεπαίνειν μὲν οὐ δεῖν ἐμὲ Διονυσίῳ μᾶλλον ἢ ἑμαυτῷ τε καὶ τοῖς βιασαμένοις ἐλθεῖν ἐμὲ τὸ τρίτον εἰς τὸν πορθμὸν τὸν περὶ τὴν Σκύλλαν, ὅφρ' ἔτι τὴν ὁλοὴν ἀναμετρήσαιμι Χάρυβδιν, λέγειν δὲ πρὸς Διονύσιον ὅτι μοι μένειν ἀδύνατον εἶη Δίωνος οὕτω προπεπηλακισμένου. ὁ δὲ παρεμυθεῖτό τε καὶ ἐδεῖτο μένειν, οὐκ οἰόμενός οἱ καλῶς ἔχειν ἐμὲ ἄγγελον αὐτὸν τῶν τοιούτων ἐλθεῖν ὅτι τάχος· οὐ πείθων δὲ αὐτός μοι πομπήν

346a

But Dionysius came up with a plan to detain me for that sailing season. He arrived the following day and presented this persuasive argument: “You and I must get Dion and his affairs out of the way and get rid of our constant disputes over these issues. For your sake I will do the following for Dion. I think it best that he takes his property and lives on the Peloponnese, not as an exile, but with permission to return home here whenever this is agreed jointly by himself, by me, and by yourselves, his friends. So consider whether these proposals are acceptable to you, and stay for this year on these conditions, and next season you may take the money and depart.” When I heard this proposal I was annoyed. Nevertheless, I told him that I would give him my views on the matter the next day when I had thought about it.

παρασκευάσειν ἔφη. ἐγὼ γὰρ ἐν τοῖς ἀποστόλοις πλοίοις ἐμβὰς διεννοοῦμην πλεῖν, τεθυμωμένος, πάσχειν τε οἰόμενος δεῖν, εἰ διακωλυοίμην, ὅτιοῦν, ἐπειδὴ περιφανῶς ἡδίκουν μὲν οὐδέν, ἡδικοῦμην δέ· ὁ δὲ οὐδέν με τοῦ καταμένειν προσιέμενον ὀρῶν, μηχανὴν τοῦ μεῖναι τὸν τότε ἔκπλου μηχανᾶται τοιάνδε τινά. τῇ μετὰ

ταῦτα ἔλθων ἡμέρᾳ λέγει πρὸς με πιθανὸν λόγον· ἐμοὶ καὶ σοὶ δίων, ἔφη, καὶ τὰ Δίωνος ἐκποδὼν ἀπαλλαχθήτω τοῦ περὶ αὐτὰ πολλάκις διαφέρεισθαι· ποιήσω γὰρ διὰ σέ, ἔφη, Δίωني τάδε. ἀξιῶ ἐκεῖνον ἀπολαβόντα τὰ ἑαυτοῦ οἰκεῖν μὲν ἐν Πελοποννήσῳ, μὴ ὡς φυγάδα δέ, ἀλλ' ὡς αὐτῷ καὶ δεῦρο ἐξὸν ἀποδημεῖν, ὅταν ἐκείνῳ τε καὶ ἐμοὶ καὶ ὑμῖν τοῖς φίλοις κοινῇ συνδοκῇ ταῦτα δ' εἶναι μὴ ἐπιβουλεύοντος ἐμοί, τούτων δὲ ἐγγυητὰς γίνεσθαι σέ τε καὶ τοὺς σουὺς οἰκείους καὶ τοὺς ἐνθάδε Δίωνος, ὑμῖν δὲ τὸ βέβαιον ἐκεῖνος παρεχέτω. τὰ χρήματα δὲ ἃ ἂν λάβῃ, κατὰ Πελοπόννησον μὲν καὶ Ἀθήνας κείσθω παρ' οἷσιν ἂν ὑμῖν δοκῇ, καρπούσθω δὲ δίων, μὴ κύριος δὲ ἄνευ ὑμῶν γιγνέσθω ἀνελέσθαι. ἐγὼ γὰρ ἐκείνῳ μὲν οὐ σφόδρα πιστεύω τούτοις χρώμενον ἂν τοῖς χρήμασιν δίκαιον γίνεσθαι περὶ ἐμέ—οὐ γὰρ ὀλίγα ἔσται—σοὶ δὲ καὶ τοῖς σοῖς μᾶλλον πεπίστευκα. ὅρα δὴ ταῦτα εἴ σοι ἀρέσκει, καὶ μένε ἐπὶ τούτοις τὸν ἐνιαυτὸν τοῦτον, εἰς δὲ ὥρας ἅπθι λαβὼν τὰ χρήματα ταῦτα· καὶ δίων εὖ οἶδ' ὅτι πολλὴν χάριν ἔξει σοι διαπραξαμένῳ ταῦτα ὑπὲρ ἐκείνου. τοῦτον δὲ ἐγὼ τὸν λόγον ἀκούσας ἐδυσχέραινον μὲν, ὅμως δὲ βουλευσάμενος ἔφην εἰς τὴν ὑστεραίαν αὐτῷ περὶ τούτων τὰ δόξαντα ἀπαγγελεῖν. ταῦτα συνεθέμεθα τότε. ἐβουλεύομην δὴ τὸ μετὰ ταῦτα κατ' ἐμαυτὸν γενόμενος, μάλα συγκεχυμένος· πρῶτος δ' ἦν μοι τῆς βουλῆς ἡγούμενος ὁδε λόγος. φέρε, εἰ διανοεῖται τούτων μηδὲν ποιεῖν Διονύσιος ὢν φησιν, ἀπελθόντος δ' ἐμοῦ ἔαν ἐπιστέλλῃ Δίωني πιθανῶς, αὐτός τε καὶ ἄλλοις πολλοῖς τῶν αὐτοῦ διακελευόμενος, ἃ νῦν πρὸς ἐμέ λέγει, ὡς αὐτοῦ μὲν ἐθέλοντος, ἐμοῦ δὲ οὐκ ἐθέλησαντος ἃ προυκαλεῖτό με δρᾶν, ἀλλ' ὀλιγορήσαντος τῶν ἐκείνου τὸ παράπαν πραγμάτων, πρὸς δὲ καὶ τούτοις ἐτι μηδ' ἐθέλῃ με ἐκπέμπειν, αὐτὸς τῶν ναυκλήρων

347a

Having made my decisions, I told Dionysius the following day: “I have decided to stay, but I ask you not to presume that I have authority over Dion, but send a letter to him, jointly with myself, explaining what has now been agreed, and asking whether this is acceptable to him. Meanwhile, you should implement no new measures affecting Dion.” This is what was said, and this, more or less, was what we agreed upon.

After this, the ships sailed away. It was no longer possible for me to depart. But Dionysius followed up on his proposals in a most high-handed manner by selling Dion's property, in its entirety, as he pleased, to whomsoever he pleased, without saying anything to me about these plans.

μηδενὶ προστάττων, ἐνδείξεται δὲ πᾶσιν ῥαδίως ὡς ἀβουλῶν ἐμὲ ἐκπλεῖν, ἄρα τις ἐθελήσει με ἄγειν ναύτην ὁρμώμενον ἐκ τῆς Διονυσίου οἰκίας; —ὥρουν γὰρ πρὸς τοῖς ἄλλοις κακοῖς ἐν τῷ κήπῳ τῷ περὶ τὴν οἰκίαν, ὅθεν οὐδ' ἂν ὁ θυρωρὸς ἤθελέν με ἀφεῖναι μὴ πεμφθείσης αὐτῷ τινος ἐντολῆς παρὰ Διονυσίου— ἂν δὲ περιμείνω τὸν ἐνιαυτόν, ἔξω μὲν Δίῳνι ταῦτα ἐπιστέλλειν, ἐν οἷς τ' αὐτ' εἰμὶ καὶ ἃ πράττω· καὶ ἐὰν μὲν δὴ ποιῇ τι Διονύσιος ὧν φησιν, οὐ παντάπασιν ἔσται μοι καταγελάστως πεπραγμένα—τάλαντα γὰρ ἴσως ἐστὶν οὐκ ἔλαττον, ἂν ἐκτιμᾷ τις ὀρθῶς, ἑκατὸν ἢ Δίῳνος οὐσία—ἂν δ' οὖν γίγνηται τὰ νῦν ὑποφαίνοντα οἷα εἰκὸς αὐτὰ γίνεσθαι, ἀπορῶ μὲν ὅτι χρήσομαι ἐμαυτῷ, ὅμως δὲ ἀναγκαῖον ἴσως ἐνιαυτόν γ' ἔτι πονῆσαι καὶ ἔργοις ἐλέγξει πειραῖσθαι τὰς Διονυσίου μηχανάς. ταῦτά μοι δόξαντα, εἰς τὴν ὑστεραίαν εἶπον πρὸς Διονύσιον ὅτι δέδοκται μοι μένειν· ἀξιώ μὴν, ἔφη, μὴ κύριον ἡγεῖσθαι σε Δίῳνος ἐμέ, πέμπειν δὲ μετ' ἐμοῦ σὲ παρ' αὐτὸν γράμματα τὰ νῦν δεδογμένα δηλοῦντα, καὶ ἐρωτᾶν εἴτε ἀρκεῖ ταῦτα αὐτῷ, καὶ εἰ μὴ, βούλεται δὲ ἄλλ' ἅττα καὶ ἀξιοῖ, καὶ ταῦτα ἐπιστέλλειν ὅτι τάχιστα, σὲ δὲ νεωτερίζειν μηδὲν πω τῶν περὶ ἐκεῖνον. ταῦτα ἐρρήθη, ταῦτα συνωμολογήσαμεν, ὡς νῦν εἴρηται σχεδόν. ἐξέπλευσεν δὴ τὰ πλοῖα μετὰ τοῦτο, καὶ οὐκέτι μοι δυνατόν ἦν πλεῖν, ὅτε δὴ μοι καὶ Διονύσιος ἐμνήσθη λέγων ὅτι τὴν ἡμίσειαν τῆς οὐσίας εἶναι δύοι Δίῳνος, τὴν δ' ἡμίσειαν τοῦ ὕεος· ἔφη δὲ πωλήσειν αὐτήν, πραθείσης δὲ τὰ μὲν ἡμίσεα ἐμοὶ δώσειν ἄγειν, τὰ δ' ἡμίσεα τῷ παιδί καταλείψειν αὐτοῦ· τὸ γὰρ δὴ δικαιοτάτον οὕτως ἔχειν. πληγείς δ' ἐγὼ τῷ λεχθέντι πάνυ μὲν ὥμην γελοῖον εἶναι ἀντιλέγειν ἔτι, ὅμως δ' εἶπον ὅτι χρεῖη τὴν παρὰ Δίῳνος ἐπιστολὴν περιμένειν ἡμᾶς καὶ ταῦτα πάλιν αὐτὰ ἐπιστέλλειν. ὁ δὲ ἐξῆς τούτοις πάνυ νεανικῶς ἐπώλει τὴν οὐσίαν αὐτοῦ πᾶσαν, ὅπῃ τε καὶ ὅπως ἤθελε καὶ οἷστισι, πρὸς ἐμὲ δὲ οὐδὲν ὅλως ἐφθέγγετο περὶ αὐτῶν, καὶ μὴν ὡσαύτως ἐγὼ πρὸς ἐκεῖνον αὖ

περὶ τῶν Δίωνος πραγμάτων οὐδὲν ἔτι διελεγόμην· οὐδὲν γὰρ ἔτι πλέον ὥμην ποιεῖν. μέχρι μὲν δὴ τούτων ταύτῃ μοι βεβοηθημένον ἐγεγόνει φιλοσοφία καὶ φίλοις· τὸ δὲ μετὰ ταῦτα ἐζῶμεν ἐγὼ καὶ

348a

Until these developments took place, I had been acting in support of philosophy and my friends, but afterwards, Dionysius and I lived differently. I was looking outwards like a bird yearning to fly away from the place, while he was working out how he might intimidate me without giving away any of Dion's property. Then, contrary to the practice of his father, Dionysius tried to reduce the pay of his older mercenaries. But the soldiers, being angry, banded together and charged the walls, shouting some barbaric war cry, at which Dionysius became fearful and conceded all the demands. Word quickly spread that Heraclides had been responsible for these troubles, and when the man heard this he took himself off and disappeared, while Dionysius tried to capture him.

Διονύσιος, ἐγὼ μὲν βλέπων ἔξω, καθάπερ ὄρνις ποθῶν ποθεν ἀναπτέσθαι, ὁ δὲ διαμηχανώμενος τίνα τρόπον ἀνασοβήσοι με μηδὲν ἀποδοὺς τῶν Δίωνος· ὅμως δὲ ἔφαμεν ἐταῖροί γε εἶναι πρὸς πᾶσαν Σικελίαν. τῶν δὴ μισθοφόρων τοὺς πρεσβυτέρους Διονύσιος ἐπεχείρησεν ὀλιγομισθοτέρους ποιεῖν παρὰ τὰ τοῦ πατρὸς ἔθη, θυμωθέντες δὲ οἱ στρατιῶται συνελέγησαν ἄθροοι καὶ οὐκ ἔφασαν ἐπιτρέψειν. ὁ δ' ἐπεχείρει βιάζεσθαι κλείσας τὰς τῆς ἀκροπόλεως πύλας, οἱ δ' ἐφέροντο εὐθὺς πρὸς τὰ τεῖχη, παιῶνά τινα ἀναβοήσαντες βάρβαρον καὶ πολεμικόν· οὗ δὴ περιδεὴς Διονύσιος γενόμενος ἅπαντα συνεχώρησεν καὶ ἔτι πλείω τοῖς τότε συλληχθεῖσι τῶν πελταστῶν. λόγος δὴ τις ταχὺ διῆλθεν ὡς Ἡρακλείδης αἴτιος εἶη γεγονώς πάντων τούτων· ὃν ἀκούσας ὁ μὲν Ἡρακλείδης ἐκποδὼν αὐτὸν ἔσχεν ἀφανῇ, Διονύσιος

348c

He summoned Theodotes to the garden where I happened to be walking at the time. I know and remember what Theodotes said to Dionysius in my presence: "Plato, I am in the process of persuading

Dionysius here that should I prove capable of getting Heraclides to come here to discuss the accusations that have now been made against him, I think it best that he set sail for the Peloponnese, taking his wife and son, and dwell there without being a threat to Dionysius. I ask and implore Dionysius, should someone come across Heraclides, either in the countryside or here in the city, let no harm come to him apart from being deported from this land.” Then, addressing Dionysius, he said, “Do you agree with this?” “I agree,” said he. “And even if he turns up in your own home, he shall suffer no harm beyond what has just been said.”

δὲ ἐζήτει λαβεῖν, ἀπορῶν δέ, Θεοδότην μεταπεμψάμενος εἰς τὸν κῆπον —ἔτυχον δ’ ἐν τῷ κήπῳ καὶ ἐγὼ τότε περιπατῶν—τὰ μὲν οὖν ἄλλα οὐτ’ οἶδα οὐτ’ ἤκουον διαλεγομένων, ἃ δὲ ἐναντίον εἶπεν Θεοδότης ἐμοῦ πρὸς Διονύσιον, οἶδά τε καὶ μέμνημαι. Πλάτων γάρ, ἔφη, Διονύσιον ἐγὼ πείθω τουτονί, ἐὰν ἐγὼ γένωμαι δεῦρο Ἑρακλείδην κομίσαι δυνατὸς ἡμῖν εἰς λόγους περὶ τῶν ἐγκλημάτων αὐτῷ τῶν νῦν γεγονότων, ἂν ἄρα μὴ δόξῃ δεῖν αὐτὸν οἰκεῖν ἐν Σικελίᾳ, τὸν τε ὑὸν λαβόντα καὶ τὴν γυναῖκα ἀξιῶ εἰς Πελοπόννησον ἀποπλεῖν, οἰκεῖν τε βλάπτοντα μηδὲν Διονύσιον ἐκεῖ, καρπούμενον δὲ τὰ ἑαυτοῦ. μετεπεμψάμην μὲν οὖν καὶ πρότερον αὐτόν, μεταπέμψομαι δὲ καὶ νῦν, ἄντ’ οὖν ἀπὸ τῆς προτέρας μεταπομπῆς ἄντε καὶ ἀπὸ τῆς νῦν ὑπακούσῃ μοι Διονύσιον δὲ ἀξιῶ καὶ δέομαι, ἂν τις ἐντυχάνῃ Ἑρακλείδην ἐάντ’ ἐν ἀγρῷ ἐάντ’ ἐνθάδε, μηδὲν ἄλλο αὐτῷ φλαῦρον γίγνεσθαι, μεταστῆναι δ’ ἐκ τῆς χώρας, ἕως ἂν ἄλλο τι Διονυσίῳ δόξῃ. ταῦτα, ἔφη, συγχωρεῖς; λέγων πρὸς τὸν Διονύσιον. συγχωρῶ· μηδ’ ἂν πρὸς τῇ σῇ, ἔφη, φανῇ οἰκία, πείσεσθαι φλαῦρον μηδὲν παρὰ τὰ νῦν εἰρημένα. τῇ δὴ μετὰ ταύτην τὴν ἡμέραν δείλης Εὐρύβιος καὶ Θεοδότης προσηλθέτην μοι σπουδῇ τεθορυβημένῳ θαυμαστῶς, καὶ Θεοδότης λέγει, Πλάτων, ἔφη, παρήσθα χθές οἷς περὶ Ἑρακλείδου Διονύσιος ὠμολόγει πρὸς ἐμέ καὶ σέ; πῶς δὲ οὐκ; ἔφην. νῦν τοίνυν, ἣ δ’ ὅς, περιθέουσιν πελτασταὶ λαβεῖν Ἑρακλείδην ζητοῦντες, ὁ δὲ εἶναί πη ταύτην κινδυνεύει· ἄλλ’ ἡμῖν, ἔφη,

The next day, during the afternoon, Eurybius and Theodotes came to me in a hurry, remarkably troubled, and Theodotes said, “Plato, you were present yesterday when Dionysius entered into an agreement with both of us in relation to Heraclides, were you not?” “Of course,” I replied. “Well, right now,” said he, “there are peltasts running around seeking to apprehend Heraclides. But you really need to come with us to Dionysius.” So we set off, gained admission, and while the other two stood tearfully in silence, I said, “My friends here are afraid that you might do something high-handed in relation to Heraclides, contrary to what we agreed yesterday.” When Dionysius heard this he was enraged. But I said, “Take heart, Theodotes, for Dionysius will never be so bold to do anything contrary to what was agreed yesterday.” But Dionysius, in a highly tyrannical manner, said, “With you I agreed nothing, great or small.” “Yes you did, by the gods,” said I. “You agreed not to do the very things this man is now asking you not to do.” And with these words I turned around and walked out.

συνακολούθησον πρὸς Διονύσιον ἀπάσῃ μηχανῇ. ὥχόμεθα οὖν καὶ εἰσέλθομεν παρ’ αὐτόν, καὶ τὼ μὲν ἐστάτην σιγῇ δακρύνοντε, ἐγὼ δὲ εἶπον· οἶδε πεφόβηνται μὴ τι σὺ παρὰ τὰ χθὲς ὠμολογημένα ποιήσης περὶ Ἡρακλείδην νεώτερον· δοκεῖ γάρ μοι ταύτῃ πῃ γεγονέναι φανερὸς ἀποτετραμμένος. ὁ δὲ ἀκούσας ἀνεφλέχθη τε καὶ παντοδαπὰ χρώματα ἤκεν, οἱ ἂν θυμούμενος ἀφεΐη προσπεσὼν δ’ αὐτῷ ὁ Θεοδότης, λαβόμενος τῆς χειρὸς ἐδάκρυσέν τε καὶ ἰκέτευεν μηδὲν τοιοῦτον ποιεῖν, ὑπολαβὼν δ’ ἐγὼ παραμυθούμενος, θάρρει, Θεοδότα, ἔφην· οὐ γὰρ τολμήσει Διονύσιος παρὰ τὰ χθὲς ὠμολογημένα ἄλλα ποτὲ δρᾶν. καὶ ὃς ἐμβλέψας μοι καὶ μάλα τυραννικῶς, σοί, ἔφη, ἐγὼ οὔτε τι σμικρὸν οὔτε μέγα ὠμολόγησα. νῆ τοὺς θεοὺς, ἦν δ’ ἐγώ, σύ γε, ταῦτα ἃ σοῦ νῦν οὗτος δεῖται μὴ ποιεῖν· καὶ εἰπὼν ταῦτα ἀποστρεφόμενος ὥχομην ἔξω. τὸ μετὰ

349c

After this, Dionysius continued to hunt down Heraclides. According to reports, Heraclides was a few hours ahead of them and escaped into Carthaginian territory. After this, his ongoing plan to hold onto Dion’s

property seemed to afford Dionysius a convincing basis for enmity with myself. First, he expelled me from the acropolis. While I was staying outside the acropolis, Theodotes sent for me, and complained at length about everything that had happened. He then indicated to me that I was not acting at all well in attaching more importance to Dion and his friends than to Dionysius himself.

ταῦτα ὁ μὲν ἐκυνήγει τὸν Ἡρακλείδην, Θεοδότης δὲ ἀγγέλους πέμπων Ἡρακλείδῃ φεύγειν διεκελεύετο. ὁ δὲ ἐκπέμψας Τεισίαν καὶ πελταστὰς διώκειν ἐκέλευε· φθάνει δέ, ὡς ἐλέγετο, Ἡρακλείδης εἰς τὴν Καρχηδονίων ἐπικράτειαν ἐκφυγὼν ἡμέρας μικρῷ τινι μέρει. τὸ δὴ μετὰ τοῦτο ἢ πάλαι ἐπιβουλὴ Διονυσίῳ τοῦ μὴ ἀποδοῦναι τὰ Δίωνος χρήματα ἔδοξεν ἔχθρας λόγον ἔχειν ἂν πρὸς με πιθανόν, καὶ πρῶτον μὲν ἐκ τῆς ἀκροπόλεως ἐκπέμπει με, εὐρὼν πρόφασιν ὡς τὰς γυναῖκας ἐν τῷ κήπῳ, ἐν ᾧ κατώκουν ἐγώ, δεοὶ θῆσαι θυσίαν τινὰ δεχήμερον· ἔξω δὴ με παρ' Ἀρχεδήμῳ προσέταττεν τὸν χρόνον τοῦτον μεῖναι. ὄντος δ' ἐμοῦ ἐκεῖ, Θεοδότης μεταπεμψάμενός με πολλὰ περὶ τῶν τότεπραχθέντων ἡγανάκτει καὶ ἐμέμφετο Διονυσίῳ· ὁ δ' ἀκούσας ὅτι παρὰ Θεοδότην εἶην εἰσεληλυθώς, πρόφασιν

349e

Thereafter, I was residing outside the acropolis among the mercenaries. Various people came to me, including some ships' rowers who were fellow citizens from Athens, advising me that damaging stories about me were spreading amongst the peltasts, some of whom were threatening to kill me if they ever got their hands on me. So, I sent word to Archytas and other friends in Tarentum, explaining the predicament I happened to be in. Under the pretext of an embassy from their city, they sent a thirty-oared boat and also one of their own people, Lamiskus, who, on arrival, made a request to Dionysius concerning myself, saying that I wished to depart, and asking that he do nothing whatsoever to stop me. He agreed, and sent me on my way having given me provisions for the journey.

αὐτὴν ἄλλην τῆς πρὸς ἐμὲ διαφορᾶς ποιούμενος, ἀδελφὴν τῆς πρόσθεν, πέμψας τινὰ ἡρώτα με εἰ συγγιγνοίμην ὄντως μεταπεμψαμένου με Θεοδότου. καὶ γὰρ, παντάπασιν, ἔφη· ὁ δέ, ἐκέλευε τοίνυν, ἔφη, σοὶ φράζειν ὅτι καλῶς οὐδαμῇ ποιεῖς Δίωνα καὶ τοὺς Δίωνος φίλους αἰεὶ περὶ πλείονος αὐτοῦ ποιούμενος. ταῦτ' ἐρρήθη, καὶ οὐκέτι μετεπέμψατό με εἰς τὴν οἴκησιν ἄλιν, ὡς ἤδη σαφῶς Θεοδότου μὲν ὄντος μου καὶ Ἡρακλείδου φίλου, αὐτοῦ δ' ἐχθροῦ, καὶ οὐκ εὖ νοεῖν ὤφετό με, ὅτι Δίῳνι τὰ χρήματα ἔρρει παντελῶς. ὥκουν δὲ τὸ μετὰ τοῦτο ἔξω τῆς ἀκροπόλεως ἐν τοῖς μισθοφόροις προσιόντες δέ μοι ἄλλοι τε καὶ οἱ τῶν ὑπηρεσιῶν ὄντες Ἀθήνηθεν, ἐμοὶ πολῖται, ἀπήγγελλον ὅτι διαβεβλημένος εἶην ἐν τοῖς πελτασταῖς καὶ μοί τινες ἀπειλοῖεν, εἴ ποὺ λήψονταί με, διαφθερεῖν. μηχανῶμαι δὲ τίνα τοιάνδε σωτηρίαν. πέμπω παρ' Ἀρχύτην καὶ τοὺς ἄλλους φίλους εἰς Τάραντα, φράζων ἐν οἷς ὧν τυγχάνω· οἱ δὲ πρόφασιν τίνα πρεσβείας πορισάμενοι παρὰ τῆς πόλεως πέμπουσιν

350b

On reaching the Peloponnese at Olympia I came across Dion, who was a spectator at the Games, and I told him all that happened. He, calling upon Zeus as his witness, immediately exhorted myself and my associates and friends to make arrangements to take revenge on Dionysius. Having heard this, I encouraged him to call upon my friends to help him if they wished to do so. "As for myself," said I, "it was you, along with others, who somehow forced me to share the table and hearth of Dionysius and join in his sacred rites. And although he probably believed that I was plotting along with you against himself and the tyranny, he nevertheless did not have me put to death, but showed me respect. Now, I am no longer really at an age to be of military assistance to anybody, but if you ever feel the need for friendship towards one another and wish to do one another some good, I am fully available to both sides."

τριακόντορόν τε καὶ λαμίσκον αὐτῶν ἓνα, ὃς ἐλθὼν ἐδεῖτο Διονυσίου περὶ ἐμοῦ, λέγων ὅτι βουλοίμην ἀπιέναι, καὶ μηδαμῶς ἄλλως ποιεῖν. ὁ δὲ συνωμολόγησεν καὶ ἀπέπεμψεν ἐφόδια δούς, τῶν Δίωνος δὲ

χρημάτων οὐτ' ἐγὼ ἔτι ἀπῆτουν οὔτε τις ἀπέδωκεν. ἐλθὼν δὲ εἰς
 Πελοπόννησον εἰς Ὀλυμπίαν, Δίωνα καταλαβὼν θεωροῦντα, ἡγγελλον
 τὰ γεγονότα· ὁ δὲ τὸν Δία ἐπιμαρτυράμενος εὐθὺς παρήγγελλεν ἐμοὶ
 καὶ τοῖς ἐμοῖς οἰκείοις καὶ φίλοις παρασκευάζεσθαι τιμωρεῖσθαι
 Διονύσιον, ἡμᾶς μὲν ξεναπατίας χάριν—οὕτω γὰρ ἔλεγεν τε καὶ ἐνόει—
 αὐτὸν δ' ἐκβολῆς ἀδίκου καὶ φυγῆς. ἀκούσας δ' ἐγὼ τοὺς μὲν φίλους
 παρακαλεῖν αὐτὸν ἐκέλευον, εἰ βούλοιντο· ἐμὲ δ' εἶπον ὅτι σὺ μετὰ τῶν
 ἄλλων βία τινὰ τρόπον σύσσειτον καὶ συνέσειτον καὶ κοινωνὸν ἱερῶν
 Διονυσίῳ ἐποίησας, ὃς ἴσως ἡγεῖτο διαβαλλόντων πολλῶν
 ἐπιβουλεύειν ἐμὲ μετὰ σοῦ ἑαυτῷ καὶ τῇ τυραννίδι, καὶ ὅμως οὐκ
 ἀπέκτεινεν, ἥδεσθη δέ. οὐτ' οὖν ἡλικίαν ἔχω συμπολεμεῖν ἔτι σχεδὸν
 οὐδενί, κοινός τε ὑμῖν εἰμι, ἂν ποτέ τι πρὸς ἀλλήλους δεηθέντες φιλίας
 ἀγαθὸν τι ποιεῖν βουλευθῇτε· κακὰ δὲ ἕως ἂν ἐπιθυμῇτε, ἄλλους
 παρακαλεῖτε. ταῦτα εἶπον μεμισηκῶς τὴν περὶ Σικελίαν πλάνην καὶ
 ἀτυχίαν· ἀπειθοῦντες δὲ καὶ οὐ πειθόμενοι ταῖς ὑπ' ἐμοῦ διαλλάξεσιν
 πάντων τῶν νῦν γεγονότων κακῶν αὐτοὶ αἴτιοι ἐγένοντο αὐτοῖς, ὧν, εἰ
 Διονύσιος ἀπέδωκεν τὰ χρήματα Δίῳ ἢ καὶ παντάπασι κατηλλάγη, οὐκ
 ἂν ποτε ἐγένετο οὐδέν, ὅσα γε δὴ τάνθρώπινα—Δίωνα γὰρ ἐγὼ καὶ τῷ
 βούλεσθαι καὶ τῷ δύνασθαι κατεῖχον ἂν ῥαδίως—νῦν δὲ ὀρμήσαντες
 ἐπ' ἀλλήλους κακῶν πάντα ἐμπεπλήκασιν.

351a

Dion had the same intention as I would attribute to myself or, indeed, anyone else who is reasonable and intends to confer the greatest benefits in terms of power and honour on himself, his friends and his own city to the greatest possible extent. For neither Dion nor anyone else ever intentionally pursues power that will be a curse for all time to himself and his family. They pursue, rather, a political system and the provision of the best and most just laws, introduced without any murders or slayings. This is what Dion was engaged in at the time, preferring to suffer unrighteous deeds rather than perform them. For a righteous person, being sound-minded and sensible, would never wholly be deceived about the souls of any unrighteous people he was dealing with. This same failure brought Dion down, for although he

was fully aware that those who brought him down were bad people, he failed to notice the height of ignorance they had attained, and their general depravity and greed, and because he overlooked this he now lies fallen, bringing countless misfortunes upon Sicily. As for the situation following the events described, the advice I have to offer has more or less been presented, so let that suffice.

καίτοι τήν γε αὐτὴν δίων εἶχεν βούλησιν ἥνπερ ἂν ἐγὼ φαίην δεῖν ἐμὲ καὶ ἄλλον, ὅστις μέτριος, περὶ τε τῆς αὐτοῦ δυνάμεως καὶ φίλων καὶ περὶ πόλεως τῆς αὐτοῦ διανοοῖτ' ἂν εὐεργετῶν ἐν δυνάμει καὶ τιμαῖσιν γενέσθαι τὰ μέγιστα ἐν ταῖς μεγίσταις. ἔστιν δὲ οὐκ ἂν τις πλούσιον ἑαυτὸν ποιήσῃ καὶ ἐταίρους καὶ πόλιν, ἐπιβουλεύσας καὶ συνωμότας συναγαγών, πένης ὦν καὶ ἑαυτοῦ μὴ κρατῶν, ὑπὸ δειλίας τῆς πρὸς τὰς ἡδονὰς ἡττημένος, εἴτα τοὺς τὰς οὐσίας κεκτημένους ἀποκτείνας, ἐχθροὺς καλῶν τούτους, διαφορῇ τὰ τούτων χρήματα καὶ τοῖς συνεργοῖς τε καὶ ἐταίροις παρακελεύηται ὅπως μηδεὶς αὐτῷ ἐγκαλεῖ πένης φάσκων εἶναι· ταῦτόν δὲ καὶ τὴν πόλιν ἂν οὕτω τις εὐεργετῶν τιμᾷται ὑπ' αὐτῆς, τοῖς πολλοῖς τὰ τῶν ὀλίγων ὑπὸ ψηφισμάτων διανέμων, ἢ μεγάλης προεστῶς πόλεως καὶ πολλῶν ἀρχούσης ἐλαττόνων, τῇ ἑαυτοῦ πόλει τὰ τῶν σμικροτέρων χρήματα διανέμῃ μὴ κατὰ δίκην. οὕτω μὲν γὰρ οὔτε δίων οὔτε ἄλλος πετὲ οὐδεὶς ἐπὶ δύναμιν ἐκὼν εἴσιν ἀλιτηριώδη ἑαυτῷ τε καὶ γένει εἰς τὸν αἰὲ χρόνον, ἐπὶ πολιτείαν δὲ καὶ νόμων κατασκευὴν τῶν δικαιοτάτων τε καὶ ἀρίστων, οὗ τι δι' ὀλιγίστων θανάτων καὶ φόνων γιγνομένην· ἃ δὴ δίων νῦν πράττων, προτιμήσας τὸ πάσχειν ἀνόσια τοῦ δρᾶσαι πρότερον, διευλαβούμενος δὲ μὴ παθεῖν, ὅμως ἔπταισεν ἐπ' ἄκρον ἐλθὼν τοῦ περιγενέσθαι τῶν ἐχθρῶν, θαυμαστὸν παθὼν οὐδέν. ὅσιος γὰρ ἄνθρωπος ἀνοσίων πέρι, σῶφρων τε καὶ ἔμφρων, τὸ μὲν ὅλον οὐκ ἂν ποτε διαψευσθεῖη τῆς ψυχῆς τῶν τοιούτων πέρι, κυβερνήτου δὲ ἀγαθοῦ πάθος ἂν ἴσως οὐ θαυμαστὸν εἰ πάθοι, ὃν χειμῶν μὲν ἐσόμενος οὐκ ἂν πάνυ λάθοι, χειμῶνων δὲ ἐξαίσιον καὶ ἀπροσδόκητον μέγεθος λάθοι τ' ἂν καὶ λαθὼν κατακλύσειεν βίᾳ. ταῦτόν δὲ καὶ Δίωνα ἔσφηλεν· κακοὶ μὲν γὰρ ὄντες αὐτὸν σφόδρα οὐκ ἔλαθον οἱ σφήλαντες, ὅσον δὲ ὕψος ἀμαθίας εἶχον καὶ τῆς ἄλλης μοχθηρίας τε καὶ λαιμαργίας,

ἔλαθον, ὧς δὴ σφαλεῖς κεῖται, Σικελίαν πένθει περιβαλὼν μυρίῳ. τὰ δὴ μετὰ τὰ νῦν ῥηθέντα ἅ συμβουλευώ, σχεδὸν εἴρηται τέ μοι καὶ εἰρήσθω· ὧν δ' ἐπανελάβον ἔνεκα τὴν εἰς Σικελίαν ἄφιξιν τὴν δευτέραν, ἀναγκαῖον εἶναι ἔδοξέ μοι ῥηθῆναι δεῖν διὰ τὴν ἀτοπίαν καὶ ἀλογίαν τῶν γενομένων. εἰ δ' ἄρα τινὶ νῦν ῥηθέντα εὐλογώτερα ἐφάνη καὶ προφάσεις πρὸς τὰ γενόμενα ἱκανὰς ἔχειν ἔδοξέν τω, μετρίως ἂν ἡμῖν καὶ ἱκανῶς εἴη τὰ νῦν εἰρημένα.

352b

EH: EIGHTH EPISTLE Plato to the relatives and associates of Dion: may ye fare well

352b

I shall attempt to explain to you, as best I can, what principles you should keep in mind if you really are to fare well. Now that the tyranny has been undone, your entire struggle throughout all of Sicily involves two factions, one side wishing to restore the regime again, the other wishing to finalise the elimination of the tyranny. Now, most people in such situations think the correct advice about such matters is to recommend whatever will do most harm to your enemies and most good to your friends. But it is not at all easy while doing much harm to others to avoid suffering a lot of other evils yourself.

Πλάτων τοῖς Δίῳνος οἰκείοις τε καὶ ἐταίροις εὖ πράττειν. ἃ δ' ἂν διανοηθέντες μάλιστα εὖ πράττοιτε ὄντως, πειράσσομαι ταῦθ' ὑμῖν κατὰ δύναμιν διεξελθεῖν. ἐλπίζω δὲ οὐχ ὑμῖν μόνοις συμβουλευσεῖν τὰ συμφέροντα, μάλιστα γε μὴν ὑμῖν, καὶ δευτέροις πᾶσιν τοῖς ἐν Συρακούσαις, τρίτοις δὲ ὑμῶν καὶ τοῖς ἐχθροῖς καὶ πολεμίοις, πλὴν εἴ τις αὐτῶν ἀνοσιουργὸς γέγονεν· ταῦτα γὰρ ἀνιάτα καὶ οὐκ ἂν ποτέ τις αὐτὰ ἐκνίψειν. νοήσατε δὲ ἃ λέγω νῦν. ἔσθ' ὑμῖν κατὰ Σικελίαν πᾶσαν λελυμένης τῆς τυραννίδος πᾶσα μάχη περὶ αὐτῶν τούτων, τῶν μὲν βουλομένων ἀναλαβεῖν πάλιν τὴν ἀρχήν, τῶν δὲ τῇ τῆς τυραννίδος ἀποφυγῇ τέλος ἐπιθεῖναι. συμβουλή δὴ περὶ τῶν τοιούτων ὀρθὴ δοκεῖ ἐκάστοτε τοῖς πολλοῖς εἶναι ταῦτα συμβουλευεῖν δεῖν ἅ τοὺς μὲν πολεμίους ὡς πλεῖστα κακὰ ἐξεργάσεται, τοὺς δὲ φίλους ὡς πλεῖστα ἀγαθὰ· τὸ δὲ οὐδαμῶς ῥάδιον πολλὰ κακὰ δρῶντα τοὺς ἄλλους μὴ οὐ

καὶ πάσχειν αὐτὸν πολλὰ ἕτερα. δεῖ δὲ οὐ μακρὰν ἐλθόντας ποι τὰ τοιαῦτα ἐναργῶς ἰδεῖν, ἀλλ' ὅσα νῦν γέγονεν τῇδε, αὐτοῦ περὶ Σικελίαν, τῶν μὲν ἐπιχειρούντων δρᾶν, τῶν δὲ ἀμύνασθαι τοὺς δρῶντας· ἃ καὶ ἄλλοις μυθολογοῦντες ἱκανοὶ γίγνοισθ' ἂν ἐκάστοτε διδάσκαλοι. τούτων μὲν δὴ σχεδὸν οὐκ ἀπορία· τῶν δὲ ὅσα γένοιτ' ἂν ἢ πᾶσιν συμφέροντα ἐχθροῖς τε καὶ φίλοις ἢ ὅτι σμικρότατα κακὰ ἀμφοῖν, ταῦτα οὔτε ῥάδιον ὁρᾶν οὔτε ἰδόντα ἐπιτελεῖν, εὐχῇ δὲ προσέοικεν ἢ τοιαύτη συμβουλή τε καὶ ἐπιχείρησις τοῦ λόγου. ἔστω δὴ παντάπασι

353a

Let this then be a prayer in all respects. Now, and ever since the war began, yourselves and your enemies have been ruled throughout, more or less, by a single family which your ancestors once appointed in their hour of utmost need, at a time when there was an extreme threat to Greek Sicily of being entirely overrun by the Carthaginians. For they then chose Dionysius, who was young and warlike, for the military activities that suited him, and Hipparinus as his senior adviser. For the safety of Sicily, these two were appointed as sole rulers, or, in other words, as tyrants.

μὲν εὐχὴ τις—ἀπὸ γὰρ θεῶν χρή πάντα ἀρχόμενον αἰεὶ λέγειν τε καὶ νοεῖν—ἐπιτελῆς δ' εἴη σημαίνουσα ἡμῖν τοιόνδε τινὰ λόγον· νῦν ὑμῖν καὶ τοῖς πολεμίοις σχεδόν, ἔξ οὔπερ γέγονεν ὁ πόλεμος, συγγένεια ἄρχει μία διὰ τέλους, ἥν ποτε κατέστησαν οἱ πατέρες ὑμῶν ἐς ἀπορίαν ἐλθόντες τὴν ἅπασαν, τόθ' ὅτε κίνδυνος ἐγένετο ἔσχατος Σικελίᾳ τῇ τῶν Ἑλλήνων ὑπὸ Καρχηδονίων ἀνάστατον ὄλην ἐκβαρβαρωθεῖσαν γενέσθαι. τότε γὰρ εἴλοντο Διονύσιον μὲν ὡς νέον καὶ πολεμικὸν ἐπὶ τὰς τοῦ πολέμου πρεπούσας αὐτῷ πράξεις, σύμβουλον δὲ καὶ πρεσβύτερον Ἰππαρίνον, ἐπὶ σωτηρίᾳ τῆς Σικελίας αὐτοκράτορας, ὡς φασιν, τυράννους ἐπονομάζοντες. καὶ εἴτε δὴ θεῖαν τις ἡγεῖσθαι βούλεται τύχην καὶ θεὸν εἴτε τὴν τῶν ἀρχόντων ἀρετὴν εἴτε καὶ τὸ συναμφοτέρων μετὰ τῶν τότε πολιτῶν τῆς σωτηρίας αἰτίαν συμβῆναι γενομένην, ἔστω ταύτῃ ὅπῃ τις ὑπολαμβάνει· σωτηρία δ' οὖν οὕτως συνέβη τοῖς τότε γενομένοις. τοιούτων οὖν αὐτῶν γεγονότων, δίκαιόν

που τοῖς σώσασιν πάντας χάριν ἔχειν· εἰ δέ τι τὸν μετέπειτα χρόνον ἢ τυραννὸς οὐκ ὀρθῶς τῇ τῆς πόλεως δωρεᾷ κατακέχρηται, τούτων δίκας τὰς μὲν ἔχει, τὰς δὲ τινέτω. τίνες οὖν δὴ δίκαι ἀναγκαίως ὀρθαὶ γίνονται ἂν ἐκ τῶν ὑπαρχόντων αὐτοῖς; εἰ μὲν ῥαδίως ὑμεῖς ἀποφυγεῖν οἰοί τ' ἦτε αὐτοὺς καὶ ἄνευ μεγάλων κινδύνων καὶ πόνων, ἢ 'κεῖνοι ἐλεῖν εὐπετῶς πάλιν τὴν ἀρχήν, οὐδ' ἂν συμβουλευεῖν οἷόν τ' ἦν τὰ μέλλοντα ῥηθῆσθαι· νῦν

353d

Now, it is perhaps only right that those who were saved should all be grateful after such achievements as these. But now both sides need to bear in mind just how often you have both presumed, with high expectations, that something minor was all that was needed in order to achieve your objectives. But note that this minor detail proves again and again to be the cause of countless evils. No limit is ever reached. The conclusion of a past issue always seems to be linked to the beginning of a new one, and because of this cycle there is a danger that the entire class of tyrannical folk, and democratic folk too, will be destroyed. It therefore behoves all Greeks, with all eagerness, to come up with a remedy for these evils.

δ' ἐννοεῖν ὑμᾶς ἀμφοτέρους χρεὼν καὶ ἀναμιμνήσκεσθαι ποσάκις ἐν ἐλπίδι ἐκάτεροι γεγονάτε τοῦ νῦν οἶεσθαι σχεδὸν αἰεὶ τινος σμικροῦ ἐπιδεεῖς εἶναι τὸ μὴ πάντα κατὰ νοῦν πράττειν, καὶ δὴ καὶ ὅτι τὸ σμικρὸν τοῦτο μεγάλων καὶ μυρίων κακῶν αἴτιον ἐκάστοτε συμβαίνει γιγνόμενον, καὶ πέρας οὐδέν ποτε τελεῖται, συνάπτει δὲ αἰεὶ παλαιὰ τελευτὴ δοκοῦσα ἀρχῇ φυομένη νέᾳ, διολέσθαι δ' ὑπὸ τοῦ κύκλου τούτου κινδυνεύσει καὶ τὸ τυραννικὸν ἅπαν καὶ τὸ δημοτικὸν γένος, ἥξει δέ, ἕανπερ τῶν εἰκότων γίγνηται τι καὶ ἀπευκτῶν, σχεδὸν εἰς ἐρημίαν τῆς Ἑλληνικῆς φωνῆς Σικελία πᾶσα, Φοινίκων ἢ Ὀπικῶν μεταβαλοῦσα εἰς τινα δυναστείαν καὶ κράτος. τούτων δὲ χρὴ πάσῃ προθυμίᾳ πάντας τοὺς Ἕλληνας τέμνειν φάρμακον. εἰ μὲν δὴ τις ὀρθότερον ἄμεινόν τ' ἔχει τοῦ ὑπ' ἐμοῦ ῥηθησομένου, ἐνεγκὼν εἰς τὸ μέσον

354a

I shall now try to set out for you my own present views, in all frankness, based on our shared concept of justice. For I am speaking as a sort of arbitrator conversing with the two parties, the former tyrant and the subjects of the tyrant. Now, my word of advice to any tyrant would be to avoid this title and this role, and to transform tyranny into kingship if possible. And it is possible, as Lycurgus²¹, that wise and good man, has proved in practice. As a remedy, he introduced the authority of the Elders and of the Ephors as a bond to preserve the kingship. As a result, he brought security and fame to his own people, because for those people the rule of law became king, and people did not exercise tyrannical power over the laws.

ὀρθότατα φιλέλλην ἂν λεχθείη ὃ δέ μοι φαίνεται πῃ τὰ νῦν, ἐγὼ πειράσομαι πάσῃ παρρησίᾳ καὶ κοινῷ τινι δικαίῳ λόγῳ χρώμενος δηλοῦν. λέγω γὰρ δὴ διαιτητοῦ τινα τρόπον διαλεγόμενος ὥς δυοῖν, τυραννεύσαντί τε καὶ τυραννευθέντι, ὥς ἐνὶ ἑκατέρῳ παλαιὰν ἐμὴν συμβουλήν· καὶ νῦν δὲ ὃ γ' ἐμὸς λόγος ἂν εἴη σύμβουλος τυράννῳ παντὶ φεύγειν μὲν τοῦνομά τε καὶ τοῦργον τοῦτο, εἰς βασιλείαν δέ, εἰ δυνατόν εἴη, μεταβαλεῖν. δυνατόν δέ, ὥς ἔδειξεν ἔργῳ σοφὸς ἀνὴρ καὶ ἀγαθὸς Λυκοῦργος, ὃς ἰδὼν τὸ τῶν οἰκείων γένος ἐν Ἄργει καὶ Μεσσήνῃ ἐκ βασιλέων εἰς τυράννων δύναμιν ἀφικομένους καὶ διαφθείραντας ἑαυτοὺς τε καὶ τὴν πόλιν ἑκατέρους ἑκατέραν, δείσας περὶ τῆς αὐτοῦ πόλεως ἅμα καὶ γένους, φάρμακον ἐπήνεγκεν τὴν τῶν γερόντων ἀρχὴν καὶ τὸν τῶν ἐφόρων δεσμὸν τῆς βασιλικῆς ἀρχῆς σωτήριον, ὥστε γενεὰς τοσαύτας ἤδη μετ' εὐκλείας σῶζεσθαι, νόμος

354c

These are my words of exhortation to you all now. Those who are intent upon tyrannical power should turn back from what mindless folk crave so greedily and count as happiness. I would advise those who are pursuing the ways of freedom to be careful never to fall foul of the disease of their forefathers, a greedy and immoderate freedom. For before Dionysius and Hipparinus came to power, the Sicilians of that age thought they were living a happy life and even stoned to death the ten generals who preceded Dionysius, so that they would be slaves to

none, subject neither to justice nor law, entirely free in every respect. Consequently, they got the tyrants, for slavery and freedom in excess are in both cases utterly evil, whereas in due measure they are entirely good.

ἐπειδὴ κύριος ἐγένετο βασιλεὺς τῶν ἀνθρώπων, ἀλλ' οὐκ ἄνθρωποι τύραννοι νόμων. ὃ δὴ καὶ νῦν οὐμὸς λόγος πᾶσιν παρακελεύεται, τοῖς μὲν τυραννίδος ἐφιεμένοις ἀποτρέπεσθαι καὶ φεύγειν φυγῇ ἀπλήστως πεινῶντων εὐδαιμόνισμα ἀνθρώπων καὶ ἀνοήτων, εἰς βασιλέως δ' εἶδος πειρᾶσθαι μεταβάλλειν καὶ δουλεῦσαι νόμοις βασιλικοῖς, τὰς μεγίστας τιμὰς κεκτημένους παρ' ἐκόντων τε ἀνθρώπων καὶ τῶν νόμων· τοῖς δὲ δὴ ἐλεύθερα διώκουσιν ἥθη καὶ φεύγουσιν τὸν δούλειον ζυγὸν ὡς ὃν κακόν, εὐλαβεῖσθαι συμβουλεύοιμ' ἂν μὴ ποτε ἀπληστία ἐλευθερίας ἀκαίρου τινὸς εἰς τὸ τῶν προγόνων νόσημα ἐμπέσωσιν, ὃ διὰ τὴν ἄγαν ἀναρχίαν οἱ τότε ἔπαθον, ἀμέτρῳ ἐλευθερίας χρώμενοι ἔρωτι. οἱ γὰρ πρὸ Διονυσίου καὶ Ἰππαρίνου ἀρξάντων Σικελιῶται τότε ὡς ᾤοντο εὐδαιμόνως ἔζων, τρυφῶντές τε καὶ ἅμα ἀρχόντων ἄρχοντες· οἱ καὶ τοὺς δέκα στρατηγοὺς κατέλευσαν βάλλοντες τοὺς πρὸ Διονυσίου, κατὰ νόμον οὐδένα κρίναντες, ἵνα δὴ δουλεύοιεν μηδενὶ μήτε σὺν δίκῃ μήτε νόμῳ δεσπότη, ἐλεύθεροι δ' εἶεν πάντῃ πάντως· ὅθεν αἱ τυραννίδες ἐγένοντο αὐτοῖς. δουλεία γὰρ καὶ ἐλευθερία ὑπερβάλλουσα μὲν ἑκατέρα πάγκακον, ἕμμετρος δὲ οὕσα πανάγαθον· μετρία δὲ ἡ θεῶ δουλεία, ἄμετρος δὲ ἡ τοῖς ἀνθρώποις· θεὸς δὲ ἀνθρώποις σώφροσιν νόμος, ἄφροσιν δὲ ἡδονή. τούτων δὴ ταύτῃ πεφυκότων, ἃ συμβουλεύει Συρακοσίοις πᾶσιν φράζειν παρακελεύομαι τοῖς Δίωνος φίλοις ἐκείνου καὶ ἐμὴν κοινὴν συμβουλὴν· ἐγὼ δὲ ἐρμηνεύσω ἂν ἐκεῖνος ἔμπνους ὢν καὶ δυνάμενος εἶπεν νῦν πρὸς ὑμᾶς. τίς οὖν δὴ, τις ἂν εἴποι, λόγον ἀποφαίνεται ἡμῖν περὶ τῶν νῦν παρόντων ἢ Δίωνος συμβουλῇ; τόνδε. δέξασθε, ὦ Συρακοσίοι, πάντων πρῶτον νόμους οἵτινες

355b

Since this is the natural state of affairs, I call upon the friends of Dion to pass on to all Syracusans the advice I have given, advice common to myself and Dion. And I shall put into words what he would have said to

you were he alive and able to speak. The answer is as follows: “O Syracusans, accept, first of all, such laws as would obviously not turn your thoughts and desires towards moneymaking and wealth. Rather, since there are these three things, soul, body and wealth, assign the greatest honour to the excellence of the soul, second greatest to that of the body, and assign the third and last place of honour to wealth, the servant of body and soul. If you come to experience what is now being said about the laws, you will know in practice that my exhortations are true.”

ἂν ὑμῖν φαίνωνται μὴ πρὸς χρηματισμὸν καὶ πλοῦτον τρέψοντες τὰς γνώμας ὑμῶν μετ’ ἐπιθυμίας, ἀλλ’ ὄντων τριῶν, ψυχῆς καὶ σώματος ἔτι δὲ χρημάτων, τὴν τῆς ψυχῆς ἀρετὴν ἐντιμοτάτην ποιοῦντες, δευτέραν δὲ τὴν τοῦ σώματος, ὑπὸ τῇ τῆς ψυχῆς κειμένην, τρίτην δὲ καὶ ὑστάτην τὴν τῶν χρημάτων τιμὴν, δουλεύουσιν τῷ σώματι τε καὶ ψυχῇ. καὶ ὁ μὲν ταῦτα ἀπεργαζόμενος θεσμὸς νόμος ἂν ὀρθῶς ὑμῖν εἴη κείμενος, ὄντως εὐδαίμονας ἀποτελῶν τοὺς χρωμένους· ὁ δὲ τοὺς πλουσίους εὐδαίμονας ὀνομάζων λόγος αὐτός τε ἄθλιος, γυναικῶν καὶ παίδων ὧν λόγος ἄνους, τοὺς πειθομένους τε ἀπεργάζεται τοιοῦτους. ὅτι δ’ ἀληθῆ ταῦτ’ ἐγὼ παρακελεύομαι, ἐὰν γεύσησθε τῶν νῦν λεγομένων περὶ νόμων, ἔργῳ γνώσεσθε· ἢ δὴ βάσανος ἀληθεστάτη δοκεῖ γίγνεσθαι τῶν πάντων πέρι. δεξάμενοι δὲ τοὺς τοιοῦτους νόμους,

355d

“Accepting such laws as these, since Sicily is in a precarious situation and your side is neither sufficiently dominant nor entirely defeated, it would surely be just and advantageous for you all to adopt a middle course. These are people whose forefathers once performed the great feat of saving the Greeks from the non-Greeks, so that today we are allowed to have this discussion about political systems. So now, let one side have their freedom along with kingly rule, while the other has responsible kingly rule where the laws are master of the citizens in general, and of the kings themselves, in case they do anything contrary to the law.”

ἐπειδὴ κατέχει κίνδυνος Σικελίαν, καὶ οὔτε κρατεῖτε ἱκανῶς οὔτ' αὖ διαφερόντως κρατεῖσθε, δίκαιον ἂν ἴσως καὶ συμφέρον γίγνοιτο ὑμῖν πᾶσιν μέσον τεμεῖν, τοῖς τε φεύγουσιν τῆς ἀρχῆς τὴν χαλεπότητα ὑμῖν καὶ τοῖς τῆς ἀρχῆς πάλιν ἐρώσιν τυχεῖν, ὧν οἱ πρόγονοι τότε, τὸ μέγιστον, ἔσωσαν ἀπὸ βαρβάρων τοὺς Ἑλληνας, ὥστ' ἐξεῖναι περὶ πολιτείας νῦν ποιεῖσθαι λόγους· ἔρρουσι δὲ τότε οὔτε λόγος οὔτ' ἐλπίς ἐλείπετ' ἂν οὐδαμῇ οὐδαμῶς. νῦν οὖν τοῖς μὲν ἐλευθερία

355e

“Under all these conditions, honest and sound in your thinking, with the help of the gods you should appoint three kings: my own son being the first because of a twofold debt of gratitude you owe, firstly to my father who in former times freed the city from the non-Greeks, and secondly to myself, who, of late, twice delivered you from the tyrants; then, as a second king, because of his present assistance and because of the piety of his character, appoint the man who is the son of Dionysius and bears the same name as my father, who, despite having a tyrant as a father, is of his own free will in the process of liberating the city; the third person whom you should call upon to become king is the man who is now leading the army of your adversaries, Dionysius the son of Dionysius, provided he is prepared, voluntarily, to transform himself into the shape of a king out of fear of misfortune, or out of pity for his fatherland.”

γινέσθω μετὰ βασιλικῆς ἀρχῆς, τοῖς δὲ ἀρχὴ ὑπεύθυνος βασιλική, δεσποζόντων νόμων τῶν τε ἄλλων πολιτῶν καὶ τῶν βασιλέων αὐτῶν, ἂν τι παράνομον πράττωσιν· ἐπὶ δὲ τούτοις σύμπασιν ἀδόλῳ γνώμη καὶ ὑγιεῖ μετὰ θεῶν βασιλέα στήσασθε, πρῶτον μὲν τὸν ἐμὸν ὕδὸν χαρίτων ἔνεκα διττῶν, τῆς τε παρ' ἐμοῦ καὶ τῆς παρὰ τοῦ ἐμοῦ πατρός—ὁ μὲν γὰρ ἀπὸ βαρβάρων ἠλευθέρωσεν ἐν τῷ τότε χρόνῳ τὴν πόλιν, ἐγὼ δὲ ἀπὸ τυράννων νῦν δῖς, ὧν αὐτοὶ μάρτυρες ὑμεῖς γεγόνατε—δεύτερον δὲ δὴ ποιεῖσθε βασιλέα τὸν τῷ μὲν ἐμῷ πατρὶ ταῦτὸν κεκτημένον ὄνομα, ὕδὸν δὲ Διονυσίου, χάριν τῆς τε δὴ νῦν βοηθείας καὶ ὁσίου τρόπου· ὃς γενόμενος τυράννου πατὴρ ἐκὼν τὴν πόλιν ἐλευθεροῖ, τιμὴν αὐτῷ καὶ γένει ἀείζων ἀντὶ τυραννίδος ἐφημέρου καὶ ἀδίκου

κτώμενος, τρίτον δὲ προκαλεῖσθαι χρὴ βασιλέα γίγνεσθαι Συρακουσῶν, ἐκόντα ἐκούσης τῆς πόλεως, τὸν νῦν τοῦ τῶν πολεμίων ἄρχοντα στρατοπέδου, Διονύσιον τὸν Διονυσίου, ἐὰν ἐθέλῃ ἐκὼν εἰς βασιλέως σχῆμα ἀπαλλάττεσθαι, δεδιὼς μὲν τὰς τύχας, ἐλεῶν δὲ πατρίδα καὶ ἱερῶν ἀθεραπευσίαν καὶ τάφους, μὴ διὰ φιλονικίαν πάντως πάντα ἀπολέσῃ βαρβάροις ἐπίχαρτος γενόμενος. τρεῖς δ' ὄντας βασιλέας, εἴτ' οὖν τὴν Λακωνικὴν δύναμιν αὐτοῖς δόντες εἴτε ἀφελόντες καὶ συνομολογησάμενοι, καταστήσασθε τρόπῳ τινὶ τοιῷδε,

356c

“This is what I had in mind for you while I was alive, and still have now. Having defeated our enemies at the time with your assistance, I would have established the political system in the way I had in mind had not alien demonic forces prevented me. After this, had events unfolded as I intended, I would have recolonised the rest of Sicily by depriving the non-Greeks of the territory they now hold. And I now advise all of you together to hold these same precepts, act upon them, exhort everyone to this course of action, and regard anyone who refuses as a common enemy.” But having given honours, accompanied by prayers, to all the gods, never desist from gently persuading and exhorting friends and foes in any way you can, until the words we are now speaking shall, like a divine dream presented to waking eyes, be worked out in clear, full and happy completion by yourselves.

ὃς εἴρηται μὲν καὶ πρότερον ὑμῖν, ὅμως δ' ἔτι καὶ νῦν ἀκούετε. ἐὰν ἐθέλῃ τὸ γένος ὑμῖν τὸ Διονυσίου τε καὶ Ἰππαρίνου ἐπὶ σωτηρίᾳ Σικελίας παύσασθαι τῶν νῦν παρόντων κακῶν, τιμὰς αὐτοῖς καὶ γένει λαβόντες εἰς τε τὸν ἔπειτα καὶ τὸν νῦν χρόνον, ἐπὶ τούτοις καλεῖτε, ὥσπερ καὶ πρότερον ἐρρήθη, πρέσβεις οὓς ἂν ἐθελήσωσιν κυρίους ποιησάμενοι τῶν διαλλαγῶν—εἴτε τινὰς αὐτόθεν εἴτε ἔξωθεν εἴτε ἀμφοτέρα—καὶ ὁπόσους ἂν συγχωρήσωσιν· τούτους δ' ἐλθόντας νόμους μὲν πρῶτον θεῖναι καὶ πολιτείαν τοιαύτην, ἐν ἣ βασιλέας ἀρμόττει γίγνεσθαι κυρίους ἱερῶν τε καὶ ὅσων ἄλλων πρέπει τοῖς γενομένοις ποτὲ εὐεργέταις, πολέμου δὲ καὶ εἰρήνης ἄρχοντας νομοφύλακας ποιήσασθαι ἀριθμὸν τριάκοντα καὶ πέντε μετὰ τε δήμου

καὶ βουλῆς. δικαστήρια δὲ ἄλλα μὲν ἄλλων, θανάτου δὲ καὶ φυγῆς τούς τε πέντε καὶ τριάκοντα ὑπάρχειν· πρὸς τούτοις τε ἐκλεκτοὺς γίγνεσθαι δικαστὰς ἐκ τῶν νῦν αἰεὶ περυσινῶν ἀρχόντων, ἓνα ἅφ' ἐκάστης τῆς ἀρχῆς τὸν ἄριστον δόξαντ' εἶναι καὶ δικαιοτάτον· τούτους δὲ τὸν ἐπιόντα ἐνιαυτὸν δικάζειν ὅσα θανάτου καὶ δεσμοῦ καὶ μεταστάσεως τῶν πολιτῶν· βασιλέα δὲ τῶν τοιούτων δικῶν μὴ ἐξεῖναι δικαστὴν γίγνεσθαι, καθάπερ ἱερέα φόνου καθαρεύοντα καὶ δεσμοῦ καὶ φυγῆς. ταῦθ' ὑμῖν ἐγὼ καὶ ζῶν διενόηθην γίγνεσθαι καὶ νῦν διανοοῦμαι, καὶ τότε κρατήσας τῶν ἐχθρῶν μεθ' ὑμῶν, εἰ μὴ ξενικαὶ ἐρινύες ἐκώλυσαν, κατέστησα ἂν ἥπερ καὶ διενοοῦμην, καὶ μετὰ ταῦτα Σικελίαν ἂν τὴν ἄλλην, εἴπερ ἔργα ἐπὶ νῶ ἐγίγνετο, κατῴκισα, τοὺς μὲν βαρβάρους ἦν νῦν ἔχουσιν ἀφελόμενος, ὅσοι μὴ ὑπὲρ τῆς κοινῆς ἐλευθερίας διεπολέμησαν πρὸς τὴν τυραννίδα, τοὺς δ' ἔμπροσθεν οἰκητὰς τῶν Ἑλληνικῶν τόπων εἰς τὰς ἀρχαίας καὶ πατρῶας οἰκήσεις κατοικίσας· ταῦτ' αὖτε καὶ νῦν πᾶσιν συμβουλευώ κοινῇ διανοηθῆναι καὶ πράττειν τε καὶ παρακαλεῖν ἐπὶ ταύτας τὰς πράξεις πάντας, τὸν μὴ θέλοντα δὲ πολέμιον ἡγεῖσθαι κοινῇ. ἔστιν δὲ ταῦτα οὐκ ἀδύνατα· ἃ γὰρ ἐν δυοῖν τε ὄντα ψυχαῖν τυγχάνει καὶ λογισαμένοις εὐρεῖν βέλτιστα ἐτοίμως ἔχει, ταῦτα δὲ σχεδὸν ὁ κρίνων ἀδύνατα οὐκ εὖ φρονεῖ. λέγω δὲ τὰς δύο τήν τε Ἰππαρίνου τοῦ Διονυσίου υἱός καὶ τὴν τοῦ ἐμοῦ υἱός· τούτοις γὰρ συνομολογησάντοιν τοῖς γε ἄλλοις Συρακουσίοις οἶμαι πᾶσιν ὅσοι περ τῆς πόλεως κήδονται συνδοκεῖν. ἀλλὰ θεοῖς τε πᾶσιν τιμὰς μετ' εὐχῶν δόντες, τοῖς τε ἄλλοις ὅσοις μετὰ θεῶν πρέπει, πείθοντες καὶ προκαλούμενοι φίλους καὶ διαφόρους μαλακῶς τε καὶ πάντως μὴ ἀποστήτε, πρὶν ἂν τὰ νῦν ὑφ' ἡμῶν λεχθέντα, οἷον ὀνείρατα θεῶα ἐπιστάντα ἐγγηγορόσιν, ἐναργῆ τε ἐξεργάσησθε τελεσθέντα καὶ εὐτυχῇ. Πλάτων Ἀρχύτα Ταραντίνῳ εὖ πράττειν· ἀφίκοντο πρὸς ἡμᾶς οἱ περὶ Ἀρχιππον καὶ Φιλωνίδην,

357e

EH: NINTH EPISTLE Plato to Archytas of Tarentum: may you do well

357e

Archippus and Philonides and their associates have arrived, bringing us the letter you gave them and reporting the news from yourself.

They concluded their dealings with the city quite easily, since these were not particularly troublesome. They then told us your news and explained that you are losing patience over your inability to get free of the busyness of public affairs. Now, it is more or less obvious to everyone that the greatest pleasure in life consists in attending to your own affairs, especially if someone chooses to deal with the sort of affairs you deal with. But you should also ponder the fact that none of us has been born for ourselves alone. Rather, our fatherland confers part of what we become, our parents another part, our remaining loved ones another, and much comes from the circumstances that overtake us in life. And when our fatherland itself summons us to public affairs, it would surely be improper to disobey. So much for these matters. We are now looking after Echecrates, and will continue to do so hereafter for your sake, for the sake of his father, Phrynion, and for the sake of the young man himself.

τὴν τε ἐπιστολὴν φέροντες ἦν σὺ αὐτοῖς ἔδωκας, καὶ ἀπαγγέλλοντες τὰ παρὰ σοῦ. τὰ μὲν οὖν πρὸς τὴν πόλιν οὐ χαλεπῶς διεπράξαντο—καὶ γὰρ οὐδὲ παντελῶς ἦν ἐργώδη—τὰ δὲ παρὰ σοῦ διήλθον ἡμῖν, λέγοντες ὑποδυσφορεῖν σε ὅτι οὐ δύνασαι τῆς περὶ τὰ κοινὰ ἀσχολίας ἀπολυθῆναι. ὅτι μὲν οὖν ἡδιστόν ἐστιν ἐν τῷ βίῳ τὸ τὰ αὐτοῦ πράττειν, ἄλλως τε καὶ εἴ τις ἔλοιτο τοιαῦτα πράττειν οἷα καὶ σύ, σχεδὸν παντὶ δήλον· ἀλλὰ κάκεῖνο δεῖ σε ἐνθυμεῖσθαι, ὅτι ἕκαστος ἡμῶν οὐχ αὐτῷ μόνον γέγονεν, ἀλλὰ τῆς γενέσεως ἡμῶν τὸ μὲν τι ἢ πατρίς μερίζεται, τὸ δέ τι οἱ γεννήσαντες, τὸ δὲ οἱ λοιποὶ φίλοι, πολλὰ δὲ καὶ τοῖς καιροῖς δίδονται τοῖς τὸν βίον ἡμῶν καταλαμβάνουσι. καλούσης δὲ τῆς πατρίδος αὐτῆς πρὸς τὰ κοινὰ, ἄτοπον ἴσως τὸ μὴ ὑπακούειν· ἅμα γὰρ συμβαίνει καὶ χώραν καταλιμπάνειν φαύλοις ἀνθρώποις, οἳ οὐκ ἀπὸ τοῦ βελτίστου πρὸς τὰ κοινὰ προσέρχονται. περὶ τούτων μὲν οὖν ἱκανῶς, Ἐχεκράτους δὲ καὶ νῦν ἐπιμέλειαν ἔχομεν καὶ εἰς τὸν λοιπὸν χρόνον ἔχομεν καὶ διὰ σέ καὶ διὰ τὸν πατέρα αὐτοῦ Φρυνίωνα καὶ δι’ αὐτὸν τὸν νεανίσκον.

358c

EH: TENTH EPISTLE Plato to Aristodorus: may you do well

358c

I hear that you are one of Dion's most faithful companions at present, and have been so throughout, which is the wisest characteristic of those who apply themselves to philosophy. For I maintain that true philosophy is steadfastness, loyalty and honesty, while other forms of wisdom and cleverness, tending as they do in other directions, are what I refer to, correctly I believe, as platitudes. So, remain strong and continue in the qualities in which you are now abiding.

Πλάτων Ἀριστοδῶρῳ εὖ πράττειν. ἀκούω Δίωνος ἐν τοῖς μάλιστα ἐταῖρον εἶναί τέ σε νῦν καὶ γεγονέναι διὰ παντός, τὸ σοφώτατον ἦθος τῶν εἰς φιλοσοφίαν παρεχόμενον· τὸ γὰρ βέβαιον καὶ πιστὸν καὶ ὑγιές, τοῦτο ἐγὼ φημι εἶναι τὴν ἀληθινὴν φιλοσοφίαν, τὰς δὲ ἄλλας τε καὶ εἰς ἄλλα τεινούσας σοφίας τε καὶ δεινότητος κομψότητας οἶμαι προσαγορεύων ὀρθῶς ὀνομάζειν. ἀλλ' ἔρρωσό τε καὶ μένε ἐν τοῖς ἡθεσιν οἷσπερ καὶ νῦν μένεις.

358d

EH: ELEVENTH EPISTLE Plato to Laodamas: may you do well

358d

I wrote to you previously that it is most important for all the matters you speak of, that you yourself come to Athens. But since you maintain that this is impossible, the second best course, as you said in your letter, is that myself or young Socrates come to you, if possible. At the moment though, Socrates is sick with strangury, and it would be unseemly for me to go there and not accomplish what you asked of me. Besides, at my age I am not physically up to the task of travelling and running the sort of risks that are encountered by land and by sea. I can, however, give advice to yourself and the colonists, which may, to quote Hesiod, "sound commonplace, while being hard to understand." Now, they are mistaken in their thinking if they believe that it is ever possible for a political system to be well established by instituting laws of any sort without there being some authority looking after the day-to-day life of the city to ensure that it is both sound-minded and vigorous in the case of slaves and free alike. Until then you should set

your hearts on these outcomes, keep in mind what I am saying about them, and don't be so foolish as to think you will definitely accomplish anything. May good fortune be yours.

Πλάτων Λαοδάμαντι εὖ πράττειν. ἐπέστειλα μὲν σοι καὶ πρότερον ὅτι πολὺ διαφέρει πρὸς ἅπαντα ἃ λέγεις αὐτὸν ἀφικέσθαι σε Ἀθήναζε· ἐπειδὴ δὲ σὺ φῆς ἀδύνατον εἶναι, μετὰ τοῦτο ἦν δεύτερον, εἰ δυνατόν ἐμὲ ἀφικέσθαι ἢ Σωκράτη, ὥσπερ ἐπέστειλας. νῦν δὲ Σωκράτης μὲν ἐστίν περὶ ἀσθένειαν τὴν τῆς στραγγουρίας, ἐμὲ δὲ ἀφικόμενον ἐνταῦθα ἄσχημον ἂν εἴη μὴ διαπράξασθαι ἐφ' ἅπερ σὺ παρακαλεῖς. ἐγὼ δὲ ταῦτα γενέσθαι ἂν οὐ πολλὴν ἐλπίδα ἔχω—δι' ἃ δέ, μακρὰς ἐτέρας δέοιτ' ἂν ἐπιστολῆς ἥτις πάντα διεξίωι—καὶ ἅμα οὐδὲ τῷ σώματι διὰ τὴν ἡλικίαν ἱκανῶς ἔχω πλανᾶσθαι καὶ κινδυνεύειν κατὰ τε γῆν καὶ κατὰ θάλατταν οἷα ἀπαντᾷ, καὶ νῦν πάντα κινδύνων ἐν ταῖς πορείαις ἐστὶ μεστά. συμβουλευσάι μέντοι ἔχω σοί τε καὶ τοῖς οἰκισταῖς, ὃ εἰπόντος μὲν ἐμοῦ, φησὶν Ἡσίοδος, δόξαι ἂν εἶναι φαῦλον, χαλεπὸν δὲ νοῆσαι. εἰ γὰρ οἷόν τε ὑπὸ νόμων θέσεως καὶ ὧντινων εὖ ποτε πολιτείαν κατασκευασθῆναι ἄνευ τοῦ εἶναί τι κύριον ἐπιμελούμενον ἐν τῇ πόλει τῆς καθ' ἡμέραν διαίτης, ὅπως ἂν ἡ σὴν σὴν τε καὶ ἀνδρική δούλων τε καὶ ἐλευθέρων, οὐκ ὀρθῶς διανοοῦνται. τοῦτο δ' αὖ, εἰ μὲν εἰσὶν ἤδη ἄνδρες ἄξιοι τῆς ἀρχῆς ταύτης, γένοιτ' ἂν· εἰ δ' ἐπὶ τὸ παιδεῦσαι δεῖ τις, οὔτε ὁ παιδεύσων οὔτε οἱ παιδευθησόμενοι, ὥς ἐγὼ οἶμαι, εἰσὶν ὑμῖν, ἀλλὰ τὸ λοιπὸν τοῖς θεοῖς εὐχεσθε. καὶ γὰρ σχεδὸν τι καὶ αἱ ἔμπροσθεν πόλεις οὕτω κατεσκευάσθησαν, καὶ ἔπειτα εὖ ὥκησαν, ὑπὸ συμβάσεων πραγμάτων μεγάλων καὶ κατὰ πόλεμον καὶ κατὰ τὰς ἄλλας πράξεις γενομένων, ὅταν ἐν τοιούτοις καιροῖς ἀνὴρ καλὸς τε καὶ ἀγαθὸς ἐγγένηται μεγάλῃν δύναμιν ἔχων· τὸ δ' ἔμπροσθεν αὐτὰ προθυμεῖσθαι μὲν χρὴ καὶ ἀνάγκη, διανοεῖσθαι μέντοι αὐτὰ οἷα λέγω, καὶ μὴ ἀνοηταίνειν οἰομένους τι ἐτοίμως διαπράξασθαι. εὐτύχει. Πλάτων Ἀρχύτῃ Ταραντίνῳ εὖ πράττειν. τὰ μὲν παρὰ σοῦ ἐλθόνθ' ὑπομνήματα θαυμαστῶς ὥς

359d

EH: TWELFTH EPISTLE Plato to Archytas of Tarentum: may you do well

359d

We received the treatises that came from you with wondrous delight, and we had particular admiration for the man who wrote them, whom we deemed worthy of those ancient ancestors of his. In fact, your people were said to have been Myrions who were among the Trojans who left during the reign of Laomedon, good men as the traditional story declares. As for my own treatises about which you wrote, they are not yet fully complete, but I have sent them to you in their present state. And since we both agree that they are to be kept safe, there is no need for me to make that request.

ἄσμενοί τε ἐλάβομεν καὶ τοῦ γράψαντος αὐτὰ ἠγάσθημεν ὥς ἐνι μάλιστα, καὶ ἔδοξεν ἡμῖν εἶναι ὁ ἀνὴρ ἄξιος ἐκείνων τῶν πάλαι προγόνων· λέγονται γὰρ δὴ οἱ ἄνδρες οὗτοι Μύριοι εἶναι—οὗτοι δ' ἦσαν τῶν ἐπὶ Λαομέδοντος ἐξαναστάντων Τρώων—ἄνδρες ἀγαθοί, ὥς ὁ παραδεδομένος μῦθος δηλοῖ. τὰ δὲ παρ' ἐμοὶ ὑπομνήματα, περὶ ὧν ἐπέστειλας, ἱκανῶς μὲν οὐπω ἔχει, ὥς δέ ποτε τυγχάνει ἔχοντα, ἀπέσταλκά σοι· περὶ δὲ τῆς φυλακῆς ἀμφοτέροι συμφωνοῦμεν, ὥστ' οὐδὲν δεῖ παρακελεύεσθαι. ἀντιλέγεται ὥς οὐ Πλάτωνος.'

360a

EH: THIRTEENTH EPISTLE Plato to Dionysius, tyrant of Syracuse: may you do well

360a

[Note: the best manuscripts record that this letter is not by Plato] Let this greeting mark the beginning of my letter, and at the same time be a sign that it is from me. Once, when you were entertaining the Locrian youths and were seated some distance from me, you got up, came over to me, and in a friendly way addressed some admirable words to me, so I thought, and so too did the person beside me, who then said, “Presumably, Dionysius, when it comes to wisdom, Plato here has been of great benefit to you.” And you replied, “And in many other respects too, since from the very moment I issued the invitation, because of the fact that I sent for him, I derived immediate benefit.” Now, this is the spirit we must preserve so that our mutual benefit from one another may continually increase, and to bring this about I

am now sending you some Pythagorean writings, and some ‘Divisions’, and also a man who could prove useful to yourself and Archytas. The man’s name is Helicon, and his people are from Cyzicus²⁵. He is a student of Eudoxus, and is well versed in everything that man knows. And, unusually for such people, he is not devoid of social charm, nor it seems is he of bad character; rather, on the contrary, he seems to have a light touch and to be of good character.

Πλάτων Διονυσίῳ τυράννῳ Συρακουσῶν εὖ πράττειν. ἀρχή σοι τῆς ἐπιστολῆς ἔστω καὶ ἅμα σύμβολον ὅτι παρ’ ἐμοῦ ἐστίν· τοὺς Λοκρούς ποθ’ ἐστιῶν νεανίσκους, πόρρω κατακείμενος ἀπ’ ἐμοῦ, ἀνέστης παρ’ ἐμὲ καὶ φιλοφρονούμενος εἶπες εὖ τι ῥῆμα ἔχον, ὡς ἔμοιγε ἐδόκεις καὶ τῷ παρακατακειμένῳ—ἦν δ’ οὗτος τῶν καλῶν τις—ὃς τότε εἶπεν· ἦ που πολλά, ὦ Διονύσιε, εἰς σοφίαν ὠφελῇ ὑπὸ Πλάτωνος· σὺ δ’ εἶπες καὶ εἰς ἄλλα πολλά, ἐπεὶ καὶ ἀπ’ αὐτῆς τῆς μεταπέμψεως, ὅτι μετεπεμψάμην αὐτόν, δι’ αὐτὸ τοῦτο εὐθὺς ὠφελήθην. τοῦτ’ οὖν διασωστέον, ὅπως ἂν αὐξάνηται αἰὲν ἡμῶν ἢ ἀπ’ ἀλλήλων ὠφελία. καὶ ἐγὼ νῦν τοῦτ’ αὐτὸ παρασκευάζων, τῶν τε Πυθαγορείων πέμπω σοι καὶ τῶν διαιρέσεων, καὶ ἄνδρα, ὥσπερ ἐδόκει ἡμῖν τότε, ὃ γὰρ σὺ καὶ Ἀρχύτης, εἶπερ ἤκει παρὰ σε Ἀρχύτης, χρῆσθαι δύναισθ’ ἂν. ἔστι δὲ ὄνομα μὲν Ἑλίκων, τὸ δὲ γένος ἐκ Κυζίκου, μαθητὴς δὲ Εὐδόξου καὶ περὶ πάντα τὰ ἐκείνου πάνυ χαριέντως ἔχων· ἔτι δὲ καὶ τῶν Ἰσοκράτους μαθητῶν τῷ συγγέγονεν καὶ Πολυξένῳ τῶν Βρύσωνός τινι ἐταίρων. ὃ δὲ σπάνιον ἐπὶ τούτοις, οὔτε ἄχαρίς ἐστὶν ἐντυχεῖν οὔτε κακοήθει ἔοικεν, ἀλλὰ μᾶλλον ἐλαφρὸς καὶ εὐήθης δόξειεν ἂν εἶναι. δεδιώς δὲ λέγω ταῦτα, ὅτι ὑπὲρ ἀνθρώπου δόξαν ἀποφαίνομαι, οὐ φαύλου ζῶου ἀλλ’ εὐμεταβόλου, πλὴν πάνυ ὀλίγων τινῶν καὶ εἰς ὀλίγα· ἐπεὶ καὶ περὶ τούτου φοβούμενος καὶ ἀπιστῶν ἐσκόπουν αὐτός τε ἐντυγχάνων καὶ ἐπυνθανόμην τῶν πολιτῶν αὐτοῦ, καὶ οὐδεὶς οὐδὲν φλαῦρον ἔλεγεν τὸν ἄνδρα. σκόπει δὲ καὶ αὐτὸς καὶ εὐλαβοῦ. μάλιστα μὲν οὖν, ἂν καὶ ὁπωστιοῦν σχολάζῃς, μάθανε παρ’ αὐτοῦ καὶ τᾶλλα φιλοσόφει· εἰ δὲ μή, ἐκδίδαξαι τινα, ἵνα κατὰ σχολὴν μανθάνων βελτίων γίγνηται καὶ εὐδόξῃς, ὅπως τὸ δι’ ἐμὲ ὠφελεῖσθαι σοι μὴ ἀνιῇ. καὶ ταῦτα μὲν δὴ ταύτη.

361a

As for the items you wrote to me to send to you, I have had the Apollo made and Leptines is bringing it to you. It is by a good, young craftsman whose name is Leochares. I thought that another work of his was most charming, so I bought it, intending to give it to your wife because she looked after me in sickness and in health in a manner that was worthy of you and me. Please give it to her unless you think otherwise. I am also sending twelve jars of sweet wine for the children, and two jars of honey. We arrived too late to store the figs, and the stored myrtle berries had rotted. We shall look after them better in future. Leptines will tell you about the plants.

περὶ δὲ ὧν ἐπέστελλές μοι ἀποπέμπειν σοι, τὸν μὲν Ἀπόλλω ἐποισάμην τε καὶ ἄγει σοι Λεπτίνης, νέου καὶ ἀγαθοῦ δημιουργοῦ· ὄνομα δ' ἔστιν αὐτῷ Λεωχάρης. ἕτερον δὲ παρ' αὐτῷ ἔργον ἦν πάνυ κομψόν, ὡς ἐδόκει· ἐπριάμην οὖν αὐτὸ βουλόμενός σου τῇ γυναικὶ δοῦναι, ὅτι μου ἐπεμελεῖτο καὶ ὑγιαίνοντος καὶ ἀσθενοῦντος ἀξίως ἐμοῦ τε καὶ σοῦ. δὸς οὖν αὐτῇ, ἂν μὴ τι σοὶ ἄλλο δόξῃ. πέμπω δὲ καὶ οἴνου γλυκέος δώδεκα σταμνία τοῖς παισὶ καὶ μέλιτος δύο. ἰσχάδων δὲ ὕστερον ἤλθομεν τῆς ἀποθέσεως, τὰ δὲ μύρτα ἀποτεθέντα κατεσάπη· ἀλλ' αὖθις βέλτιον ἐπιμελησόμεθα. περὶ δὲ φυτῶν Λεπτίνης σοι ἐρεῖ. ἀργύριον δ' εἰς ταῦτα ἔνεκά τε τούτων καὶ εἰσφορῶν τινῶν εἰς τὴν πόλιν ἔλαβον παρὰ Λεπτίνου, λέγων ἅ μοι ἐδόκει εὐσχημονέστατα ἡμῖν εἶναι καὶ ἀληθῇ λέγειν, ὅτι ἡμέτερον εἴη ὃ εἰς τὴν ναῦν ἀναλώσαμεν τὴν Λευκαδίαν, σχεδὸν ἑκκαίδεκα μναῖ· τοῦτ' οὖν ἔλαβον, καὶ λαβὼν αὐτός

361c

The money for these items, for these and for some taxes due to the city, I obtained from Leptines. Now, my own circumstances are that I have charge of four daughters of the nieces of mine who died on that occasion when you bade me wear a wreath and I would not do so. The eldest is of marriageable age, another is eight years old, another is just over three, and the youngest is not yet one. These must be provided with dowries, by myself and by my friends, for those whom I live to see

married. The eldest is to marry Speusippus⁷. She is the daughter of his sister, and she requires a dowry of no more than thirty minae, which is quite reasonable with us. And furthermore, if my own mother should pass away, no more than ten minae would be required for the construction of her tomb.

τε ἐχρησάμην καὶ ὑμῖν ταῦτα ἀπέπεμψα. τὸ δὴ μετὰ τοῦτο περὶ χρημάτων ἄκουε ὥς σοι ἔχει, περὶ τε τὰ σὰ τὰ Ἀθήνησιν καὶ περὶ τὰ ἐμά. ἐγὼ τοῖς σοῖς χρήμασιν, ὥσπερ τότε σοι ἔλεγον, χρῆσθαι καθάπερ τοῖς τῶν ἄλλων ἐπιτηδείων, χρῶμαι δὲ ὥς ἂν δύνωμαι ὀλιγίστοις, ὅσα ἀναγκαῖα ἢ δίκαια ἢ εὐσχήμονα ἐμοί τε δοκεῖ καὶ παρ' οὗ ἂν λαμβάνω. ἐμοί δὴ τοιοῦτον νῦν συμβέβηκεν. εἰσί μοι ἀδελφιδῶν θυγατέρες τῶν ἀποθανουσῶν τότε ὅτ' ἐγὼ οὐκ ἔστεφανούμην, σὺ δ' ἐκέλευες, τέτταρες, ἡ μὲν νῦν ἐπίγαμος, ἡ δὲ ὀκταέτις, ἡ δὲ σμικρὸν πρὸς τρισὶν ἔτεσιν, ἡ δὲ οὐπω ἐνιαυσία. ταύτας ἐκδοτέον ἐμοί ἐστιν καὶ τοῖς ἐμοῖς ἐπιτηδείοις, αἷς ἂν ἐγὼ ἐπιβιῶ· αἷς δ' ἂν μὴ, χαιρόντων. καὶ ὧν ἂν γένωνται οἱ πατέρες αὐτῶν ἐμοῦ πλουσιώτεροι, οὐκ ἐκδοτέον· τὰ δὲ νῦν αὐτῶν ἐγὼ εὐπορώτατος, καὶ τὰς μητέρας δὲ αὐτῶν ἐγὼ ἐξέδωκα καὶ μετ' ἄλλων καὶ μετὰ Δίωνος. ἡ μὲν οὖν Σπευσίπῳ γαμεῖται, ἀδελφῆς οὕσα αὐτῷ θυγάτηρ. δεῖ δὴ ταύτη οὐδὲν πλέον ἢ τριάκοντα μνῶν· μέτραι γὰρ αὐταὶ ἡμῖν προῖκες, ἔτι δὲ ἕαν ἡ μήτηρ τελευτήσῃ ἡ ἐμή, οὐδὲν αὖ πλείονος ἢ δέκα μνῶν δέοι ἂν εἰς τὴν οἰκοδομίαν τοῦ τάφου. καὶ περὶ ταῦτα τὰ μὲν ἐμὰ ἀναγκαῖα σχεδόν τι ἐν τῷ νῦν ταῦτά ἐστιν· ἕαν δέ τι ἄλλο γίγνηται ἴδιον ἢ δημόσιον ἀνάλωμα διὰ τὴν παρὰ σὲ ἀφίζιν, ὥσπερ τότε ἔλεγον δεῖ ποιεῖν, ἐμὲ μὲν διαμάχεσθαι ὅπως ὥς ὀλίγιστον γένηται τὸ

362a

The next issue I address is the expenditure of your funds at Athens. Firstly, if I am required to incur some expense in funding a chorus or something of that sort, you do not have, as we had hoped, a single friend who will advance you the money. I actually discovered this for myself when I sent Erastus to Andromides of Aegina, from whom you told me to borrow if I needed anything. But Andromides replied, reasonably and understandably, that on a previous occasion, having

expended funds on your father's behalf, he had difficulty in recovering them, so he would now provide a small sum and no more. Those who ever report to you are reluctant to report anything that involves a financial expense, for fear of your displeasure. So you should get them accustomed to this and compel them to speak of these matters and of others too.

ἀνάλωμα, ὃ δ' ἂν μὴ δύνωμαι, σὴν εἶναι τὴν δαπάνην. τὸ δὲ μετὰ ταῦτα λέγω περὶ τῶν σῶν αὖ χρημάτων τῶν Ἀθήνησιν τῆς ἀναλώσεως, ὅτι πρῶτον μὲν ἕαν τι δέῃ ἐμὲ ἀναλίσκειν εἰς χορηγίαν ἢ τι τοιοῦτον, οὐκ ἔστι σοι ξένος οὐδεὶς ὅστις δώσει, ὡς ὥόμεθα, ἔπειτα καὶ ἂν τι σοὶ αὐτῷ διαφέρῃ μέγα, ὥστε ἀναλωθὲν μὲν ἤδη ὀνῆσαι, μὴ ἀναλωθὲν δὲ ἄλλ' ἐγχρονισθὲν ἕως ἂν τις παρὰ σοῦ ἔλθῃ, βλάβῃ, πρὸς τῷ χαλεπῷ τὸ τοιοῦτόν σοί ἐστιν καὶ αἰσχρόν. ἐγὼ γὰρ δὴ ταῦτά γε ἐξήτασα, παρ' Ἀνδρομήδῃ τὸν Αἰγινήτην πέμψας Ἑραστον, παρ' οὗ ἐκέλευες τοῦ ὑμετέρου ξένου, εἴ τι δεοίμην, λαμβάνειν, βουλόμενος καὶ ἄλλα μερίζονα ἃ ἐπέστελλες πέμπειν. ὁ δὲ εἶπεν εἰκότα καὶ ἀνθρώπινα, ὅτι καὶ πρότερον ἀναλώσας τῷ πατρί σου μόλις κομίσαιτο, καὶ νῦν σμικρὰ μὲν δοίῃ ἂν, πλείω δὲ οὐ. οὕτω δὲ παρὰ Λεπτίνου ἔλαβον· καὶ τοῦτό γε ἄξιον ἐπαινέσαι Λεπτίνην, οὐχ ὅτι ἔδωκεν, ἀλλ' ὅτι προθύμως, καὶ τὰ ἄλλα περὶ σέ

362c

I should speak of Dion next. I cannot yet speak to him of the other matters until the letters from you arrive, as promised. But in general, I think Dion is reasonably disposed towards you in word and deed. To Cratinus, the brother of Timotheus, and my friend, let us give an armoured breastplate, one of the softer variety for foot soldiers, and to the daughters of Cebes, three seven-cubit robes of Sicilian linen. You probably recognise Cebes' name since he has been written of in the Socratic dialogues, conversing with Socrates along with Simmias in the dialogue about the soul. The man is a kind friend to us all.

καὶ λέγων καὶ πράττων, ὅτι οἷός τ' ἦν ἐπιτήδειος, φανερός ἦν. χρὴ γὰρ δὴ καὶ τὰ τοιαῦτα καὶ τάναντία τούτων ἐμὲ ἀπαγγέλλειν, ὁποῖός τις ἂν

ἕκαστος ἐμοὶ φαίνεται περὶ σέ. τὸ δ' οὖν περὶ τῶν χρημάτων ἐγὼ σοὶ παρρησιάσομαι· δίκαιον γάρ, καὶ ἅμα ἐμπείρως ἔχων τῶν παρὰ σοὶ λέγοιμ' ἅν. οἱ προσαγγέλλοντες ἐκάστοτέ σοι, ὅτι ἂν οἴωνται ἀνάλωμα εἰσαγγέλλειν, οὐκ ἐθέλουσιν προσαγγέλλειν, ὥς δὴ ἀπεχθισόμενοι· ἔθιζε οὖν αὐτοὺς καὶ ἀνάγκαζε φράζειν καὶ ταῦτα καὶ τὰ ἄλλα· σὲ γὰρ δεῖ εἰδέναι τε τὰ πάντα κατὰ δύναμιν καὶ κριτὴν εἶναι καὶ μὴ φεύγειν τὸ εἰδέναι. πάντων γὰρ ἄριστόν σοι ἔσται πρὸς τὴν ἀρχήν· τὰ γὰρ ἀναλώματα ὀρθῶς ἀναλίσκόμενα καὶ ὀρθῶς ἀποδιδόμενα πρὸς τε τὰλλα καὶ πρὸς αὐτὴν τὴν τῶν χρημάτων κτήσιν καὶ σὺ δὴ φῆς ἀγαθὸν εἶναι καὶ φήσεις, μὴ οὖν σε διαβαλλόντων πρὸς τοὺς ἀνθρώπους οἱ κήδεσθαί σου φάσκοντες· τοῦτο γὰρ οὔτε ἀγαθὸν οὔτε καλὸν πρὸς δόξαν σοι, δοκεῖν δυσσύμβολον

362e

Now, I presume you remember what I said about the sign, indicating which of my letters are written seriously and which are not. A serious letter begins with “God”, a less serious one with “gods.” The ambassadors asked me to write to you with good reason, for they sing your praises and mine with great eagerness everywhere they go. If you are sending the breastplate or anything else I wrote to you about, please give it to Terillus if you don’t have someone whom you yourself prefer. He makes the journey regularly, he is a friend of ours, and he is accomplished in philosophy and other subjects. Farewell, love wisdom, and encourage the rest of the young accordingly. Don’t neglect now the repayment of the money you owe to Leptines. Repay him as soon as possible so that others, seeing this, may be more eager to be of service to us. Iatrocles, whom I set free at the time, along with Myronidus, is now travelling with the items I am sending. Please give him some paid employment as he is well disposed towards you, and use him for whatever you wish, and preserve this letter, either the letter itself or a reminder of its contents, and be the same.

εἶναι. τὰ μετὰ ταῦτα περὶ Δίωνος λέγοιμ' ἅν. τὰ μὲν ἄλλ' οὕτω ἔχω λέγειν, πρὶν ἂν παρὰ σοῦ ἔλθωσιν αἱ ἐπιστολαί, ὥσπερ ἔφης· περὶ μέντοι ἐκείνων ὧν οὐκ εἶας μεμνήσθαι πρὸς αὐτόν, οὔτε ἐμνήσθην

οὔτε διελέχθην, ἐξεπειρώμην δὲ εἴτε χαλεπῶς εἴτε ῥαδίως οἷσι γιγνομένων, καί μοι ἐδόκει οὐκ ἡρέμα ἂν ἄχθεσθαι εἰ γίνοιτο. τὰ δὲ ἄλλα περὶ σέ καὶ λόγῳ καὶ ἔργῳ μέτριός μοι δοκεῖ εἶναι δίων. Κρατίνῳ τῷ Τιμοθέου μὲν ἀδελφῷ, ἐμῷ δ' ἐταίρῳ, θώρακα δωρησώμεθα ὀπλιτικὸν τῶν μαλακῶν τῶν πεζῶν, καὶ ταῖς κέβητος θυγατρᾶσι χιτῶνια τρία ἑπταπῆχη, μὴ τῶν πολυτελῶν τῶν Ἀμοργίνων, ἀλλὰ τῶν Σικελικῶν τῶν λινῶν. ἐπεικῶς δὲ γινώσκεις τοῦνομα κέβητος· γεγραμμένος γάρ ἐστιν ἐν τοῖς Σωκρατείοις λόγοις μετὰ Σιμμίου Σωκράτει διαλεγόμενος ἐν τῷ περὶ ψυχῆς λόγῳ, ἀνὴρ πᾶσιν ἡμῖν οἰκεῖός τε καὶ εὖνους. περὶ δὲ δὴ τοῦ συμβόλου τοῦ περὶ τὰς ἐπιστολάς, ὅσας τε ἂν ἐπιστέλλω σπουδῇ καὶ ὅσας ἂν μὴ, οἶμαι μὲν σε μεμνησθαι, ὅμως δ' ἐννόει καὶ πάνυ πρόσεχε τὸν νοῦν· πολλοὶ γὰρ οἱ κελεύοντες γράφειν, οὓς οὐ ῥάδιον φανερώς διωθεῖσθαι. τῆς μὲν γὰρ σπουδαίας ἐπιστολῆς θεὸς ἄρχει, θεοὶ δὲ τῆς ἡττον.οὶ πρέσβεις καὶ ἐδέοντο ἐπιστέλλειν σοι, καὶ εἰκός· πάνυ γὰρ προθύμως σὲ πανταχοῦ καὶ ἐμὲ ἐγκωμιάζουσιν, καὶ οὐχ ἥκιστα Φίλαγρος, ὃς τότε τὴν χεῖρα ἡσθένει. καὶ φιλαίδης παρὰ βασιλέως ἥκων τοῦ μεγάλου ἔλεγεν περὶ σοῦ· εἰ δὲ μὴ πάνυ μακρᾶς ἐπιστολῆς ἦν, ἔγραψα ἂν ἃ ἔλεγεν, νῦν δὲ Λεπτίνου πυνθάνου. ἂν τὸν θώρακα ἢ ἄλλο τι ὧν ἐπιστέλλω πέμπης, ἂν μὲν αὐτός τῳ βούλῃ, εἰ δὲ μὴ, Τηρίλλῳ δός· ἔστι δὲ τῶν αἰὶ πλεόντων, ἡμέτερος ἐπιτήδειος καὶ τὰ ἄλλα καὶ περὶ φιλοσοφίαν χαρίεις. Τείσωνος δ' ἔστιν κηδεστής, ὃς τότε ὅθ' ἡμεῖς ἀπεπλέομεν ἐπολιανόμενι. ἔρρωσο καὶ φιλοσόφει καὶ τοὺς ἄλλους προτρέπου τοὺς νεωτέρους, καὶ τοὺς συσφαιριστὰς ἀσπάζου ὑπὲρ ἐμοῦ, καὶ πρόστατε τοῖς τε ἄλλοις καὶ Ἀριστοκρίτῳ, ἐάν τις παρ' ἐμοῦ λόγος ἢ ἐπιστολὴ ἴῃ παρὰ σέ, ἐπιμελεῖσθαι ὅπως ὡς τάχιστα σὺ αἰσθῇ, καὶ ὑπομιμνήσκειν σε ἵνα ἐπιμελῇ τῶν ἐπισταλέντων. καὶ νῦν Λεπτίνῃ τῆς ἀποδόσεως τοῦ ἀργυρίου μὴ ἀμελήσης, ἀλλ' ὡς τάχιστα ἀπόδος, ἵνα καὶ οἱ ἄλλοι πρὸς τοῦτον ὀρώντες προθυμότεροι ᾖσιν ἡμῖν ὑπηρετεῖν. Ἰατροκλῆς, ὁ μετὰ Μυρωνίδου τότε ἐλεύθερος ἀφεθείς ὑπ' ἐμοῦ, πλεῖ νῦν μετὰ τῶν πεμπομένων παρ' ἐμοῦ· ἔμμισθον οὖν που αὐτὸν κατάστησον ὡς ὄντα σοι εὖνουν, καὶ ἂν τι βούλῃ, αὐτῷ χρῶ. καὶ τὴν ἐπιστολὴν ἢ αὐτὴν ἢ ὑπόμνημα αὐτῆς σῶζέ τε, καὶ ὁ αὐτὸς ἴσθι.

Notes

¹ Plato's authorship of the Epistles or Letters is doubted in varying degrees and there is a lack of scholarly unanimity as to whether or not any of them are by Plato. The Seventh Epistle is the one that has traditionally been least suspected, though even the authorship of this Epistle is a matter of dispute among scholars.

² Euripides, Fragment 956.

³ Archedemus was a prominent figure in Plato's interactions with Dionysius, and, as such, is a recurring figure in the Epistles. Third Epistle 318e; Seventh Epistle 339a, 349d.

⁴ Hiero I was a Syracusan tyrant; Pausanias was a Spartan general and ruler who defeated the Persian Empire at Plataea. Both were associated with the poet Simonides.

⁵ These are groupings of famous rulers with influential thinkers. Periander was a tyrant in Corinth; Thales was a natural philosopher from Miletus; Pericles was an Athenian general and statesman; Anaxagoras was a philosopher from Clazomenae; Cyrus II was the founder of the Persian (Achaemenid) Empire; Croesus was a king of Lydia, and Solon was an Athenian statesman and legislator.

⁶ Phylition was a physician and thinker from Locri in southern Italy.

⁷ Speusippus was Plato's nephew, who became head of the Academy after Plato's death.

⁸ Perdiccas III was a ruler of Macedon.

⁹ Euphraeus of Oreus was a student of Plato who rose to prominence in Macedon under the rule of Perdiccas III.

¹⁰ Hermias, Erastus and Coriscus were all members of Plato's Academy. Hermias became a tyrant in Atarneus and was the father-in-law of Aristotle. Erastus and Coriscus were brothers from Scepsis. Both Atarneus and Scepsis were in Ionia.

¹¹ Although Plato's authorship of the Seventh Epistle is often doubted, there are scholars who regard it as authentic.

¹² These were the supporters of the democracy. The incident is recounted in Plato's Apology.

¹³ This is Dionysius II, the son of Dionysius I, tyrant of Syracuse, whose death is described just above.

¹⁴ This actually describes Plato's second time in Sicily, but is his first interaction with Dionysius II.

¹⁵ Archytas of Tarentum was a Pythagorean philosopher and mathematician. He was also a prominent statesman in his native city in southern Italy. He was an important associate of Plato and is mentioned in several of Plato's epistles, some of which are addressed to him.

¹⁶ A proverbial expression ('the third to the saviour').

¹⁷ Lynceus journeyed with the Argonauts and served as the lookout for them.

¹⁸ Iliad vii.360.

¹⁹ Odyssey xii.428, Lattimore.

²⁰ The Phoenicians and Opici were two ancient peoples. The former originated in modern-day Lebanon but had established colonies in Sicily. The latter occupied the Campania region in modern-day Italy.

²¹ Lycurgus was a Spartan legislator.

²² This is the young Socrates who appears as an interlocutor with the Eleatic Stranger in Plato's *Statesman*.

²³ This comment about the Thirteenth Epistle comes from the best-attested manuscripts and may go back to Thrasyllus, one of the early editors of Plato's work.

²⁴ The greeting 'may you do well' is intended as an indication of authorship due to its frequent use. Third Epistle 315a-b.

²⁵ Eudoxus of Cnidus was an astronomer and mathematician who had studied with Archytas and Plato. He eventually moved his school from Cyzicus to Athens, and merged it with the Academy.

²⁶ Isocrates was an influential Athenian rhetorician and teacher of rhetoric.

²⁷ Bryson of Heraclea was a mathematician and sophist who is thought to have studied with Socrates. The ancient historian Theopompus claims that Plato had taken many ideas for his dialogues from Bryson.

²⁸ This is a reference to the King of the Persian Empire.